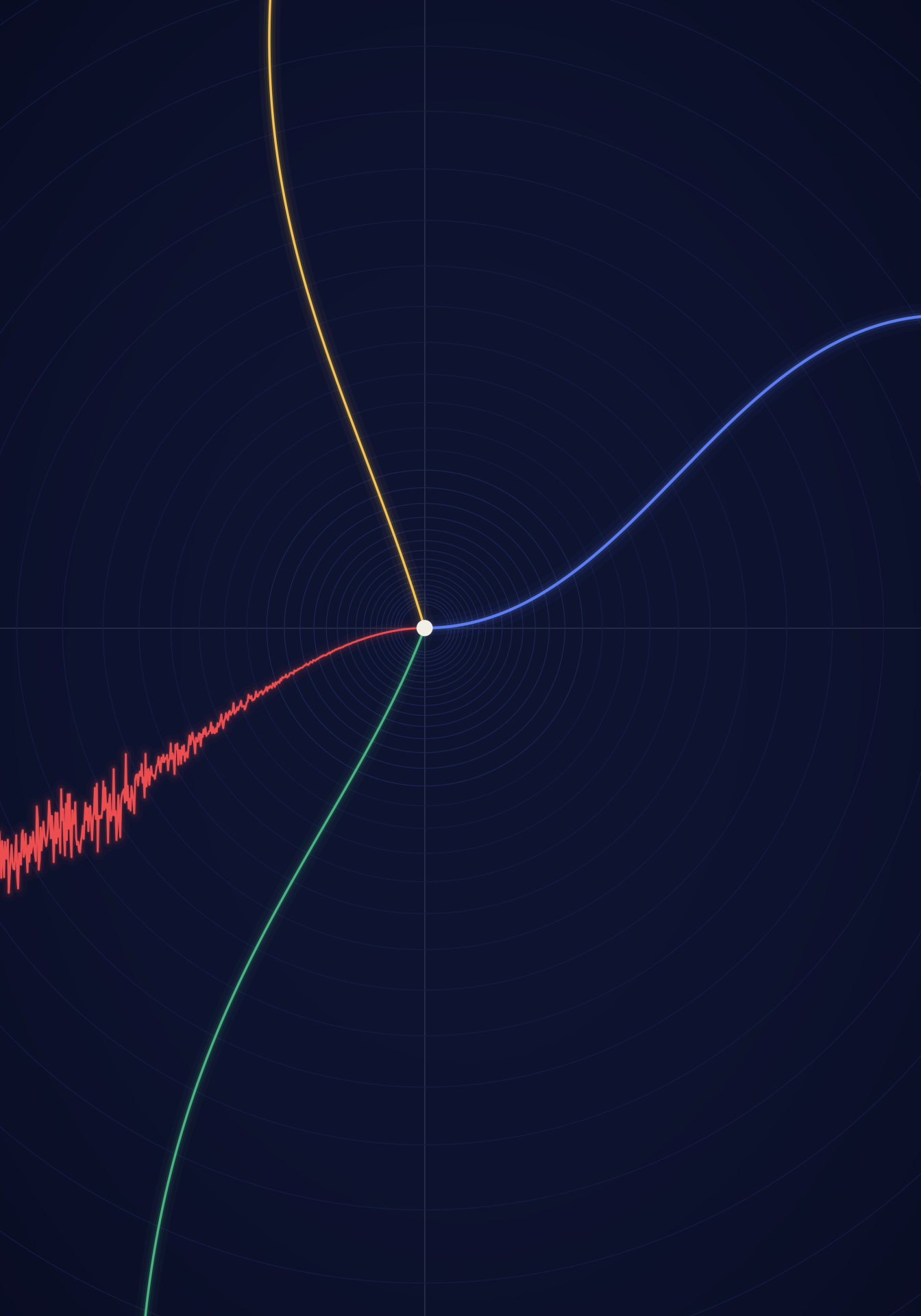
Telephonic Grace



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Gravity, Noise, and the Soteriology of Address in Shigesato Itoi's EarthBound (Mother 2: Gīgu no Gyakushū, 1994)

@ertertwert

Telephonic Grace: Gravity, Noise, and the Soteriology of Address in Shigesato Itoi's EarthBound (Mother 2: Gīgu no Gyakushū, 1994)

@ertertwert
8 November 2026

The text is set in Literata, designed by Veronika Burian and José Scaglione of TypeTogether, across its optical sizes; Japanese is set in Shippori Mincho B1 by FONTDASU.

The four colours that run through the plates and drawings follow the four coordinates of Figure 1.1: green for gravity, gold for grace, red for noise, and blue for address.

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Abstract

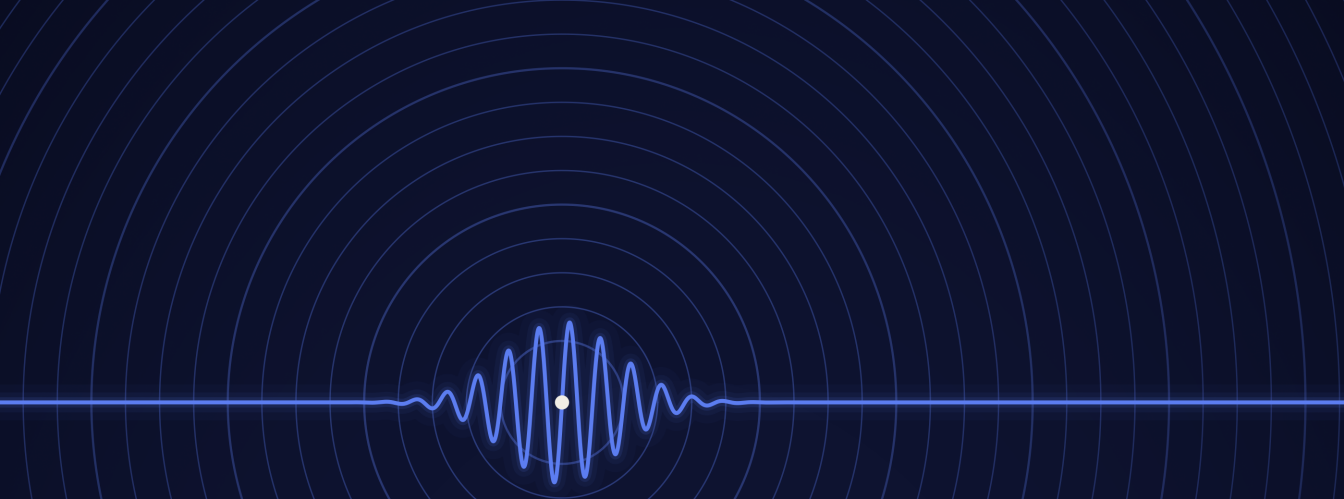
This dissertation advances a systematic philosophical reading of *EarthBound* (*Mother 2: Gīgu no Gyakushū*; Ape Inc. and HAL Laboratory for Nintendo, 1994; North American release 1995), the role-playing game written and directed by the Japanese copywriter, lyricist, and essayist Shigesato Itoi. Against a critical consensus that has treated the work chiefly as affectionate parody—of the *Dragon Quest* formula, of postwar Japan's televisual America, of the role-playing genre's own conventions—it argues that *EarthBound* elaborates a complete and internally coherent metaphysics, legible at the levels of narrative, iconography, sound, and, decisively, procedure. That metaphysics rests on a single proposition: being is constituted by address. To exist, in Itoi's world, is to be called and to be capable of answering; evil is the collapse of addressability; salvation is the restoration of the channel.

The dissertation names this structure *telephonic grace*. The term condenses the game's most persistent figure—the telephone through which an unseen father archives the child's progress, through which a mother cures his homesickness, through which the paternal voice interrupts play to counsel rest—and extends it to the full ensemble of media by which the work transmits grace at a distance: telepathic dream, recorded melody, photograph, parcel, and, finally, prayer. Telephonic grace is articulated along two axes and four coordinates. On the ontological axis, *gravity*—after Simone Weil's *pesanteur*—names the earth-bound condition the English title announces: embodiment, domesticity, appetite, commodity life, and the durational mortality encoded in the game's odometer-style hit points; *grace* names the call that arrives from elsewhere and the psychic powers that figure it. On the communicative axis, *noise* names the antagonist: Giygas, a being rendered not as a sprite but as a corrupted background layer—ground without figure, signal without message, power without thought—read here through Augustine's *privatio boni*, Hannah Arendt's diagnosis of evil as thoughtlessness, Keiji Nishitani's distinction between nihility (*kyomu*) and emptiness (*kū*), Julia Kristeva's ab-

ject, and Michel Serres's parasite. *Address* names the remedy: Paula's prayer, which traverses the noise and, in the game's culminating gesture, reaches the player by name.

Methodologically, the study joins procedural close reading to intellectual history, comparative mythography, psychoanalysis, media archaeology, the philosophy of the Kyoto School, and the phenomenology of prayer. It situates Itoi within the consumer culture of Japan's high-growth and bubble decades—his Seibu campaigns「不思議、大好き。」(1981) and「おいしい生活。」(1982), his lyrics for Kenji Sawada's "TOKIO" (1980), his co-authorship with Haruki Murakami of *Yume de aimashō* (1981), his voice and copy for Studio Ghibli—and argues that *EarthBound* constitutes the copywriter's confession and redemption of his own art. Advertising is the industrial manufacture of address: a vocative "you" offered satisfaction. Itoi's game inverts the vector. Its decisive utterance is not an offer but a supplication; not a slogan aimed at a consumer but a prayer aimed at an absent other who is thereby summoned into being. The dissertation terms this inversion *counter-copy* and contends that its climax enacts Weil's equation of attention with prayer, converting the player's attention—the very commodity the bubble economy had industrialized—into grace.

The argument proceeds through sustained comparison with a transmedial corpus spanning Kenji Miyazawa, Lewis Carroll, L. Frank Baum, Michael Ende, Ray Bradbury, Stephen King, Tove Jansson, Charles M. Schulz, Fujiko F. Fujio, Osamu Tezuka, Katsuhiro Ōtomo, Murakami, David Lynch, Andrei Tarkovsky, Steven Spielberg, and Stanley Kubrick, together with the work's successors, *Mother* 3 (2006) and Toby Fox's *Undertale* (2015). Its philosophical and theological interlocutors range from Zhuangzi, Dōgen, and Isaac of Nineveh to Dostoevsky, Buber, Heidegger, Winnicott, Lacan, Althusser, Jakobson, Barthes, Lyotard, Jean-Louis Chrétien, and John Durham Peters. The dissertation concludes that *EarthBound* proposes a soteriology of address uniquely available to interactive media—one in which the medium's constitutive relation, the call passing between a system and its player, becomes the site of grace—and that this proposal bears directly on contemporary debates concerning attention, mediation, and the ethics of the second person.



「エンディングまで、泣くんじゃない。」

the shape of a call

1

"No Crying Until the Ending"

Object, Method, and the Problem of Address

「エンディングまで、泣くんじゃない。」
"No crying until the ending."
promotional copy for Mother *(Nintendo, 1989)*

La grâce seule fait exception.
Simone Weil, La Pesanteur et la grâce (1947)

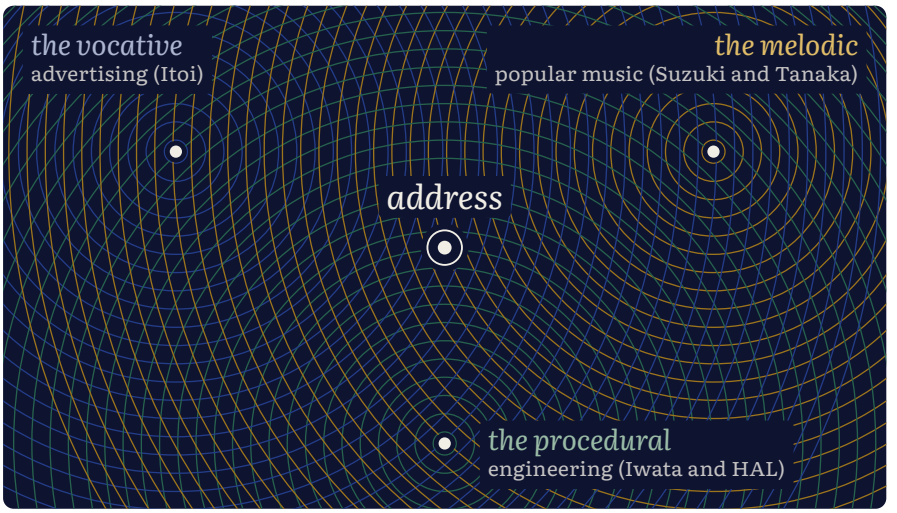
The Object: A Role-Playing Game Without Swords 1.1

LATE ONE NIGHT IN Onett, a small town in a country called Eagleland, a meteorite falls on the hill above a boy's house. The boy—Ness, in a striped shirt and a baseball cap, although the player has already been invited to rename him—is woken by the impact, turned back from the hill by a police cordon, and then summoned a second time by a knock at the door. It is his neighbour Pokey Minch, plump, petulant, and cowardly, demanding help in retrieving a younger brother who has wandered toward the crater. Ness takes the family dog, whose name is King. On the hilltop, amid smoke and barricades, an insect-like being named Buzz Buzz emerges from the rock and announces that he has travelled from ten years in the future—a future annihilated by a cosmic destroyer called Giygas—to deliver a prophecy: three boys and a girl will stand against the darkness. Until this moment the console role-playing game had been a genre of swords, castles, and sovereigns.

EarthBound begins with a cracked baseball bat, a suburban front door, and a dog called King: the genre's monarch demoted, with perfect deadpan, to the family pet.

The critical commonplace holds that this substitution is parody. The present study contends that it is something closer to what Nietzsche called transvaluation (*Umwertung*). Every structural element of the template inherited from *Dragon Quest* (Chunsoft/Enix, 1986)—turn-based combat, experience levels, the inventory, the party, the final adversary—survives intact, but each is re-anchored in the contemporary and the domestic. The sword becomes a bat, a frying pan, a yo-yo, a bottle rocket. The potion becomes a hamburger, a cookie, a pizza ordered by telephone. Magic becomes PSI, the parapsychological idiom of the 1970s. The inn becomes a hotel; the king's treasury becomes a father's deposits, withdrawn from automated teller machines; the chapel where the hero's progress is recorded becomes a telephone call home. The dragon becomes an intelligence so vast and so ruined that it can be neither depicted nor understood. Nothing is mocked; everything is relocated. And in being relocated, the genre's latent metaphysics—its implicit theory of what a hero is, of how power is acquired, of where evil resides and how it is undone—is brought into visibility, as a figure becomes legible only when it is moved against a new ground.

The work's genealogy is well documented. *Mother* (Nintendo, Famicom, 1989) originated in a proposal that Shigesato Itoi, then Japan's most celebrated copywriter, brought to Shigeru Miyamoto for a role-playing game set not in a pseudo-medieval elsewhere but in the American present that postwar Japan had absorbed through cinema, television, and popular music. Its sequel, developed by Ape Inc. and HAL Laboratory over the better part of five years, came close to collapse; HAL's Satoru Iwata—later president of Nintendo—assessed the faltering program and, in Itoi's often-repeated recollection, proposed to rebuild it from scratch in less time than salvage would require. *Mother 2: Gīgu no Gyakushū* was released for the Super Famicom on 27 August 1994; its localization, *EarthBound*, followed in North America on 5 June 1995. Its score, by Keiichi Suzuki of the rock group Moonriders and Hirokazu Tanaka, with Hiroshi Kanazu and Toshiyuki Ueno, is a dense pastiche of Anglo-American pop, rock-and-roll, and film music, punctuated by passages closer to *musique concrète* than to anything the genre had previously called battle music.



Three professional cultures converge in the object, each contributing a register of a single operation; address is what the three share (§ 1.1).

Three professional cultures thus converge in the object: advertising (Itoi), popular music (Suzuki and Tanaka), and engineering (Iwata and HAL). The meanings of *EarthBound* are constituted at their intersection, and this dissertation will argue that each contributes a distinct register of a single operation. The copywriter contributes the *vocative*: the compressed phrase that addresses a "you." The musicians contribute the *melodic*: the phrase that is carried across distance and recognized on its return. The engineers contribute the *procedural*: the rule that converts an action into a consequence and a choice into a relation. Address, in the sense developed below, is what the three registers share.

The procedural register deserves particular emphasis, because it is where *EarthBound* most decisively departs from its model. Enemies are visible in the field rather than generated by invisible random encounters, and the angle of contact determines initiative, signalled by a green or a red swirl. Adversaries rendered trivial by the protagonists' growth are dispatched instantly, without a battle being fought at all. Hit points do not fall at once but roll downward like an odometer, so that a mortal wound can be survived if the battle concludes before the meter reaches zero. Status ailments are drawn from bodily and affective life—homesickness, sunstroke, a cold, nausea, a condition the game calls simply "feeling strange." The game is saved by tele-

phoning a father who never appears on screen; money is deposited by that same father in proportion to the child's victories; items are dispatched by a courier service that employs Ness's younger sister; food heals, and condiments improve it. Each of these features will be read in the chapters that follow not as an interface convenience but as a proposition.

The narrative arc can be compressed into a paragraph only at the cost of its texture. Buzz Buzz is killed almost at once—swatted, in one of the game's most deliberately bathetic moments, by Pokey's mother, who mistakes the messenger from the future for a household pest—and Ness inherits the Sound Stone, a device that records the melodies of eight sacred sites collectively named "Your Sanctuary." The journey that follows assembles the prophesied four: Paula, a psychic girl from the town of Twoson, rescued from a cult that paints the world blue; Jeff, the bespectacled son of an absent scientist, summoned from a boarding school in the snowbound northern region of Winters; and Poo, crown prince of the mountain kingdom of Dalaam, who completes a training in nothingness before joining them. The itinerary passes through a zombie-haunted town, the metropolis of Fourside and its inverted twin Moonside, a seaside resort, a desert kingdom of pyramids, a swamp, a village of shy creatures, a valley of dinosaurs, and finally Magicant, a landscape composed of Ness's own memory. Because living bodies cannot travel into the past, where Giygas has taken refuge, the four children consent to have their souls transferred into robot bodies. In the Cave of the Past they confront Pokey, now Giygas's servant, and then Giygas itself, against whom every weapon and every psychic power proves useless. Paula prays. The prayer reaches the people the children have met, one community after another; for a time it is absorbed by the darkness; and finally it reaches the player, addressed by the name the game had quietly solicited hours before. Giygas is destroyed. The children return to their bodies and their homes. Pokey escapes into time.

The work's reception history has the same telephonic structure as its climax. In Japan the game was a substantial success; in North America it sold poorly, despite—some would say because of—an eccentric campaign built around the slogan "This game stinks" and scratch-and-sniff inserts. It survived instead as a cult object, sustained by Ness's inclusion in *Super Smash Bros.* (1999), by fan communities such as Starmen.net, by the volunteer translation of *Mother 3* (2008), by official reissues (2013 and 2022), and by direct descendants

of which Toby Fox's *Undertale* (2015) is the most celebrated. Its call, in other words, was answered a decade after it was placed, by addressees it could not have known.

The series' own paratexts announce the mode in which that call is made. The promotional copy for *Mother*, 「エンディングまで、泣くんじゃない。」 ("No crying until the ending"), is an imperative addressed to a second person: at once consolation and prohibition, it presupposes that tears will come and defers them to a promised end. The copy for *Mother 2*, 「大人も子供も、おねーさんも。」 ("Adults, children, and older sisters, too"), describes nothing about the product at all; it enumerates its addressees, and its comic third term—*onēsan*, young women, then largely absent from the imagined audience of console games—performs the inclusiveness it announces. The copy for *Mother 3*, 「奇妙で、おもしろい。そして、せつない。」 ("Strange, funny—and heartrending"), names an affective sequence the player is invited to undergo. None of these lines sells an object. Each calls a subject into a relation. They are, in miniature, the poetics this dissertation reconstructs.

They also name the tonal alloy for which the work is loved. Classical Japanese aesthetics distinguished *okashi*, the delighted wit of Sei Shōnagon's *Pillow Book*, from *aware*, the pathos of things that Motoori Norinaga located at the heart of *The Tale of Genji*; Bashō, late in life, sought *karumi*, a lightness capable of bearing weight. *EarthBound*'s signature gesture—the joke that opens onto grief, the grief that relaxes into a joke—belongs to this lineage, and also to the problem that Milan Kundera, glossing Parmenides, placed at the opening of *The Unbearable Lightness of Being* (1984): whether weight or lightness is the positive pole of existence. The present study treats that tonal problem as a philosophical one. A game whose English title names gravity, and whose climax depends upon an act as weightless as prayer, has already chosen its question.

1.2 The Author as Copy: Shigesato Itoi and the Vocative Imagination

Shigesato Itoi was born on 10 November 1948 in Maebashi, in Gunma Prefecture, a member of the postwar baby-boom cohort that Japanese sociology calls the *dankai sedai*. He enrolled at Hōsei University in Tokyo, was drawn into the student movement of the late 1960s, and left without a degree; by the early 1970s he was writing advertising copy, and by the early 1980s he had become the most visible copywriter in the country and a public figure of consumer culture in his own right. The trajectory—from the barricades of the *zenkyōtō* movement to the display windows of the department store—is the emblematic arc of a generation, and it is one that the fiction of Itoi's contemporary Haruki Murakami would narrate as a melancholy of the postpolitical. Chapter 2 pursues that history in detail. Here it suffices to establish the craft that Itoi brought to games, because the argument of this dissertation is that the craft became the cosmology.

Two slogans for the Seibu department stores define the craft. The first, 「不思議、大好き。」 (1981), joins a noun of wonder—*fushigi*, the strange, the mysterious, the inexplicable—to *daisuki*, the child's predicate of wholehearted enthusiasm. It describes no merchandise; it confesses a love on the reader's behalf and offers wonder as a disposition one may acquire by passing through a door. The second, 「おいしい生活。」 (1982), fuses a gustatory adjective with existence itself: "delicious life." In two words it registers the shift, theorized by Jean Baudrillard in *La Société de consommation* (1970), from the consumption of goods to the consumption of signs and ways of being, and it became a watchword of the aesthetic program that Seiji Tsutsumi's Saison group—Seibu, Parco, and their museums and bookshops—made of 1980s consumption. Itoi's gift was compression: the reduction of a worldview to an address brief enough to be worn.

The same gift shaped his work outside advertising. His lyrics for Kenji Sawada's "TOKIO" (1980) imagined the capital as an object aloft, a city that flies. With Murakami he co-authored *Yume de aimashō* (1981), a collection of short prose pieces in an idiom of deadpan whimsy and pop-literate fantasy that both writers would carry forward. For Hayao Miyazaki he voiced Tatsuo Kusakabe, the gentle academic father of *Tonari no Totoro* (1988)—a father present while the mother lies absent in hospital, the exact inversion, as Chapter 3 will show, of *EarthBound*'s household. And he wrote the copy for a

series of Studio Ghibli films. For *Totoro*: 「このへんないきものは、まだ日本にいるのです。たぶん。」 ("This strange creature still lives in Japan. Probably."), in which a single hedging adverb, *tabun*, opens the space of wonder by withholding certainty. For *Kiki's Delivery Service* (1989): 「おちこんだりもしたけれど、私はげんきです。」 ("I've been down at times, but I'm doing fine."), a first-person testimony. For *Princess Mononoke* (1997): 「生きろ。」 ("Live."), a bare imperative.

The grammar of these lines is consistent and diagnostic. Itoi's copy speaks *to* someone, in the vocative and the imperative, or *as* someone, in the testimonial first person; it almost never speaks *about*. Where the referential function of language, in Roman Jakobson's terms, would describe a product, Itoi's sentences activate the conative function, oriented toward the addressee, and the emotive function, oriented toward the speaker. They are, in Mikhail Bakhtin's vocabulary, maximally *addressive*. Bakhtin's late essay on speech genres identified addressivity—the quality of being directed to someone, and of anticipating that someone's response—as the constitutive feature of the utterance as such. Itoi's distinction is to have built a world in which addressivity is not merely a property of sentences but the principle of being.

Why games? Itoi's fascination with *Dragon Quest*, whose designer Yuji Horii was himself a former magazine writer, is a matter of record. What the role-playing game offered a copywriter was a new medium for the addressed micro-text. Its non-player characters are, structurally, speaking inscriptions: utterances fixed in place, each awaiting a passer-by whose approach will activate it. The form has an ancient ancestor in the epigraphic address to the traveller—the *siste, viator* ("stop, traveller") of Roman epitaphs, or the Thermopylae epigram attributed to Simonides that charges the passing stranger with a message for Sparta. An RPG town is a field of such inscriptions; an RPG is, among other things, a landscape whose every stone has something to say to whoever walks by. For a professional of the brief, situated, guaranteed address, the format was ideal. Itoi wrote *Mother* 2's Japanese text almost entirely in kana and plain vocabulary so that children could read it; the townspeople's lines, the signage, the gnomic pronouncements of the Mr. Saturn creatures (rendered in a childlike typeface of their own), and the deadpan narration that greets each defeat are thousands of small acts of copy distributed across a navigable space.

This raises the question of how the author should figure in an interpretation. The anti-intentionalist tradition—W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's "The Intentional Fallacy" (1946), Roland Barthes's "La mort de l'auteur" (1967), Michel Foucault's "Qu'est-ce qu'un auteur?" (1969)—warns against treating the author as the guarantor of meaning, and Foucault in particular showed that "author" names a function of discourse rather than a person behind it. The present study accepts the warning without dissolving Itoi altogether. It treats "Itoi" as a *vocative function*: the name for a consistent manner of address legible across advertising, lyric, essay, and game. The paradox is apt. In 1980s Japan Itoi's own name operated as a kind of brand, his public persona an extension of his copy. The author, in this case, was already copy.

The dissertation cites Itoi's statements where they are attested, and marks them as testimony rather than proof. Itoi has been notably reluctant to over-explain his work; in the decades since *Mother* 2 he has more often spoken of feelings, childhood, and the limits of explanation than of doctrine, and that reluctance is itself a datum. In 1998 he founded the website *Hobonichi Itoi Shinbun* ("the almost-daily Itoi newspaper"), and with it a small enterprise whose stated principle, 「やさしく、つよく、おもしろく。」 ("kindly, strongly, interestingly"), reads as a late, explicit formulation of an ethic the games had already enacted. *Hobonichi* represents a withdrawal from mass advertising toward a daily, intimate, small-scale address. *Mother* 2 stands at the hinge of that withdrawal—the copywriter's last great address to a mass audience and the essayist's first sustained meditation on what address is for—and the historical index of the hinge, the collapse of Japan's asset-price bubble in 1990–91, is the subject of the next chapter.

1.3 *The State of the Question*

For three decades the popular-critical reception of *EarthBound* has been organized around a lexicon of quirk: "charming," "weird," "surreal," "offbeat," "heartfelt," and, above all, "cult classic." The lexicon is not inaccurate, but it is evasive. "Quirk" names a surplus of meaning while declining the labour of interpreting it; it converts the work's strangeness into a brand attribute—an irony that Itoi, of all authors, would appreciate. Alongside it has grown a genre of fond retrospective in which a critic recounts the shock of the final battle and the

tears that followed. The genre is now so established that it functions as a secondary paratext: a liturgy of testimony that repeats, in the register of personal confession, the very structure of being-addressed that this dissertation analyses. The reception, in other words, is already evidence for the thesis; it simply does not know it.

Book-length studies are few. Ken Baumann's *EarthBound* (Boss Fight Books, 2014), the inaugural volume of a series devoted to single games, braids the game with memoir and thereby demonstrates, rather than theorizes, the work's capacity to become a vehicle for an individual life. Clyde Mandelin's *Legends of Localization Book 2: EarthBound* (2016), produced with Chris Kohler, offers a philological comparison of the Japanese and English scripts, documenting the transformations—some imposed by Nintendo of America's content standards, others born of the translator's inventiveness—by which *Mother 2* became *EarthBound*. Both are indispensable; neither attempts to reconstruct the work's metaphysics, and neither situates Itoi's copywriting as its matrix. In Japanese, the most extensive body of commentary is Itoi's own, dispersed across interviews, guidebook conversations, and decades of *Hobonichi* columns. It is valuable precisely for its refusal to systematize, and it is treated here as primary testimony rather than secondary criticism.

Within academic game studies, *EarthBound* has appeared mostly in passing: as a case in discussions of localization and censorship, of Japanese representations of America, of retro aesthetics and nostalgia, and of the lineage that runs to *Undertale*. Its absence from the founding debates of the discipline is striking. The controversy that structured the field's first decade—between "ludologists" who insisted on the specificity of games as rule-systems (Gonzalo Frasca, Jesper Juul, Espen Aarseth) and scholars who read games through narrative and drama (Janet Murray; Henry Jenkins's "narrative architecture")—might have been dissolved at a stroke by *EarthBound*, whose most important meanings are at once procedural and lyrical. Its climactic act is a menu command whose meaning cannot be separated from the story it completes. Its save system is a narrative relation. Its antagonist is a rendering technique. A game in which the rules tell the story and the story is a theory of the rules is a standing refutation of the dichotomy.

Three interpretive paradigms dominate the existing literature, academic and otherwise. The first, *parodic*, reads *EarthBound* as a meta-RPG, a knowing deformation of generic convention—parody in Linda

Hutcheon's sense of repetition with critical distance (*A Theory of Parody*, 1985). This paradigm explains the comedy and much of the structure, but it cannot explain why the parody culminates in an earnestness without irony. The second, *nostalgic*, reads the game as a reservoir of Americana and childhood affect, whether in the restorative or the reflective mode Svetlana Boym distinguished in *The Future of Nostalgia* (2001). It explains the work's atmosphere and its long afterlife among adult players, but not why the nostalgia is so persistently interrupted by terror. The third, *horrific-psychoanalytic*, concentrates on the final dungeon and the final battle, often in the form of fan exegesis: the reading of the organic walls of the Cave of the Past and of Giygas's last form as uterine and fetal, sometimes extended into an allegory of abortion, and the circulation of Itoi's own account of a childhood encounter with a frightening film scene as a source for Giygas's dialogue. This paradigm explains the game's capacity to wound; it isolates the ending from the many hours that prepare it.

The three paradigms are not false. They are strata, and each describes accurately the layer on which it stands. What none supplies is the logic that holds the strata together: the reason a parody of genre, a reservoir of nostalgia, and a horror of the unformed should cohere in a single work and resolve in a single act. Nor do they ask the questions that the game makes unavoidable once they have been posed. Why is the father a voice and the mother a body? Why is the game saved by telephone? Why does the decisive weapon take the form of prayer, and why must the prayer pass through the whole social world before it reaches the player? Why does the final antagonist lack a sprite? Why does the hero's most private interior take the form of a landscape to be walked, and why are the eight sacred sites of the earth called "*Your* Sanctuary," in the second person? Why, in a game written by a professional of address, are there so many media—telephones, telepathy, couriers, photographs, recordings, broadcast prayer—and so many scenes in which communication fails?

This dissertation proposes that these questions have one answer. *EarthBound* is a work about what it means to be addressed, and its metaphysics is a theory of communication in the strongest sense: an account of how beings come to exist for one another, and of what happens when they cannot. The lacuna in the literature is therefore not a missing detail but a missing frame. Once supplied, the frame reorganizes the three paradigms as moments of a single argument: the parody as the transvaluation of a genre's mode of address; the nos-

talgia as the address of a home that never existed; the horror as the encounter with that which cannot be addressed at all.

1.4 Method: Procedural Hermeneutics and the Comparative Field

The interpretation of a game must read its procedures—rules, systems, interface conventions—as bearers of meaning alongside its narrative and its images. Four bodies of work supply foundations. Ian Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric in *Persuasive Games* (2007) establishes that rule-based representations persuade; Alexander Galloway's analysis of gamic action in *Gaming* (2006) establishes that the act, not the image, is the medium's primary unit; Espen Aarseth's *Cybertext* (1997), with its definition of ergodic literature as text requiring non-trivial effort to traverse, establishes the reader's labour as constitutive of the work; and Janet Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck* (1997) establishes procedural authorship as the writing of rules by which texts are generated. The present study extends these into what it calls *procedural hermeneutics*. A procedure is read not only for what it persuades the player to do but for what it presupposes about a world in which such doing is possible. To save by telephoning a father presupposes that the archive of a life is held by an absent paternal voice. To suffer homesickness in combat presupposes that attachment is a variable of courage. To win instantly against weaker foes presupposes that growth abolishes certain kinds of fear. To survive a mortal blow by acting quickly presupposes that death is a duration rather than an instant. These presuppositions are the game's metaphysics, and they are written in code.

Procedures in turn rest on a material substrate, which the platform studies inaugurated by Nick Montfort and Ian Bogost (*Racing the Beam*, 2009) teach us to read. The Super Famicom's graphics hardware, with its layered backgrounds and its capacity for line-by-line distortion and palette manipulation, is the condition of possibility for *EarthBound*'s undulating, psychedelic battle backgrounds. That Giygas, in his final form, is produced as a manipulation of the background rather than drawn as a sprite is a technical fact; Chapter 6 argues that it is also the game's most precise metaphysical statement.

Hans-Georg Gadamer, in *Wahrheit und Methode* (1960), took play as the clue to the ontology of the artwork: play possesses an essence in-

dependent of the consciousness of those who play, so that the players are, in a sense, played. Understanding, for Gadamer, is a fusion of horizons between the world of the work and the world of the interpreter. Comparative method makes that fusion explicit and therefore accountable. A dissertation that reads a Super Famicom game alongside Dōgen and Dostoevsky owes its reader an account of the kinds of relation it is asserting. Three registers are distinguished throughout. The first is *attested* relation: connections documented by the production or by Itoi himself—the debt to *Dragon Quest*, the absorption of American film and television, the series' internal genealogy, Itoi's collaborations with Murakami and Studio Ghibli, his recollection of a childhood cinematic trauma. The second is *ambient* relation: the cultural milieu of which the work is a symptom whether or not its makers intended a reference—Saison culture and the consumer society; the occult boom of the 1970s, with Uri Geller's televised tour of Japan in 1974, the spoon-bending children who followed, and the monthly magazine Mū, founded in 1979; postwar Japan's American imaginary; the asset bubble and its collapse; the "new new religions" (*shin-shin shūkyō*) of the 1980s. The third is *homological* relation: structural affinity without any claim of influence—between Paula's prayer and Simone Weil's theory of attention, between Giygas's ambivalent cries and Isaac of Nineveh's "scourge of love," between the Mu training and Dōgen's dropping-off of body and mind.

The model for the third register is the elective affinity (*Wahlverwandtschaft*), a term Goethe borrowed from eighteenth-century chemistry for the title of his 1809 novel and which Max Weber, and later Michael Löwy, adapted to describe relations of mutual attraction between cultural forms that are neither causal nor accidental. Its safeguard is Samuel Sandmel's celebrated warning against "parallelomania" (1962), the inflation of resemblance into derivation. Each comparison in this dissertation is marked by register. Where a claim is homological it asserts illumination, not descent: it holds that the comparandum clarifies what the game does, not that the game was made from it.

Psychoanalytic theory—Freud, Melanie Klein, D. W. Winnicott, Jacques Lacan, Julia Kristeva—is drawn upon not to diagnose Itoi or the player but because the work itself thematizes mothers and fathers, nightmares and interiors, the infantile and the formless with an explicitness that invites the vocabulary. Magicant is an interior world whose cartography amounts to a theory of the psyche; home-

sickness is an attachment variable; Giygas speaks like an infant in pain. The concepts serve as a grammar of figures, tested against the work rather than imposed upon it. Theology and the philosophy of religion are approached in a spirit akin to what Ninian Smart called methodological agnosticism. *EarthBound*'s prayer is not an argument for God, and this dissertation is not an apology for faith; but the phenomenology of prayer illuminates what the game makes its player do with unusual precision, and it would be a failure of scholarship to refuse that illumination out of secular embarrassment. The philosophy of the Kyoto School—Kitarō Nishida, Keiji Nishitani—is used for its unrivalled analysis of nothingness, with full acknowledgment of the school's wartime entanglements, including Nishitani's participation in the *Chūōkōron* roundtables of 1941–42 and the 1942 symposium on "Overcoming Modernity" (*Kindai no chōkoku*). Its concepts are employed critically, not reverentially.

Media theory supplies the fourth instrument. Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964), Friedrich Kittler's *Grammophon, Film, Typewriter* (1986), Avital Ronell's *The Telephone Book* (1989), and John Durham Peters's *Speaking into the Air* (1999) together furnish a vocabulary for what *EarthBound* stages in miniature: a media history of telephone, recorder, camera, courier, and telepathic broadcast, through which the game reflects upon its own medium. A game is itself a medium of address—a system that speaks to a player and awaits response—and its depictions of other media are, inevitably, depictions of itself.

The breadth of the comparative corpus requires a final justification. *EarthBound* is a syncretic artifact assembled by a professional of popular culture, and its meaning is constituted by citation. Its score samples and quotes; its world is a collage of American films, comics, and television; its enemy roster includes a melting clock named for Dalí and a "New Age Retro Hippie"; even the name "Eagleland" is a citation. A comparative method that ranges across literature, film, comics, music, philosophy, theology, and other games does not impose breadth upon the work. It mirrors the work's own mode of composition. The governing principle is to read upward from the minor detail—an item name, an enemy, a stray line of dialogue—on the assumption, which the analysis will vindicate, that in a work made of copy nothing is filler.

A last methodological term concerns the figure of the player. Wolfgang Iser's implied reader (*Der implizite Leser*, 1972; *Der Akt des Lesens*,

1976) names the role a text constructs for its reader; Aarseth's implied player (2007) transposes the concept to games, naming the role a game's rules and fictions prepare for the one who plays. Empirical players differ; the implied player is the addressee the work constructs. When this dissertation speaks of "the player," it means that addressee—who, uniquely in *EarthBound*, is eventually called by name.

1.5 *Telephonic Grace: The Thesis Stated*

The argument of this dissertation can be stated in seven theses. Each is developed at length in the chapters that follow; together they constitute what is here called *telephonic grace*.

1 **Being is being-addressed.** In *EarthBound*, whatever matters is constituted through a call. The game begins not with the meteorite but with a knock; the hero is summoned by name before he acts; the prophecy addresses him as one of four; the sacred sites of the earth address him in the second person, as "Your Sanctuary"; his companions reach him in dreams before they meet him in the flesh. To be, in this world, is to be called and to be capable of answering.

2 **The world is a network of channels.** Eagleland is threaded with media: public telephones in every town, a courier service, a pizza delivery, telepathic dreams, the Sound Stone's recordings, the camera of a roving photographer, and, at the end, a prayer broadcast across the world. Grace arrives through these channels, at a distance (*tēle*) and as a voice (*phōnē*). Hence the term.

3 **Gravity is the condition of the addressed.** The beings who are called are bound. They have bodies that hunger and tire, homes they miss, debts they owe, money they need, a ground they cannot leave. The English title names this condition. Gravity is not evil; it is finitude, and it is the medium in which address becomes care.

4 **Evil is noise.** The antagonist is not a rival will but the destruction of the channel: a power that has annihilated its own capacity for thought, rendered as a background without a figure, whose attacks cannot be grasped, and whose ambient influence renders dogs, crows,

townspeople, and police incapable of recognizing one another. Giygas is what it would mean to be absolutely unaddressable.

5

Salvation is address restored. The decisive act is not a blow but a prayer: an utterance sent, without guarantee, toward an absent other. Prayer succeeds where force fails because it does not attempt to overpower the noise; it traverses it. The communities that answer Paula do not defeat Giygas by strength. They defeat him by being reachable.

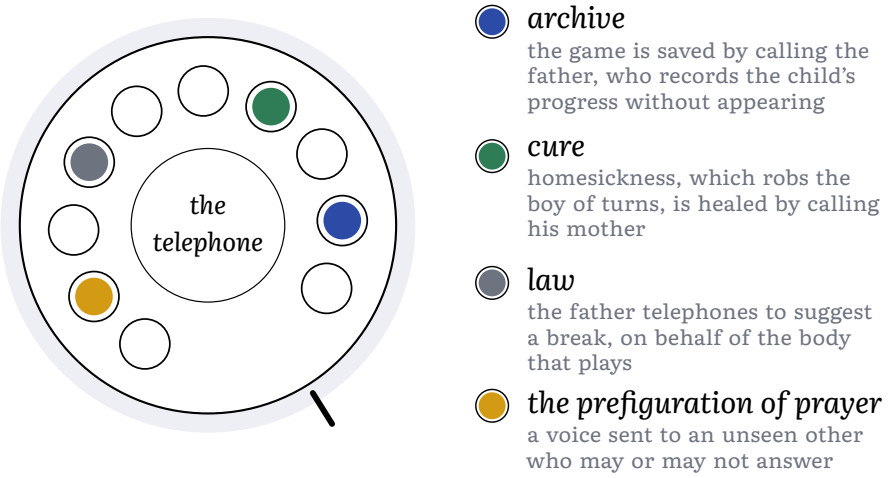
6

The last channel runs through the screen. The final prayer reaches the player by name. The interface—the constitutive relation between a game and the one who plays it—is revealed to have been the outermost of the world's channels, and the player's attention is revealed to have been, all along, a form of answer.

7

This structure is counter-copy. Itoi, whose profession was the industrial manufacture of address, inverts its vector. The slogan offers satisfaction to a consumer; the prayer asks help of an absent other. *EarthBound* thereby converts the substance on which advertising feeds—attention—into what Simone Weil held to be its highest form.

The coinage requires justification. *Grace*—Latin *gratia*, Greek *charis*—names, across the theological traditions, the unearned gift that arrives from beyond the economy of desert: for Augustine the help without which the will cannot turn, for Weil the sole exception to the gravity of the soul. Japanese religious history offers a homology of remarkable precision. Shinran (1173–1263), radicalizing the Pure Land teaching of his master Hōnen, distinguished *jiriki*, self-power, from *tariki*, other-power, and held that salvation comes only through the latter—through entrusting oneself to the vow of Amida Buddha, expressed in the recitation of the *nembutsu*, "Namu Amida Butsu." In the *Kyōgyōshinshō* Shinran glosses the first word of that formula, *namu*—"taking refuge"—as the summons of Amida's Primal Vow calling beings to itself. The human utterance is the echo of a call already sounding within it; the petition is the answer. Mapped onto *EarthBound* as homology rather than influence, the distinction is exact. Everything the player has accumulated over dozens of hours—levels, weapons, armour, the escalating PSI techniques—is *jiriki*, and the final battle stages its exhaustion. What saves is *tariki*, arriving as an utterance passed from voice to voice, and it culminates in a name.



The telephone is the game's master figure because it performs four offices that, together, prefigure the whole (§ 1.5).

The qualifier *telephonic* designates the form in which grace arrives: as a voice at a distance. The telephone is the game's master figure because it performs four functions that, together, prefigure the whole. It is the *archive*: the game is saved by calling Ness's father, who records the child's progress without ever appearing. It is the *cure*: homesickness, a status ailment that robs Ness of turns in combat, is healed by calling his mother. It is the *law*: if the player continues too long without rest, the father telephones to suggest a break, a paternal voice interrupting play on behalf of the body that plays. And it is the *prefiguration of prayer*: a voice sent to an unseen other who may or may not answer. Avital Ronell's *The Telephone Book* (1989) reads the telephone as the technological figure of the call and connects it to Heidegger's analysis, in *Sein und Zeit* (1927), of the call of conscience, which "comes from me and yet from beyond me" (*Der Ruf kommt aus mir und doch über mich*, § 57). In *EarthBound*, the call that finally saves comes from the player: from beyond the game, and yet, as the game has patiently taught, from within its own world of address.

The contributions claimed for this dissertation follow from the thesis. It offers, first, a reading of the *Mother* series' metaphysics as a soteriology of address. It offers, second, a reading of Itoi's oeuvre in which the copywriter's art is confessed and inverted as *counter-copy*. It proposes, third, the concept of the *domestic sublime*—an inversion of the Freudian uncanny in which the cosmic is made homely rather than

the homely made strange. It reads, fourth, Giygas as a figure–ground inversion: an enemy that is not a figure against the background but the background itself turned hostile, a materialization of noise in Shannon's and Serres's senses. It identifies, fifth, two incommensurable nothings in the game—the emptiness of Poo's Mu training and the nihility of Giygas—and reads the former as the game's internal theory of the robot transfer that makes the final confrontation possible. It interprets, sixth, the ambivalence of Giygas's last utterances through Isaac of Nineveh's doctrine of the "scourge of love," in which the same divine love is suffered as torment by those who cannot receive it and as joy by those who can. And it argues, seventh, that the final prayer converts the player's attention into grace, and thereby constitutes, *avant la lettre*, an intervention in the political economy of attention that has since become the dominant economy of digital media.

Four Coordinates: Gravity, Grace, Noise, Address 1.6

Telephonic grace is articulated along two axes. The ontological axis runs from *gravity* to *grace*: from what beings are by necessity to what is given them beyond necessity. The communicative axis runs from *noise* to *address*: from what destroys relation to what establishes it. Each of the game's major structures occupies a position in the field the axes define, and the field's four quadrants organize its moral cosmology. Gravity joined to address is *home*: the kitchen telephone, the mother's steak, the dog, the bed—embodied communion, the ground made hospitable. Grace joined to noise is *counterfeit grace*: the Mani Mani Statue, an object that grants power and the fulfilment of wishes without relation, possessing its successive owners—a hermit who unearthed it beneath his house, a cult leader, a tycoon—and, in Moonside, inverting the speech of an entire city so that yes means no. Power given without address isolates; it is grace's simulacrum. Gravity joined to noise is *Giygas*: a power so dense that it has collapsed upon itself and destroyed its own mind, a gravitational collapse from which no signal escapes. The astrophysical metaphor is exact. A black hole is the point at which gravity forbids communication, and Giygas, rendered as a red-and-black vortex, is its moral equivalent. Grace joined to address, finally, is *prayer*: the gift that arrives as a call and is answered. Figure 1.1 sets out the field.

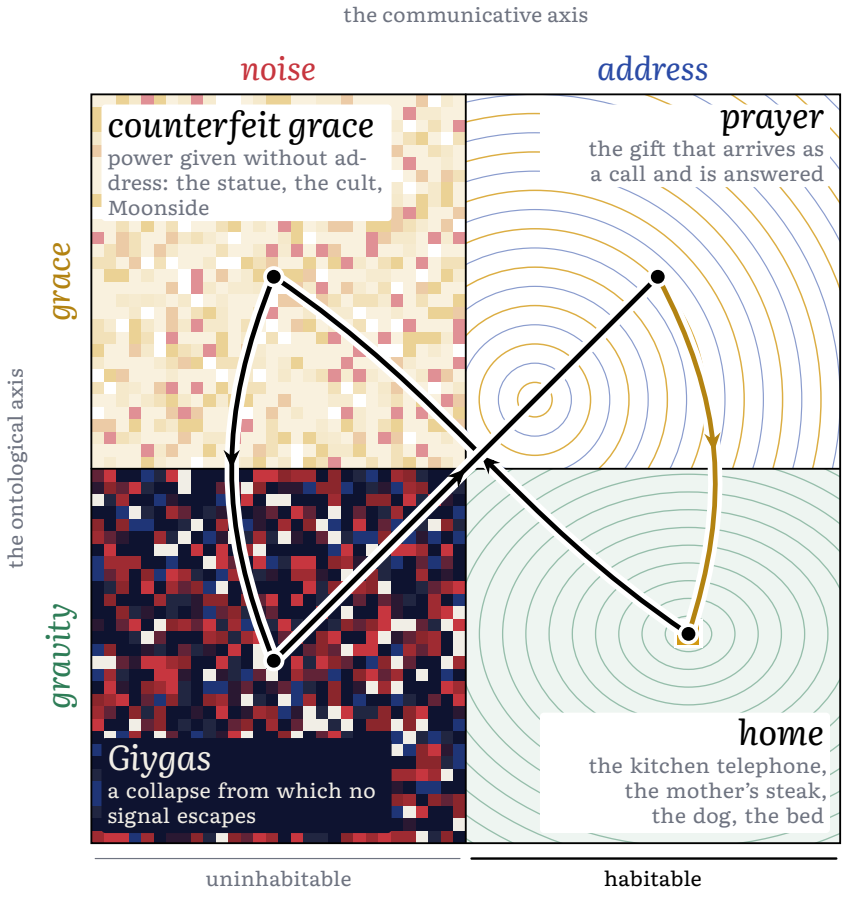


Figure 1.1 Four coordinates of telephonic grace: the 2 × 2 field, with the circuit of the call drawn through it.

Only the right-hand column, where gravity or grace is joined to address, is habitable. The game's circuit runs from Home through the counterfeit graces to Giygas, and returns through Prayer.

Gravity. Weil's *La Pesanteur et la grâce*, assembled after her death by Gustave Thibon from her notebooks and published in 1947, opens with the claim that the natural movements of the soul obey laws analogous to those of physical gravity, and that grace alone is the exception. Gravity, for Weil, is not sin but necessity: the downward pull of appetite, self-interest, and force; the mechanism by which the self rushes to fill every void. The English title of the series—first prepared, as *Earth Bound*, for an American release of the original *Mother* that was abandoned and resurrected only in 2015 as *EarthBound Beginnings*—names this condition with uncanny exactness. Procedurally, gravity is everywhere: in hit points and psychic points, in the hamburgers that restore them, in the hotels where the party must sleep, in the father's deposits and the cash machines that dispense them, in homesickness and sunstroke and colds, and in the rolling meter that converts mortality from an instant into a duration. Even the game's most magical technique is earth-bound. PSI Teleport cannot be invoked from rest; the child must run, building momentum in a straight line or a spiral, and if he strikes an obstacle before departing he is left scorched and smoking on the ground. In this dissertation's usage, gravity is not evil. It is finitude: the condition of beings who can be hurt, fed, missed, and called home.

Grace. The call that arrives from elsewhere is figured, first, by PSI, the parapsychological idiom that runs from J. B. Rhine's laboratory at Duke in the 1930s to the Japanese occult boom of the 1970s. But PSI, which is acquired by experience and spent from a finite reserve, belongs in Shinran's terms to self-power. The game marks the difference through Paula's unique command, Pray, which in ordinary battles produces unpredictable effects—healing or harm, to friend or foe—and is therefore of little tactical use for most of the game. Its randomness is the game's figure of grace's gratuity. In Roger Caillois's typology of play (*Les Jeux et les hommes*, 1958), grace belongs not to *agôn*, the contest won by effort, nor to *mimicry* or *ilinx*, but to *alea*: it is received, not earned. Weil adds a further condition that the game will honour in its final act: grace fills, *mais elle ne peut entrer que là où il y a un vide pour la recevoir*—it can enter only where there is a void to receive it. Chapter 5 argues that the robot bodies into which the children pour their souls are precisely such a void.

Noise. Claude Shannon's "A Mathematical Theory of Communication" (1948) defined noise as the perturbation of a channel that the receiver cannot distinguish from signal. Michel Serres's *Le Parasite* (1980) exploited the fact that in French *parasite* names at once the biological parasite, the uninvited guest at table, and static on the line, and argued that this triple figure—the interfering third—founds and threatens every relation. Jacques Attali's *Bruits* (1977) treated noise as a simulacrum of violence and music as its channelling, the ritual by which a community domesticates the weapon it fears. Giygas is noise in all three senses. He is the corruption of the signal, rendered through the distortion of the background layer; he is the parasite lodged in the earth's past, feeding on its future; and he is violence untamed by music, against which the eight melodies of the Sound Stone stand as Attali's channelled sound. The game's most famous battle message—"You cannot grasp the true form of Giygas's attack!"—is a precise statement of undecodability. And Giygas's influence before the final confrontation is social noise: animals turn vicious, townspeople turn cranky, police turn corrupt, and the channels by which neighbours recognize one another fill with static.

Address. Bakhtin's addressivity furnishes the general principle; Martin Buber's *Ich und Du* (1923) its ethical form, in the distinction between the relation to a Thou and the use of an It, and in the claim that all actual life is encounter (*Alles wirkliche Leben ist Begegnung*). Franz Rosenzweig's *Der Stern der Erlösung* (1921) made revelation grammatical: the divine vocative "Where art thou?" of Genesis 3:9 and the human answer "Here I am." Louis Althusser's account of interpellation (1970) showed how ideology hails individuals into subjects; Roman Jakobson's phatic function (1960) named the utterances—"Hello? Can you hear me?"—whose whole content is the checking of the channel; Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et Infini* (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face that addresses before it is known; and Jean-Louis Chrétien's *L'appel et la réponse* (1992) argued that every response arrives after a call it never fully heard. *EarthBound* furnishes the instances: the knock at the door, the telephone, the telepathic dream, the scrolling interlude in which, over coffee, the game speaks directly to the player of the journey so far, the photographer's cry of "fuzzy pickles," and the prayer.

The four coordinates are not static positions but the stations of a circuit. The game traverses the field from home (gravity and address) outward through a series of counterfeit graces—the cult, the statue, the

tycoon's tower, Moonside—toward the collapsed star of noise, and returns through prayer to the house on the hill. Its shape is the shape of a call: departure, transmission, interference, reception, return. This is, recognizably, the circuit that Joseph Campbell called the monomyth (*The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949): departure, initiation, return. But *EarthBound* alters the monomyth at its root. Campbell's hero returns bearing a boon won by his own ordeal. Ness returns having been saved by the voices of others, the last of them belonging to someone he has never met. The monomyth of self-power becomes a monomyth of other-power; the hero's journey becomes the journey of a call.

Corpus, Versions, and Translation 1.7

The primary object of this study is a single work in two languages: *Mother 2: Gīgu no Gyakushū* (Super Famicom, 1994) and *EarthBound* (Super Nintendo Entertainment System, 1995). The two are treated as versions of one diglossic artifact rather than as original and copy. The work's later editions—the Game Boy Advance compilation *Mother* 1+2 (2003), the Wii U Virtual Console release (2013), and the Nintendo Switch Online release (2022)—are textually conservative and are cited only where they bear on reception. Two further works are read as the series' frame. *Mother* (1989), whose completed English localization was shelved and released only in 2015 as *EarthBound Beginnings*, functions as the prologue whose orphaned alien, Giegue, becomes the Giygas of the sequel. *Mother 3* (Game Boy Advance, 2006), never officially published in English but widely played through the volunteer translation released in 2008 by a team led by Clyde Mandelin, functions as epilogue and commentary: it returns to Pokey, now an immortal child-tyrant, and to the commodification of happiness that the Happy Happyists had prefigured.

The English localization, associated principally with Marcus Lindblom at Nintendo of America, introduced alterations of several kinds, which Mandelin's philological study documents in detail. Some were imposed by the content standards then governing Nintendo's North American releases and concerned religious iconography, alcohol, and nudity. Some were renamings: the antagonist's Japanese name, *Gīgu*, became "Giygas"; *Pōkī* became "Pokey"; *Dosei-san* became, with literal fidelity and a gain in comic dignity, "Mr. Saturn." Others were inventive transpositions of wordplay for which no equivalent existed.

This dissertation treats the two scripts as a parallel text. Where they converge, the convergence is evidence of the work's structural commitments, which survived translation; where they diverge, the divergence is evidence of a different kind—of how address is carried across a cultural border, and of what a localization judged unsayable to an American child in 1995. Japanese terms are supplied wherever the English obscures a resonance on which the argument depends.

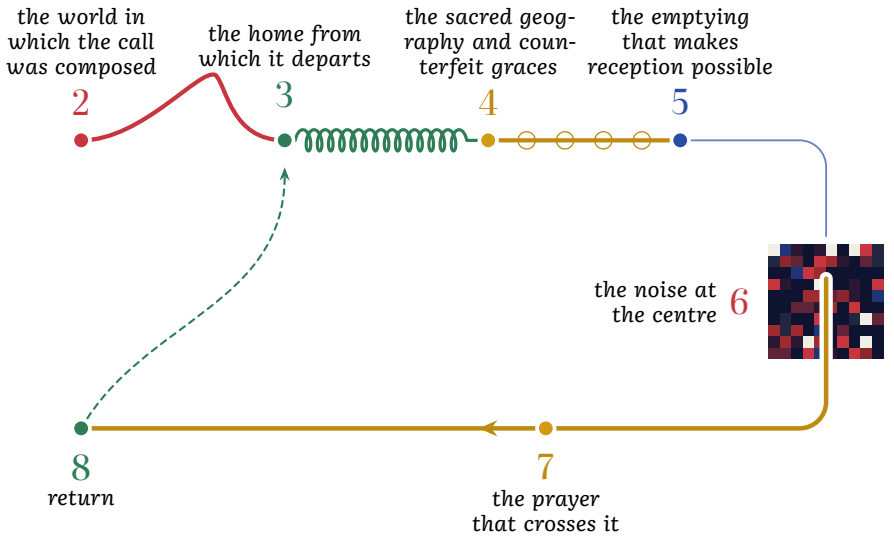
In-game text is cited from the English localization, in paraphrase wherever possible and in brief quotation where exact wording matters. Modern Japanese personal names are given in Western order, given name first, with macrons where conventional (Kōjin Karatani, Keiji Nishitani, Katsuhiro Ōtomo); premodern figures appear under their customary names (Dōgen, Shinran, Bashō, Sei Shōnagon). Dates are those of first publication or release. Translations from French, German, and Japanese are the author's unless otherwise indicated. Fan interpretations are cited as evidence of reception, never as canon, and their status is examined directly in Chapter 8.

1.8 *Architecture of the Dissertation*

The chapters follow the circuit of the call described in Section 1.6: outward from the world in which the call was composed, through the home from which it departs, across the sacred geography and counterfeit graces it must traverse, through the emptying that makes reception possible, into the noise at the centre, and back through the prayer that crosses it.

Chapter 2, "Delicious Life," reconstructs Itoi's milieu: the generation of 1968 and its passage from politics to consumption; the Saison culture of the 1980s and the poetics of the slogan; Eagleland as a hyperreal America assembled from postwar media, read through Jean Baudrillard, Shun'ya Yoshimi, John Dower, and Arjun Appadurai's "armchair nostalgia"; Japan's conspicuous absence from the game's world, read through Kōjin Karatani's account of the discovery of landscape; and Fourside as an allegory of the bubble's collapse, from the tycoon Monotoli to the debts of the Runaway Five and the father's cash machines, with Michael Ende's *Momo* as comparandum. It closes by defining counter-copy.

Chapter 3, "The House on the Hill," examines the meteorite as cosmic intrusion into the small town (Ray Bradbury, Tove Jansson's *Comet in Moominland*, Steven Spielberg's E.T.); dwelling and



The chapters follow the circuit of the call: outward from the world in which it was composed, through the home it leaves, inward to the noise at the centre, and back through the prayer that crosses it (§ 1.8).

gravity in Gaston Bachelard, Martin Heidegger, and Weil; homesickness as an attachment mechanic, read through John Bowlby, Winnicott, and Freud's *fort-da*; the present mother and the absent father, read through Lacan's Name-of-the-Father, Charles Schulz's unseen adults, and the inverted household of *Totoro*; Pokey Minch as the failed house, read through René Girard's mimetic rivalry and Melanie Klein's envy; and the domestic sublime as an anti-uncanny, contrasted with David Lynch's suburban abyss.

Chapter 4, "Your Sanctuary," reads the Sound Stone as songline, temple stamp book, and gramophone; traces the doctrine of harmony and recollection from Pythagoras and Plato to *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*; reads the Mani Mani Statue as counterfeit grace alongside Murakami's possessing sheep, Lynch's BOB, Tarkovsky's Room, and Tolkien's Ring; examines Moonside's inversions through Lewis Carroll, surrealism, and the Red Room of *Twin Peaks*; reads the Happy Happyists through Kenji Miyazawa's ethics of happiness and the new religions of the 1980s; treats Saturn Valley and Tenda Village as an ethics of alterity; and maps Magicant as an interior continent through Murakami's *Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World*, Tarkovsky's *Solaris*, and Jung's shadow.

Chapter 5, "Mu," interprets Poo's training in nothingness through Dōgen's dropping-off of body and mind, Zhuangzi's sitting-in-forgetfulness, and the Tibetan practice of *gcod* (Chöd), with its uncanny echo in Stephen King's *It*; deploys Nishitani's distinction between nihility and emptiness as the key to the game's two nothings; reads Jeff Andonuts through Heidegger's question concerning technology; interprets the Phase Distorter and the robot body through Osamu Tezuka's *Astro Boy*, Masamune Shirow's *Ghost in the Shell*, and Gilbert Ryle's "ghost in the machine"; maps the four children onto Heidegger's fourfold of earth, sky, divinities, and mortals; and analyses prophecy, time travel, and the rolling meter through Henri Bergson, *Chrono Trigger*, and *Doraemon*.

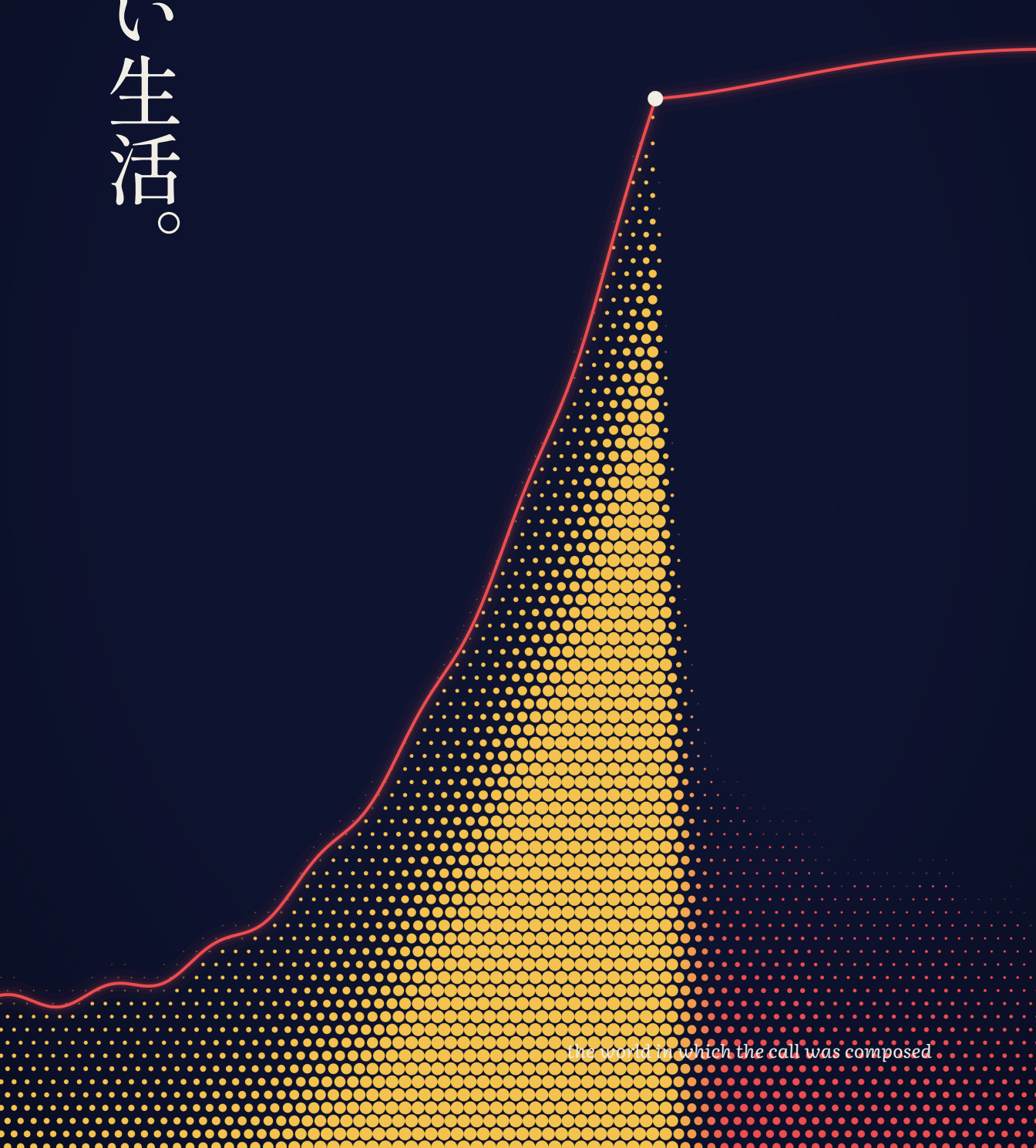
Chapter 6, "You Cannot Grasp the True Form," traces Giygas from the orphaned Giegue of *Mother*, pacified by a mother's lullaby; reads him as background, noise, and parasite; as privation and thoughtlessness (Augustine, Arendt); as the abject infant (Kristeva, Otto Rank, Lynch's *Eraserhead*, Ōtomo's *Akira*, Kubrick's Star Child); and as the sublime withheld (Edmund Burke, Kant, Jean-François Lyotard, H. P. Lovecraft's Azathoth). It examines Itoi's account of the childhood film scene behind Giygas's dialogue and concludes with Isaac of Nineveh and Dostoevsky's Father Zosima, for whom hell is the suffering of being unable to love.

Chapter 7, "Paula Prayed," reads the final battle as liturgy; reconstructs a phenomenology of prayer from Marcel Mauss's unfinished thesis on prayer, Friedrich Heiler, Weil, and Chrétien; analyses the prayer as inverted interpellation and as phatic act; situates it in the history of dissemination and telepathy traced by Peters and Ronell; reads the address to the player alongside Ende's *The Neverending Story*, Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler*, and Murakami's "Super-Frog Saves Tokyo"; reads the photographs of the closing credits through Barthes's *La Chambre claire*, a book written around a photograph of the author's mother; and argues that the final prayer completes counter-copy by converting attention into grace.

Chapter 8, "Adults, Children, and Older Sisters, Too," summarizes the findings; traces the inheritance of telephonic grace in *Mother 3*, *Undertale*, and *OMORI*; confronts the principal objections—the orientalism of Dalaam and Scaraba, the instabilities of localization, the canon-making power of fan theory; draws out implications for game studies, media theory, and the philosophy of religion; and closes with a coda on Pokey's escape, the one call the game leaves unanswered.

The promotional copy of the first *Mother* forbade tears until the ending. This dissertation adopts the injunction as a method. It defers its final judgments—on what Giygas is, on what the prayer achieves, on whom the game finally addresses—to its closing chapters, and asks its reader to hold, through the chapters between, the questions the game itself holds open: how a being comes to be called, what it means to answer, and what remains of a world in which no one can be reached.

おいしい生活。



2

"Delicious Life"

The Copywriter's Cosmos and the Japanese Imaginary of America

「おいしい生活。」

"Delicious life."

Shigesato Itoi, copy for Seibu Department Stores (1982)

"The subject does not belong to the world but it is a limit of the world."

Ludwig Wittgenstein, Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus (1922), 5.632

THIS CHAPTER ARGUES THAT *EarthBound*'s world was composed by a professional of address at the moment his profession's world collapsed, and that the game bears the marks of both conditions. It is built, like a department-store campaign, out of the signs of a desired elsewhere called America; and it ends, unlike any campaign, by turning its address around. The chapter reconstructs Itoi's formation and milieu (2.1–2.2), analyses Eagleland as a hyperreal America (2.3), interprets the absence of Japan from the game's world (2.4), reads Fourside as the afterimage of the asset bubble (2.5), and defines the operation this dissertation calls counter-copy (2.6).

2.1 *Maebashi, Hōsei, and the Generation of 1968*

Shigesato Itoi was born in 1948 in Maebashi, the prefectural capital of Gunma, a silk town on the northern rim of the Kantō plain. The city had already given modern Japanese poetry one of its founders. Sakutarō Hagiwara (1886–1942), born there into a physician's family, established in *Tsuki ni hoeru* (*Howling at the Moon*, 1917) a free verse in the colloquial language: everyday speech raised, for the first time in Japanese, to the pitch of lyric. Two of Hagiwara's later works bear on the present argument, in the ambient and homological registers defined in Chapter 1 rather than as sources. The prose-poem *Nekomachi* (*Cat Town*, 1935) concerns a narrator with a defective sense of direction who, approaching a familiar town from an unaccustomed side, finds it transfigured into an exquisite stranger, and then crowded with cats; Hagiwara presents the vision as a glimpse of the reverse side of the ordinary world. And *Kyōshū no shijin Yosa Buson* (*Buson, Poet of Nostalgia*, 1936) recast the eighteenth-century haiku master as a poet of *kyōshū*, a plaintive nostalgia of the soul for a home that cannot be located in any place. A provincial city thus bequeathed three motifs that *EarthBound* would develop half a century later: everyday speech lifted into poetry, a town that inverts when seen from its other side, and nostalgia for a home no one has seen. No claim is made that Itoi wrote with Hagiwara in mind. The claim is that the copywriter who would raise colloquial Japanese to the condition of public poetry belongs, by birth and by craft, to a local lineage that had already made those moves.

Itoi was born in the first full year of the *dankai*, the baby boom of 1947–49 and the most numerous cohort in Japanese history. That cohort grew up under the afterlife of the American Occupation (1945–52), amid the high-growth economy, and with the television that carried the American consumer imaginary into Japanese homes. It came of age in the student revolt of 1968–69, when the All-Campus Joint Struggle Committees (*zenkyōtō*) occupied universities across the country, a revolt that culminated in the police siege of the University of Tokyo's Yasuda Auditorium in January 1969. The movement then fractured into sectarian violence; the purges of the United Red Army and the Asama-Sansō siege of 1972 ended its moral authority. Itoi, who entered Hōsei University in these years, was drawn into the movement and left without a degree. The 1970s that followed were the decade of *shirake*, disenchantment: the cool withdrawal of a gen-

eration that had spent its political passion and found nothing on the other side.

Haruki Murakami, born in January 1949, two months after Itoi, and his collaborator on *Yume de aimashō*, made that disenchantment the founding mood of his fiction. The narrators of *Kaze no uta o kike* (*Hear the Wind Sing*, 1979) and *Hitsuji o meguru bōken* (*A Wild Sheep Chase*, 1982) are survivors of 1968 who drink beer, listen to American records, and drift through a world in which the energies of the barricades have been redirected into style. Murakami has recounted that he found the voice of his first novel by writing its opening in English and translating it back into Japanese. His prose was thus, at its origin, a translation from an imagined American: an interior America that became a Japanese style. The point bears directly on *EarthBound*. Eagleland is likewise a translation from an America that exists nowhere except in the Japanese imagination of it.

The passage of this generation from politics to consumption has often been narrated as a defeat. It can also be described, more neutrally, as a transfer of rhetorical energy. The student movement was itself an art of address. Its standing placards (*tatekan*), lettered in the angular script students called *gebaji*, "Gewalt characters," hailed passers-by in the imperative and the vocative. Advertising in the 1970s absorbed a generation of young writers trained in that art and redirected it from the barricade to the display window, and Itoi's career is the most brilliant instance of the redirection. What remained constant across the transfer was a grammar: the imperative, the vocative, the testimonial first person.

The copy that first brought Itoi professional recognition—the Tokyo Copywriters Club's New Face Award of 1975, for a campaign by the clothing firm Tomen Apparel—already displays the structure this dissertation calls telephonic. It reads: 「このジャンパーの良さがわからないなんて、とうさん、あんたは不幸な人だ!」 ("If you can't see how good this jacket is, Dad, you're an unfortunate man!"). The line is spoken in the voice of a son to his father. It sells a garment by staging a generational rupture in the form of a vocative—*tōsan*, "Dad"—and it pities the father for an incapacity to receive. Two decades later, the father of *EarthBound* will be reachable only by telephone, and the son's relation to him will consist entirely of calls. The address that made Itoi's name was a child calling across a gap to a father who could not quite hear.

Table 2.1 sets Itoi's career against the economic and political history of postwar Japan. Read across its columns, it shows a career that rises with the high-growth and bubble economies and produces its decisive game work at the bubble's crest and in its collapse: *Mother* in the year the Shōwa era ended and the stock market peaked, *Mother* 2 in the trough that followed.

2.2 *Seibu, Saison, and the Poetics of the Slogan*

Itoi's mature style was formed in the orbit of a single patron. Seiji Tsutsumi (1927–2013), head of the Seibu retail empire, later the Saison group, was simultaneously a business magnate and, under the pen name Takashi Tsujii, a novelist and poet. Seibu's department stores trailed the old houses of Mitsukoshi, Takashimaya, and Isetan in prestige, and Tsutsumi's answer, as Itoi has recalled it, was to sell not goods but new culture. The group built an ecosystem for the purpose: the Parco fashion buildings in Ikebukuro and Shibuya, the Seibu Museum of Art (1975), bookshops in which contemporary theory was shelved beside fashion, record shops, and, in 1980, Mujirushi Ryōhin—"no-brand quality goods," the brand whose name is the negation of branding. The Saison milieu was also the commercial home of the "New Academism" of the early 1980s: Akira Asada's *Kōzō to chikara* (*Structure and Power*, 1983) and *Tōsōron* (*Escape Theory*, 1984), with its celebration of the nomadic "schizo kid" who flees the paranoid accumulation of the salaryman, and Shin'ichi Nakazawa's *Chibetto no Mōtsaruto* (*Mozart in Tibet*, 1983), which carried Tibetan Buddhist esotericism into the Japanese theory boom. Itoi has described 1980 as the year in which what had been subculture—manga, anime, comic performance, the fan conventions then acquiring their names—became the mainstream. The copywriter stood at the junction of department store, theory, and subculture, and the slogan was the form in which the three met.

Itoi's slogans share a formal signature: they end in the Japanese full stop, the *kuten* (。). 「不思議、大好き。」「おいしい生活。」「くうねるあそぶ。」「生きろ。」 A noun phrase closed with a full stop is not a label but an utterance. The stop converts a phrase into a completed speech act, delivered by someone to someone, with a breath at its end. The *kuten* functions much as the cutting-word (*kireji*) functions in haiku: it severs the phrase from its surroundings and leaves a resonant silence in which the addressee is expected to respond. The analogy is

Table 2.1 Itoi's career and postwar Japan, 1948–1998

Itoi		Japan
Born in Maebashi, Gunma (10 Nov.)	1948	Occupation (1945–52); the baby boom (1947–49)
Hōsei University; drawn into the student movement	1968–69	*Zenkyōtō* university occupations; siege of Yasuda Auditorium (Jan. 1969)
Tokyo Copywriters Club New Face Award (Tomen Apparel)	1975	Slower growth after the 1973 oil shock
Lyrics for "TOKIO"	1980	Mujirushi Ryōhin launched within the Seibu Saison group
「不思議、大好き。」(Seibu); 「僕の君は世界一。」(Parco); *Yume de aimashō* with Murakami	1981	Saison culture at its height
「おいしい生活。」(Seibu)	1982	Murakami, *A Wild Sheep Chase*
Figurehead of the copywriter boom	1983	Tokyo Disneyland opens (Apr.); Asada, *Kōzō to chikara*
「想像力と数百円」(Shinchō Bunko)	1984	Asada, *Tōsōron*
—	1985	Plaza Accord (Sept.); the yen begins to rise
—	1986	*Dragon Quest* (May); the asset bubble begins
「くうねるあそぶ。」(Nissan Cefiro); voice of the father in *Totoro*	1988	The emperor's illness; *jishuku* (from Sept.)
Mother (July)	1989	Shōwa ends (7 Jan.); the Nikkei peaks (29 Dec.)
Mother 2 in development	1990–91	The bubble collapses; land prices peak (1991)
Mother 2 (27 Aug.)	1994	The "lost decade"; Matsumoto sarin attack (June)
EarthBound in North America (5 June)	1995	Hanshin earthquake (Jan.); Tokyo subway sarin attack (Mar.)
Hobonichi Itoi Shinbun founded (June)	1998	The banking crisis deepens after the failures of 1997

The two lines run side by side; gold marks the years of *Mother*, *Mother* 2, and *EarthBound*.

not ornamental. Japanese copy of the 1980s inherited from haikai poetry its brevity, its seasonal rhythm (department-store campaigns turned with the seasons), its cut, and its orientation toward a reader who completes the verse. Itoi even conducted, in the weekly *Shūkan Bunshun*, a reader-participation column, *Itoi Shigesato no banryū kopī juku*, in which readers submitted copy for his judgment—a practice closer to the communal "seat" (*za*) of linked verse than to the solitary craft of the agency.

「不思議、大好き。」 (1981) consecrates wonder. *Fushigi* names the strange, the uncanny, the inexplicable; *daisuki* is the predicate of a child's unguarded love. The sentence has no grammatical subject, and in Japanese none is needed: the implied speaker is at once the store, the copywriter, and the reader, who finds the confession of love already made in his or her name. The slogan does not promise that the store contains wonders. It addresses the reader as someone capable of loving wonder and thereby, in Althusser's sense, recruits the reader into that identity. It is the earliest public formulation of the disposition on which the *Mother* series rests.

「おいしい生活。」 (1982) is more complex. Itoi has stated that the phrase derives from the Japanese title of Federico Fellini's *La dolce vita* (1960), released in Japan as 『甘い生活』, *Amai seikatsu*, "sweet life." The substitution of *oishii* for *amai* is the whole poem. *Amai* names a taste and carries a moral ambiguity: it can mean indulgent, naive, spoiled. *Oishii* is an evaluation, and a social one; it is what one says at table, very often to the person who cooked. The adjective itself began in the private idiom of the court ladies (*nyōbō kotoba*), the honorific o- joined to an older *ishii*, "good"—a word of the inner rooms before it became a word of the market. Itoi's slogan thus translated Fellini's decadent sweetness into domestic gratitude and offered it for sale. Section 2.6 returns to Fellini's film, whose ending, it will be argued, *EarthBound* reverses.

The American matrix of Itoi's imagination is, in at least one case, directly attested. His 1981 slogan for Parco, 「僕の君は世界一。」 ("My you is the best in the world"), took its theme of *sekai-ichi*, "best in the world," from the American family television broadcast in Japan during Itoi's childhood, notably *The Donna Reed Show*, aired as *Uchi no mama wa sekai-ichi*, "Our Mom Is the Best in the World." The grammar of the slogan is extraordinary: *boku no kimi*, "my you," is a possessive second person, the most intimate vocative Japanese can construct. The source is equally telling. It is a suburban American sitcom

whose title, in its Japanese form, praised the mother. The household of *EarthBound*—a mother at home, a father elsewhere—is already present in the television that taught a Japanese copywriter what an American home looked like.

Two later lines complete the repertoire. 「想像力と数百円」 ("Imagination, and a few hundred yen," 1984), for the Shinchō Bunko paperback series—a line Itoi has said he set out to make an imperishable classic—names the price of a book with candid modesty beside the faculty the book unlocks, staging the exchange of commodity and imagination without concealing either term. And 「くうねるあそぶ。」 ("Eat, sleep, play," 1988), for the Nissan Cefiro sedan, reduces the good life to three verbs without subject or object; Itoi has recalled that the phrase began as the name of a private members' club. In the television commercial the singer Yōsui Inoue turned to the camera with a greeting, 「みなさん、お元気ですか」 ("Is everyone well?"). The campaign launched in the autumn of 1988, just as the Shōwa Emperor's final illness plunged the country into a mood of "self-restraint" (*jishuku*) in which broadcasters cancelled festivities and rearranged their schedules. In a widely recalled emblem of those months, the greeting was muted, and the singer's lips moved without sound. In the year before *Mother*, Itoi's vocative was silenced by the sovereign's dying body; a public greeting had become unspeakable.

The three verbs of the Cefiro campaign, meanwhile, name with uncanny exactness the procedural gravity of *EarthBound*. Ness eats—hamburgers, pizza, his mother's steak—to survive. He sleeps, in hotels and finally in his own bed, to recover. And he plays, since the game is play. An automobile advertisement that sold a life of eating, sleeping, and playing became, six years later, the triad on which a child's survival depends.

The theory of advertising offers terms for what Itoi was doing and for what he would undo. Raymond Williams called advertising "the magic system" (1960): a structure of magical inducements that attaches social meanings to commodities because the society cannot otherwise satisfy the needs those meanings name. Roland Barthes's *Mythologies* (1957) and Marshall McLuhan's *The Mechanical Bride* (1951) had already read the advertisement as modern myth. Judith Williamson's *Decoding Advertisements* (1978) applied Althusser's concept of interpellation directly: the advertisement hails a "you," offers that "you" an identity, and closes its circuit when the viewer recognizes himself or herself in the address. Itoi's copy is perhaps the most

refined practice of the magic system that postwar Japan produced. It rarely names a product; it addresses the reader as someone capable of wonder, appetite, love, and life. Yet its vector remained the vector of advertising: from the corporation toward the consumer, an offer. The question pursued in the rest of this chapter is what happened to that vector when the economy that sustained it collapsed.

2.3 *Eagleland as Hyperreal: Simulation, Occupation, and Armchair Nostalgia*

The world of *EarthBound* is called Eagleland, after the emblem of the American republic, and its towns are numbered as if they were levels of a game: Onett, Twoson (a pun on Tucson), Threed, Fourside. Beyond them lie places named for seasons, Summers and Winters. In the Japanese original every one of these names is a katakana loanword, foreign to the eye before it is read. The world is assembled from American signs: drugstores and burger shops, a hotel in every town, a bus line, a police chief infatuated with his own authority, a soul revue in dark suits and hats, a haunted tent, a ghost town overrun by zombies, a desert highway frozen in a traffic jam, a department store, a tycoon's tower, a seaside resort with a museum and a beach. The America so assembled corresponds to no region of the actual United States. It is an America of the screen—the America of postwar Japanese television, cinema, comics, and records—recombined.

That America has a history. The Occupation, which John Dower in *Embracing Defeat* (1999) described as a revolution from above whose reforms the Japanese public adopted with startling enthusiasm, left behind not only a constitution but an image of affluence. In the late 1950s and 1960s Japanese television broadcast American family series—*Father Knows Best*, *The Donna Reed Show*, *Lassie*, *Bewitched*—whose suburban kitchens displayed the refrigerators, washing machines, and automobiles that Japanese households were then acquiring as the "three sacred treasures" and, later, the "3C." Shun'ya Yoshimi's *Shinbei to hanbei* (*Pro-America and Anti-America*, 2007) argues that "America" functioned in postwar Japan as a structure of the political unconscious, divided between a visible America of consumer goods and media and a concealed America of bases and violence, the latter pushed to the margins of national consciousness and, above all, to Okinawa. Eagleland reproduces the division with

precision. It has drugstores, hotels, burger shops, and a department store; it has police, some of them corrupt; it has no visible army, no base, and no war. It is the consumer America without the military America: the America the postwar Japanese child was permitted to see.

The theory of that permitted America is Jean Baudrillard's. In *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) he argued that Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest of America is real, when the surrounding country belongs to the same order of simulation—the hyperreal, the generation by models of a real without origin. Umberto Eco, crossing the same landscape in the 1970s, found an American appetite for the "absolute fake," the copy more perfect than any original. Japan imported this order in its purest form in April 1983, when Tokyo Disneyland opened on reclaimed land at Urayasu, a sealed world whose berms shut out any view of the city around it. If Disneyland is America's simulation of itself, Tokyo Disneyland is Japan's simulation of that simulation, and Eagleland, a decade later, is a construction of the third order: an America composed from American media by a Japanese copywriter for Japanese children. Baudrillard's *Amérique* (1986) called the United States the original version of modernity and Europe its dubbed or subtitled version. In those terms Eagleland is a dub that has forgotten its original and become, for its players, an original in its own right.

Fredric Jameson's account of postmodern culture supplies the next term. Pastiche, he argued, is "blank parody": imitation without the satiric impulse and without the norm against which parody measures its object. Its characteristic genre is the nostalgia film, of which *American Graffiti* (1973) is the paradigm, a genre that renders not the past but our images of the past. Arjun Appadurai, in *Modernity at Large* (1996), carried the analysis to its limit with the concept of "armchair nostalgia": nostalgia without lived experience or collective historical memory, supplied entirely by mass media. His emblem was the Filipino performers who render American popular songs of earlier decades with uncanny fidelity, nostalgic for a world they never lost. Eagleland is armchair nostalgia in its purest form. Its Japanese players of 1994 longed for an Onett they had never inhabited; its American players, meeting the game decades later, long for an America that never existed and for the childhood in which they first walked through it. The game's nostalgia is doubly unanchored. It belongs neither to the place it depicts nor to the people who depicted it.

Japanese theory had its own vocabulary for the condition. Eiji Ōtsuka's *Monogatari shōhi-ron* (*A Theory of Narrative Consumption*, 1989) took as its case the Bikkuriman stickers packaged with Lotte chocolate wafers, each bearing a fragment of a vast mythology of angels and devils that children collected in order to reconstruct the hidden whole. What was consumed, Ōtsuka argued, was not the object but the "grand narrative" behind it, and he predicted that consumers would eventually wish to manufacture that narrative themselves. Hiroki Azuma, a decade later, described a further mutation: the decline of grand narratives in favour of a database of affective elements recombined at will, a "grand nonnarrative." Azuma drew on Alexandre Kojève's celebrated footnote, added to the 1962 edition of his lectures on Hegel after a visit to Japan, which contrasted the post-historical American, returned to animality and the satisfaction of needs, with the Japanese "snob," who maintains pure forms emptied of historical content. *EarthBound* sits precisely at the junction these theorists describe. Its world is a database of American signs, and it is collected in fragments: eight melodies, a sequence of photographs, a sea of stray lines of dialogue. Yet the fragments are bound by a narrative of a peculiar kind—not a mythology to be reconstructed but a call to be answered. Kojève's dichotomy, moreover, fits it uncannily. The program of the post-historical animal is exactly 「くうねるあそぶ。」: eat, sleep, play. The game renders that animal program with the formal, self-delighting comedy of the snob.

The decisive difference between Eagleland and the hyperreal as Baudrillard conceived it lies in address. Jameson's blank pastiche speaks to no one. Baudrillard's simulation culminates in the "silent majorities" of *À l'ombre des majorités silencieuses* (1978): masses that absorb every message and return none, a sink into which the social disappears—an image Baudrillard himself drew from the astrophysics of collapse. Eagleland, by contrast, is spoken. Every inhabitant addresses the player; the land's sacred places are called "Your Sanctuary"; the narration pauses, over a cup of coffee, to speak to the player directly about the journey so far. The game's America is hyperreal, but it is not blank. It is a *sincere simulacrum*: a world made entirely of copies, each of which is addressed to someone. And the absorbing mass that Baudrillard described as the endpoint of simulation reappears in the game as its antagonist—the vortex of noise that swallows every signal—to be met, at the end, by the reply that Baudrillard believed could no longer come.

The Missing Archipelago: Kōjin Karatani and the Discovery of Landscape 2.4

One feature of Itoi's world is so obvious that it is rarely remarked: Japan is not in it. The map of *EarthBound* comprises Eagleland, a snowbound north, a resort coast, a desert kingdom of pyramids, a Himalayan principality, a swamp, a prehistoric underworld, a valley of gentle and unclassifiable creatures, and an interior continent made of memory. There is no Japanese town, no shrine, no rice paddy, no Japanese name. Japanese culture appears only displaced—in the Zen-inflected discipline of Dalaam, in a hot spring in Saturn Valley, in the excruciating bashfulness of the Tenda. The absence is the more striking because Itoi's copy for Studio Ghibli, written in the same years, so insistently located wonder in Japan: *Totoro*'s strange creature still lives in Japan, probably. The game made by the same hand for the same children locates wonder everywhere but there.

Kōjin Karatani's *Nihon kindai bungaku no kigen* (1980; translated as *Origins of Modern Japanese Literature*, 1993) supplies the frame for understanding this absence as constitutive rather than accidental. Karatani argued that landscape (*fūkei*) in the modern sense was not found but discovered in the Meiji period through an inversion (*tentō*) of perception: only a subject who had turned inward, become indifferent to the outer world, could constitute that world as landscape, a scene spread before an interior gaze. His exemplary text is Kunikida Doppo's story "Wasureenu hitobito" ("Unforgettable People," 1898), whose narrator recalls not his friends or teachers but people glimpsed once in passing—a man gathering something on a shore at low tide, a packhorse driver singing on a mountain road—people unforgettable precisely because they were never persons to him at all, only figures in a scene. For Karatani the discovery of landscape and the discovery of interiority are a single event, and he added a third discovery to the pair: the child, which he likewise read as a construction of the same modern inversion.

EarthBound is a discovered landscape in Karatani's exact sense. Its world is America as seen from an interior that does not itself appear, composed by a gaze turned inward toward its own store of images. Its inhabitants are Doppo's unforgettable people: met once, never named, remembered for a single line. The game even lists some of them among its enemies, under names that are nothing but descriptions of figures in a scene—Unassuming Local Guy, Cranky Lady, An-

noying Old Party Man. Magicant, the landscape composed of Ness's memory, is the moment at which the interiority that founded the landscape appears inside it as more landscape: Karatani's inversion made visible and walkable. And the hero is the third discovery, the child, whom the game constructs with the same tenderness and the same distance with which it constructs its America.

Wittgenstein formulated the logic of such a construction in the *Tractatus* (1922). The subject, he wrote, does not belong to the world but is a limit of the world (5.632); one might suppose that the subject stands to the world as the eye to the visual field, but the eye itself is not seen (5.633). Japan stands to Eagleland as the eye stands to the visual field: it is the point from which the world is seen and which, for that very reason, cannot appear in it. The same holds, structurally, for the player, who is the limit of every game's world and never a part of it. Here lies the audacity of the ending of *EarthBound*. Its final prayer addresses the one entity that, by the logic of the picture, could not appear in the picture: the eye, the limit, the subject who sees. It reaches past the edge of the visual field. Wittgenstein closed the *Tractatus* by consigning to silence whatever cannot be said within the world. The game answers by addressing it.

Roland Barthes, in *L'Empire des signes* (1970), observed that Tokyo possesses a centre, but that the centre is empty: the walled and invisible precinct of the Imperial Palace, around which the city turns. Eagleland, too, is organized around an empty centre, the archipelago from which it was imagined and in which it does not appear. The historical coincidence is worth recording without being over-read. The first *Mother* was conceived in the last years of Shōwa and released in the first summer of Heisei. The months of *jishuku* that muted Itoi's Cefiro greeting were the months in which the empty centre of the Japanese polity became, briefly and overwhelmingly, the centre of every broadcast. The world of the *Mother* games was built in the aftermath of that saturation, and it keeps its centre empty.

The absence of Japan also governs how the game's other elsewheres are drawn. Dalaam, a Himalayan principality of meditation and martial discipline, and Scaraba, a desert kingdom of pyramids, sphinx, and bazaar, are rendered in the idiom Stefan Tanaka identified in *Japan's Orient* (1993) as modern Japan's own Orientalism: tōyō, an Asia constructed as the past and the spiritual reserve of Japanese modernity, here refracted through the Tibet of Nakazawa's theory boom and the deserts of Western adventure cinema. Japan, Orientalized by

the West, orientalizes in turn; the game, which removes Japan from its map, retains this double gaze in its margins. Chapter 8 confronts the ethical consequences directly. Here the point is structural. The absent archipelago is the condition of possibility of the whole. The world of *EarthBound* is composed from outside by a subject who cannot enter it—until the end, when that subject is called by name.

Fourside After the Bubble: Debt, Monopoly, and the Grey Men 2.5

Mother 2 was developed through the rise and collapse of one of the largest asset bubbles in modern economic history. After the Plaza Accord of September 1985 drove up the yen, the Bank of Japan's easy money fed speculation in land and equities; at the height of the frenzy, the grounds of Tokyo's Imperial Palace were said to be worth more than all the real estate of California. The Nikkei index peaked on 29 December 1989. The collapse began within weeks; land prices peaked in 1991 and then fell for more than a decade. By the time the game appeared in August 1994 the "lost decade" had begun, and within a year the Hanshin earthquake and the Aum Shinrikyō sarin attack on the Tokyo subway would extinguish the era's remaining confidence. The game was conceived in the bubble and finished in its wreckage.

Fourside, the game's metropolis, can be read as the bubble's afterimage. It is a city of towers reached across a desert, its skyline dominated by the headquarters of a tycoon; it contains a department store, a theatre, cafés and alleys, and a passage into an inverted copy of the city. The department store—the institution in which Itoi had made his name—is the site of one of the game's eeriest episodes: the lights fail, the shoppers vanish, and Ness must fight a spectral boss the game calls the Department Store Spook. The temple of 1980s consumption is haunted. The tycoon is Geldegarde Monotoli, whose given name joins the German *Geld*, money, to a surname that in its Japanese form, *Monotorī*, cannot fail to sound like *monotori*, "thief." Monotoli has come into possession of the Mani Mani Statue, and the statue has come into possession of him; he employs Pokey Minch, the hero's treacherous neighbour, as his adviser. When Ness breaks the statue's power in Moonside, Monotoli recovers his senses and becomes, of all things, kind. The bubble is figured as a possession and its collapse as an exorcism.

Debt pervades the game's cities. The Runaway Five, a soul revue modelled unmistakably on John Landis's *The Blues Brothers* (1980), are held twice in bondage by contracts and debts to theatre owners—at the Chaos Theater in Twoson and the Topolla Theater in Fourside—and are released only through the children's intervention. The comparison with their cinematic models is instructive. Jake and Elwood Blues reunite their band to raise the five thousand dollars in tax owed by the orphanage that raised them, and they describe the enterprise as a mission from God: a debt-payment sanctified. The Runaway Five's liberation is likewise a debt-payment, but it is performed by children for musicians, gratuitously, and it binds the musicians to nothing except gratitude, which they repay by appearing unbidden when the children most need them. A commercial relation becomes a gift relation. The debt is not paid so much as dissolved.

The game's procedures encode the same economy. Ness's money is deposited in a bank account by his father, in proportion to the battles the boy has won, and withdrawn from automated teller machines in every town: violence converted into paternal credit, love translated into money and transmitted at a distance. Knowledge, too, is for sale; towns have hint shops where advice can be purchased. In Twoson one boy inventor solicits the player's investment in a scheme that yields nothing, while a second boy inventor, poor and earnest, produces devices that will help to save the world: speculation and invention, the bubble and the work, side by side. Georg Simmel's *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900) described money as the purest means, the instrument that makes the distant near and the near distant, mediating relations across any interval. In this sense the father's deposits are the first form of telephonic grace the game presents—support arriving from afar—and its most ambiguous. They are real help, and they are also the substitution of a transfer for a presence. The father who saves the game is the father who sends money: an archive and a cash machine.

Walter Benjamin's fragment "Kapitalismus als Religion" (1921) proposed that capitalism is a pure cult without dogma, celebrated without pause, and the first cult to produce guilt rather than to expiate it—the German *Schuld* meaning both guilt and debt. David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) traced the same equivalence through the moral vocabularies of the world's religions, noting how often the oldest prayers of forgiveness are framed as the cancellation of debts; in the Gospel of Matthew, the Lord's Prayer asks that "our debts" be forgiven as we forgive "our debtors." Read against this background, the

final prayer of *EarthBound* is notable for what it does not do. It does not bargain, does not promise, and incurs no obligation. It asks for help and creates no debt. It is the one transaction in the game that lies outside the economy of credit.

The most precise literary analogue for Fourside's economy is Michael Ende's *Momo* (1973), a novel whose Japanese reception was exceptional and whose author married his Japanese translator, Mariko Satō, in 1989. In *Momo* the grey gentlemen of the Time-Savings Bank persuade the inhabitants of a city to "save" time for the future. The time is in fact stolen; the city becomes efficient and joyless; the children forget how to play. Momo's only power is to listen, and with it she restores the stolen hours. Ende's critique of money continued to the end of his life, and its Japanese afterlife included an NHK documentary on his views of money and interest, *Ende no yuigon* ("Ende's Testament," 1999). The grey gentlemen are the allegorical form of an economy that harvests time and attention; Momo's listening is attention returned as a gift. The opposition anticipates the one on which *EarthBound* will close.

The collapse of the bubble also changed the economics of Itoi's own profession. The copywriter boom of the 1980s ended with the money that had paid for it, and the culture of the 1990s turned toward what the Japanese media called *iyashi*, "healing," and toward the small, the daily, and the free. Itoi's founding of *Hobonichi Itoi Shinbun* in 1998—a website free to read, updated almost daily, organized around the small words of ordinary life—is the post-bubble form of his address. *Mother 2* stands between the department store and the website. It is the work in which the vocative of the bubble years, cut loose from the economy that had funded it, searches for another destination.

Counter-Copy: From the Slogan to the Supplication 2.6

The concept toward which this chapter has been moving can now be stated. Advertising's address has three constitutive features. Its *vector* runs from seller to buyer. Its *content* is an offer of satisfaction. And it constitutes its *addressee* as a subject of lack: a "you" who will recognize in the offer the object of a desire the advertisement has helped to produce. *Counter-copy* reverses all three. Its vector runs from those in need toward an absent other. Its content is a supplication rather than an offer. And it constitutes its addressee not as a subject of lack but as a source of grace—a "you" whose attention, freely given, is

what the speaker most needs. Counter-copy is not anti-advertising. It is neither the no-brand of Mujirushi, which negates branding by branding the negation, nor the ironic self-deprecation of the American campaign that told consumers "This game stinks." It preserves everything formal about copy—brevity, the second person, intimacy, the full stop, the expectation of response—and reverses the direction in which value flows.

Itoi's best copy had always strained toward this reversal. 「生きろ。」 sells nothing; it commands life. 「不思議、大好き。」 confesses rather than promises. The hedging *tabun* of the Totoro line withholds the certainty that selling requires. But a slogan on a poster cannot complete the reversal, because it remains embedded in an exchange. A game can. In *EarthBound* the copywriter's micro-texts are distributed across a world, every one addressed to the player and none of them selling anything; the sacred places of the earth are given to the player in the second-person possessive, "Your Sanctuary"; and the decisive utterance of the game is a request for help addressed to the player by name. The form of copy remains. The commodity has vanished from inside it.

The genealogy of 「おいしい生活。」 permits a further, homological observation. Fellini's *La dolce vita*, from whose Japanese title Itoi drew his most famous slogan, is framed by two failures of address, both caused by noise. In its opening sequence a helicopter carries a statue of Christ over Rome while a second helicopter, bearing the journalist Marcello and his photographer Paparazzo, hovers above a rooftop of sunbathing women; Marcello shouts down to them, asking for a telephone number, and the roar of the rotors swallows the exchange. In its final sequence, at dawn on a beach where fishermen have hauled in a monstrous dead fish, Marcello sees across a narrow inlet the young waitress Paola, whose innocence he had glimpsed earlier. She calls to him, gesturing, and the surf and wind carry her words away. He shrugs that he cannot hear and turns back to his companions; she watches him go. The film's portrait of a society given over to spectacle and appetite is bracketed by a sacred image become aerial publicity at one end and, at the other, a girl's call drowned by noise.

The young woman who calls across the noise and is not heard is named Paola. The girl who, at the end of *EarthBound*, prays across the noise and is heard is named Paula. No claim is made that Itoi named his heroine after Fellini's; there is no evidence for it, and the argument does not require it. The claim is structural, and it is exact. The

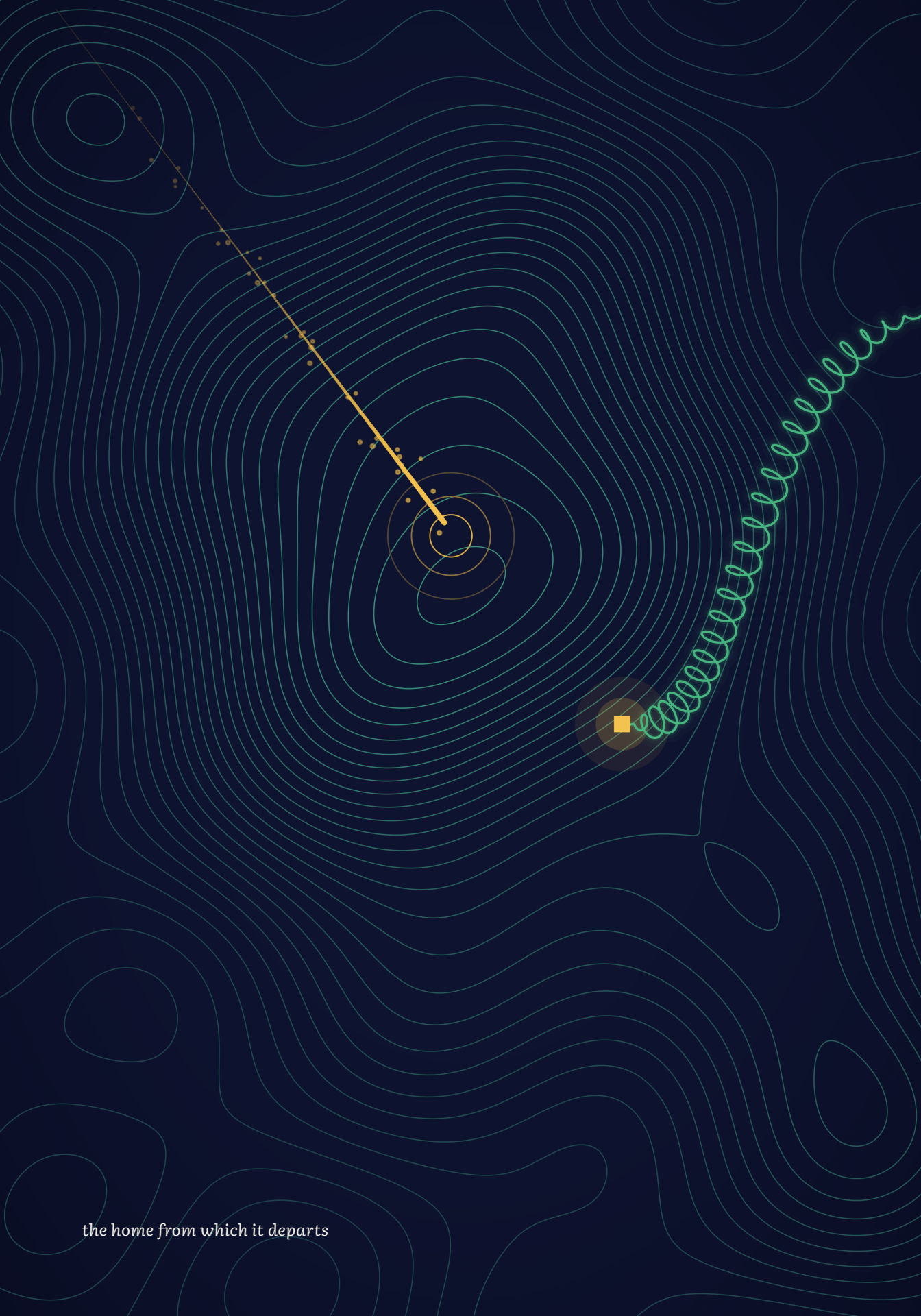
slogan that made Itoi famous was lifted from a film about a society in which calls cannot be heard, and the game he made at the end of that society's Japanese incarnation concludes with a call that crosses the noise. The film's other emblem is reversed as well. Fellini's Paparazzo, whose name gave the world its word for the predatory photographer, hunts images to sell; *EarthBound*'s roving photographer descends unbidden to take the children's picture at the landmarks of their journey, and his photographs are given back to the player, free, as the credits roll. If *La dolce vita* is the allegory of the failed address in the age of spectacle, *EarthBound* is its inversion. Counter-copy, in its most compressed definition, is the reversal of Fellini's ending.

The substance at stake in this reversal is attention. Herbert Simon observed in 1971 that a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention; Michael Goldhaber, in 1997, named the resulting order an "attention economy"; and Tim Wu's *The Attention Merchants* (2016) traced its history from the penny press through broadcast advertising to the platforms of the present. Advertising was the original attention merchant, and the copywriter its most skilled artisan. Simone Weil had named the opposite pole. In her wartime essay on the right use of school studies she argued that the true purpose of education is the formation of attention, because prayer consists of attention; and in the notebooks collected as *La Pesanteur et la grâce* she held that attention, taken to its highest degree, is the same thing as prayer. Momo's listening, in Ende's parable, is attention of this kind. Counter-copy is the procedure by which attention—the commodity the copywriter was paid to capture—is converted back into the faculty Weil identified with prayer. Chapter 7 shows how the final battle performs this conversion step by step.

An objection presents itself at once. *EarthBound* is itself a commodity, sold by one of the world's largest entertainment corporations; whatever counter-copy it contains is packaged, priced, and marketed. Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer's analysis of the culture industry in *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1947) would predict that any such reversal is absorbed in advance by the form that delivers it. The objection is serious, and it can be answered but not dissolved. Counter-copy does not stand outside the commodity form; it works within it, as Serres's parasite works within a channel—a perturbation that the system carries without being able to neutralize, and which may, as Serres argued of noise in general, become the seed of a new order. The history of the game's reception bears this out. Its American market-

ing failed. Its call was carried instead by testimony, by players who wrote years later of the night the game said their name. Counter-copy circulates not by advertisement but by witness.

The copywriter’s cosmos, then, is a world made of addresses: composed from outside by a subject it cannot depict, built from the signs of an America seen on television, and haunted by the economy that collapsed while it was being made. Its fall is the bubble; its redemption, as the following chapters argue, is the prayer. But before a call can travel, it must depart from somewhere. Chapter 3 turns to the place from which every call in *EarthBound* begins and to which every call returns: the house on the hill.


the home from which it departs

3

"The House on the Hill"

Gravity, Home, and the Domestic Sublime

> "Knock, and it shall be opened unto you."
>
> *Luke 11:9 (King James Version)*

> *L'enracinement est peut-être le besoin le plus important et le plus méconnu de l'âme humaine.*
>
> *Simone Weil, L'Enracinement (1949)*

EVERY CALL IN EARTHBOUND begins and ends at a single house. It stands on a hill above Onett; it is the first place the player sees and the last; and it receives the two summonses that bracket the game: a neighbour's knock in the middle of the night at the beginning, and, after the credits, a second knock bearing that neighbour's taunting letter. This chapter argues that the house is not the backdrop of the adventure but its first coordinate—gravity joined to address—and that the game's distinctive sublimity is domestic: cosmic forces are approached from a home, measured against it, and finally reabsorbed into it. The chapter considers the meteor's intrusion into the small town (3.1); the philosophy of dwelling in Bachelard, Heidegger, and Weil (3.2); homesickness as a procedure (3.3); the asymmetry of mother and father (3.4); the failed house next door (3.5); and the domestic sublime as an anti-uncanny (3.6).

3.1 The Meteor in the Backyard: Cosmic Intrusion and the Small Town

The game opens at night, inside the house. A crash shakes the hill above Onett. The boy wakes, goes out in his pyjamas, is turned back by a police cordon on the road up the slope, and returns home, where he is invited to go back to sleep. Then comes the knock; and before he may answer it properly, his mother has him change out of his pyjamas. The first world the player learns is therefore the distance between a bedroom and a crater: a staircase, a front door, a path past the neighbour's yard, a slope. The first hostile creatures are a backyard bestiary—a stray dog, a crow, a snake—made vicious by an influence no one can yet name. The cosmos, in *EarthBound*, does not descend upon a temple, a castle, or a capital. It lands behind a house.

The meteorite has a long history as a message from the sky. The oldest meteorite whose fall was witnessed and whose stone survives came down at Nōgata, in northern Kyushu, in 861, and was preserved as a sacred object at a local shrine; the stone that fell at Ensisheim in Alsace in 1492 was hung in the parish church and read as a portent. *EarthBound* takes the old interpretation literally: its meteorite contains a messenger. Buzz Buzz, the insect-like visitor who crawls out of the rock, is an *angelos* in the strict etymological sense, a bearer of tidings. He announces a prophecy, assigns a vocation, entrusts the boy with the Sound Stone, and dies almost as soon as his message is delivered, swatted by the neighbour's mother. The cosmic, here, arrives first as address.

The scene belongs to a lineage this dissertation calls the *suburban cosmic*, in which the vastness of the universe enters the smallest unit of settled life. Ray Bradbury's Green Town, Illinois—the setting of *Dandelion Wine* (1957) and *Something Wicked This Way Comes* (1962)—is its classic locale: a town where a boy discovers in a summer field that he is alive, and where, one October, a carnival arrives whose proprietor trades in stolen years. Bradbury resolves the second novel through a father, Charles Halloway, the ageing library janitor who defeats the carnival's master with laughter. Tove Jansson's *Kometjakten* (*Comet in Moominland*, 1946), written in the shadow of the war, sends two young creatures to a distant observatory to learn whether a comet will destroy their valley and brings them home to a mother who keeps the household going under a burning sky. Steven Spielberg's *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial* (1982) lands its visitor behind a suburban house in

California, where a boy whose father has recently left the family hides him in a closet. Stephen King's *It* (1986) gives a small town in Maine an ancient predator that the adults cannot or will not see, leaving the children to face it alone.

In each of these works the intruder takes a definite form: a temptation to be resisted, a disaster to be survived, a friend to be sent home, a predator to be destroyed. In *EarthBound* it takes the form of a vocation. The meteorite does not threaten the boy; it calls him. The difference extends to the adults. King's Derry is complicit, its grown-ups willfully blind to the violence around them. Onett is afflicted: as Giygas's influence spreads, its dogs bite, its crows jeer, and its police force turns officious and, eventually, hostile. But the boy's own household is untouched. His mother remains entirely herself, and the house remains a sanctuary. The cosmic call comes from the hill above the house—close enough to be reached on foot from the front door—and the house itself is never breached.

The point is sharpened by comparison with the first game. *Mother* (1989) opened with an intrusion inside the home: a poltergeist that sets a lamp upon the boy in his own house, a scene that recalls Tobe Hooper's *Poltergeist* (1982), produced by Spielberg, in which the television static of a planned suburb becomes the portal through which a child is taken. *Mother* 2 relocates the intrusion from the interior to the hill outside. This relocation is the first sign of the game's domestic theology. The house will not be the site of horror; it will be the fixed point from which horror is approached.

Onett itself is a complete small town in miniature: a mayor, a police chief infatuated with his own authority, a gang of delinquents headquartered in an arcade, a library, a drugstore, a hotel, a burger shop, a hint shop. Its moral weather is legible. When the influence of Giygas thickens, the town frays; when the boy confronts its local evils, they are often converted rather than destroyed, so that the leader of the arcade gang, once defeated, becomes an unexpected source of restoration. The Japanese summer of 1994 offers a revealing counterpoint. In July, a month before *Mother* 2 appeared, Studio Ghibli released Isao Takahata's *Heisei tanuki gassen Ponpoko* (*Pom Poko*), an elegy for the hills west of Tokyo that were being levelled for the vast planned suburb of Tama New Town, and for the creatures displaced by the bulldozers. Onett, by contrast, keeps a wild hill above its houses. It is on that hill, the one place the suburb has left unbuilt, that the cosmos can land.

3.2 *Bachelard's Cellar, Heidegger's Dwelling, Weil's Gravity*

Gaston Bachelard's *La Poétique de l'espace* (1957) begins with the house, "our corner of the world," which he called our first universe, a cosmos in every sense of the word. The house, for Bachelard, shelters daydreaming and protects the dreamer; the house in which we were born is physically inscribed in us as a set of organic habits. And the house is vertical. Its cellar is the dark, irrational substratum where fears are buried; its attic is the zone of light and rational clarity under the roof. *EarthBound* extends Bachelard's verticality into cosmology. Above the house rises the hill on which the message from the sky has fallen. Below the inhabited surface lie the caves of the sanctuaries, the Lost Underworld, and finally the Cave of the Past, where Giygas waits. The world has an attic and a cellar, and the house stands on the axis between them.

Martin Heidegger's lecture "Bauen Wohnen Denken" (1951), delivered at a Darmstadt colloquium on the theme of man and space amid the housing shortage of postwar Germany, made dwelling the basic character of human existence: to be a mortal on the earth is to dwell. Dwelling, for Heidegger, gathers the fourfold of earth, sky, divinities, and mortals. Mortals dwell in that they save the earth, receive the sky as sky, await the divinities as divinities, and accompany their own nature, the capacity for death. Saving (*retten*), he insisted, does not mean merely rescuing something from danger; it means setting something free into its own presencing. Heidegger's late thought took as one of its mottoes Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos": *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*—where danger is, the saving power also grows. The coincidence with the vocabulary of games is accidental, but it is not empty. In *EarthBound* a save is not a mechanical act performed at a crystal or a shrine. It is a relation, accomplished by calling the father, who holds the child's journey in being so that it may continue. Chapter 5 returns to Heidegger's fourfold, which the game's four children embody with surprising precision.

Heidegger's rhetoric of dwelling, with its Black Forest farmhouse and its pieties of soil, provoked two of the most consequential critiques in postwar philosophy. Theodor Adorno's *Jargon der Eigentlichkeit* (1964) dissected its idiom as an ideology of authenticity. Emmanuel Levinas, in the essay "Heidegger, Gagarine et nous" (1961), went further, welcoming Yuri Gagarin's orbit of the earth as a liberation from what he called the superstition of Place, the pagan

enchantment of rootedness that sets the native against the stranger. *EarthBound*'s house escapes both the enchantment and the critique. It is rooted, but not in blood or soil. Eagleland has no ancestors, no graves of forefathers, no national myth; Ness's house stands on a suburban lot in a country assembled from television. Its rootedness consists entirely of relations: a mother, a sister, a dog, a telephone line. It is a home of address rather than a home of earth, rooted in the line rather than in the land.

Simone Weil supplies the vocabulary that Heidegger lacks. *L'Enracinement*, written in London in 1943 for the Free French and published posthumously in 1949, opens its account of the soul's needs by calling rootedness perhaps the most important and least recognized of them. A human being is rooted, Weil argued, through real, active, and natural participation in a community that preserves certain treasures of the past and certain expectations for the future; uprootedness is the characteristic disease of modern workers, of peasants, and of the colonized. In *La Pesanteur et la grâce* she gave the intermediaries of rootedness a name borrowed from Plato's *Symposium*: *metaxu*, the "between." Home, country, traditions, and culture are metaxu. They warm and nourish the soul; they are relative goods and must never be mistaken for the absolute; but it is a crime to deprive anyone of them. The house of *EarthBound* is metaxu exactly. It cannot defeat Giygas and cannot answer the cosmic question. Without it, however, the soul cannot sustain the journey. In the quaternity of Chapter 1, the quadrant of home—gravity joined to address—is the place of the metaxu.

The Japanese context gives this structure a sharper edge. Marilyn Ivy's *Discourses of the Vanishing* (1995) analysed the commodification of nostalgia in postwar Japan, from the national railways' "Discover Japan" campaign of 1970 to the *furusato* ("old home town") boom of the 1980s, which reached a bureaucratic apotheosis in 1988–89 when the government of Noboru Takeshita gave every municipality in the country one hundred million yen to revitalize its sense of home. At the same time the bubble was pricing the salaryman's dream of a detached house of his own—*mai hōmu*, "my home"—beyond reach in the great cities. Ness's house, detached, with a yard, a dog, and a hill behind it, is that dream relocated to an American slope. It is also the one place in the game where everything is free. Hotels charge for a night's rest; at home, sleep and food cost nothing. In a world that runs on money, the house is the enclave of the gift.

3.3 Homesickness as Mechanic: Attachment, Fort-Da, and "Phone Home"

Most status ailments in role-playing games are bodily: poison, paralysis, sleep, confusion. *EarthBound* has these too, with characteristic domestic inflections—sunstroke, colds, nausea, a mushroom sprouting from the head. But one ailment is peculiar to Ness and is not bodily at all. If the boy goes too long without speaking to his mother, he may become homesick, and in battle he will sometimes lose his turn, absorbed in thoughts of home. The condition is cured not by medicine but by a telephone call to his mother, or by going home. Homesickness is the game's one purely relational ailment: caused by an absence, cured by a voice. It is the earliest procedural statement of telephonic grace.

John Bowlby's three-volume *Attachment and Loss* (1969–80) recast the child's tie to its mother as a behavioural system of evolutionary origin whose function is to maintain proximity to a protective figure. Its central concept, elaborated in Mary Ainsworth's observational studies of infants in what she called the Strange Situation, is the *secure base*: the attachment figure from whom the child ventures out to explore and to whom it returns when alarmed. Bowlby stressed that the attachment and exploratory systems are antithetical. When attachment is activated—by separation, fatigue, or fear—exploration is suspended until proximity is restored. The homesickness mechanic is an exact procedural rendering of this principle. A homesick Ness does not lose hit points; he loses initiative. The activation of attachment inhibits action. James Robertson's film *A Two-Year-Old Goes to Hospital* (1952), made in association with Bowlby, documented the phases through which a separated child passes: protest, despair, detachment. Ness never passes beyond the first, because the telephone never lets him.

The journey of *EarthBound* is, in these terms, a Strange Situation on the scale of a world. The telephone permits what attachment theory calls proximity maintenance across any distance, by voice alone, and the game's portrait of a child who ranges across deserts and continents precisely because he can always call home is the clinical picture of secure attachment. The far-flung adventure is not opposed to the tie with home. It is grounded in it.

D. W. Winnicott's paper "The Capacity to Be Alone" (1958) argued that the ability to be alone, among the surest signs of emotional ma-

turity, rests on a paradox: it is founded on the experience of having been alone, as an infant, in the presence of someone. The mother who is there but does not intrude allows the child to discover solitude without abandonment. Ness's journey is a solitude of exactly this kind. He travels far from home, but always in the presence of a mother who can be reached. Winnicott's earlier paper on transitional objects (1953) described the blanket or soft toy that the infant clutches, the first "not-me" possession, which occupies an intermediate area between inner and outer reality; Charles Schulz's Linus made the "security blanket" a phrase of everyday speech in the same years. Ness's baseball cap and bat—the equipment of play turned into the instruments of a quest—are transitional objects promoted to weapons. But the telephone is the transitional object par excellence: a thing that is the mother and not the mother, her voice without her body, a presence carried in an absence.

Freud's *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) contains the most famous game in the history of psychoanalysis. His eighteen-month-old grandson, a good child who did not cry when his mother left him, played with a wooden reel tied to a string, throwing it over the edge of his curtained cot with a long "o-o-o-o" that the adults understood as *fort*, "gone," and drawing it back with a joyful *da*, "there." Freud read the game as the child's mastery of his mother's departures: what he had suffered passively he now staged actively, as a game of disappearance and return. Lacan later made the scene the emblem of the child's entry into the symbolic order, in which presence and absence are articulated by a pair of phonemes. *EarthBound* is *fort-da* on the scale of a world. Ness goes away and comes back, and the telephone is the string tied to the reel. The save, performed by calling the father, and the cure for homesickness, performed by calling the mother, are the two ends of a single cord. The game, as Freud said of play in general, turns a suffering into a mastery: the player decides when to leave and when to call.

Popular culture had already given homesickness its emblematic sentences. In E.T., the stranded visitor assembles a communicator from a Speak & Spell, an umbrella, and a record player in order to "phone home," and his body sickens as his separation lengthens, drawing the boy who loves him into a mirrored illness. *EarthBound* inverts the structure. In Spielberg's film the alien longs for home and the human child befriends him; in Itoi's game the human child leaves home and phones it, while the alien, Giygas, is the one being

in the cosmos with no home to call. The other emblematic sentence belongs to Dorothy Gale, who in Victor Fleming's *The Wizard of Oz* (1939) returns to Kansas by repeating that there is no place like home. L. Frank Baum's Dorothy (1900) is an orphan raised by an aunt and uncle on a grey prairie. Her home is a home of care rather than of blood, and she returns to it by an utterance. Baum's book also contains the counter-image to which Chapter 4 returns: the Wizard, a humbug who projects an awful power from behind a screen—in the film, a curtain his audience is commanded to ignore—and who is counterfeit grace in its purest form.

Japanese psychology supplies the last term. Takeo Doi's *Amae no kōzō* (1971), a bestseller translated as *The Anatomy of Dependence*, placed at the centre of Japanese emotional life the concept of *amae*: the desire to depend upon, and presume upon, another's benevolence, whose prototype is the infant's relation to its mother. Doi argued that Japanese social life is organized around the permission and the frustration of that desire. Read through Doi, homesickness is the deprivation of *amae*, and the telephone call home is its restoration. The mechanic translates a psychology Doi considered characteristically Japanese into a universal procedure; its effect on players across cultures suggests that the psychology was never Japanese alone.

Homesickness, in sum, makes attachment a variable of courage. It asserts that the capacity to act in the world depends on the persistence of a voice from home, and it makes the telephone the instrument of that persistence. It is the simplest demonstration in the game that grace, in this world, arrives at a distance and as a voice.

3.4 The Mother at the Stove, the Father on the Line

The household of *EarthBound* is divided along a line the game never states and never violates. The mother is present. She stands in the kitchen, she cooks, she can be visited, and the boy recovers in the bed upstairs. The father is absent. He is never seen. He exists as a voice on the telephone, as deposits in a bank account, as the keeper of the record of progress, and as an occasional interruption. The mother cures homesickness; the father ends sessions. The mother nourishes; the father pays and preserves. And when the journey is over, it is with his mother, at home, that Ness looks through the photographs taken along the way while the credits roll.

The division is announced before the game begins. Among the names the player is asked to supply on the opening screens are two that belong to no character: a favourite homemade food (by default, steak) and a favourite thing (by default, "Rockin"). The first becomes the dish Ness's mother cooks whenever he comes home; the second becomes the name of Ness's signature psychic power. Before a single step has been taken, the game asks the player what he or she loves, and it distributes the answers between the mother's kitchen and the hero's strength. Home and power are made, literally, out of the player's loves. The game's first act of address is a question rather than an offer.

The absent father has a specific history in postwar Japan. Jun Etō's *Seijuku to sōshitsu* (*Maturity and Loss*, 1967) read the fiction of the postwar generation as the record of a double collapse: the shame of the father, humiliated by defeat, and the dissolution of the "mother," the emotional core of the Japanese household, under the pressure of modernization. His central text, Nobuo Kojima's novel *Hōyō kazoku* (*Embracing Family*, 1965), concerns a household in which a wife's affair with an American serviceman exposes the hollowness of her husband's authority. During the decades of high growth the absent father acquired a sociological form in the salaryman, absorbed by the company's hours and present at home chiefly as income. In 1986 a television commercial for a household insect repellent gave the year one of its most quoted phrases: 「亭主元気で留守がいい」, "a husband is best when he is healthy and away." The copywriter's trade had made the father's absence a punchline. *EarthBound*'s father is the ideal husband of that slogan—healthy, one presumes; wholly absent; generous with money—but the game gives him a dignity the slogan denied. He is the archive of the child's life and the voice of its conscience.

Lacan's account of the paternal function supplies the structural reading. In the 1950s he described the father not as a person but as a signifier, the Name-of-the-Father (*le Nom-du-Père*), whose French homophone, *le Non du père*, names its office: the paternal "no" that separates the child from the mother and installs it in the symbolic order of language and law. The father need not be present to perform this function; he need only be named, and spoken. *EarthBound* reduces the father to precisely this function. He is a voice, and therefore symbolic; he keeps the record, the archive of the symbolic order; he deposits money, the medium of exchange; and he says no, telephoning when the player has played too long to suggest a break. The last of these is

the most remarkable. The paternal prohibition is addressed not to the child in the fiction but to the player outside it, interrupting the enjoyment of play on behalf of the body that plays. It is the first moment at which the game's address passes through the screen, and it comes in the father's voice.

Itoi had performed the inverse arrangement six years earlier. In *Tonari no Totoro* he gave his voice to Tatsuo Kusakabe, a father wholly present—who bathes with his daughters and leads them in laughing aloud to chase away whatever haunts their new house—while the mother lies in a hospital some distance away. When a telegram from the hospital arrives, it is the elder daughter who must run to a neighbour's telephone to reach her father at his university. *Totoro*'s household is held together by a present father, an absent mother, and a desperate telephone call; *EarthBound*'s by a present mother, an absent father, and a routine one. *Totoro*'s most moving address, moreover, is an anonymous gift: an ear of corn left on the windowsill of the mother's hospital room, inscribed 「おかあさんへ」, "to Mother." Bradbury's Charles Halloway and Itoi's Tatsuo Kusakabe are fathers who defeat fear by laughing in person. *EarthBound*'s father defeats nothing. He keeps the line open.

Charles Schulz's *Peanuts* (1950–2000), translated into Japanese by the poet Shuntarō Tanikawa and enormously popular in Japan, organized its world by the opposite principle. The adults are kept off the page altogether, and in the animated television specials their voices are rendered as the wordless honking of a muted trombone. Schulz's children are left alone with their theology. Each autumn Linus keeps a vigil in the pumpkin patch for the Great Pumpkin, a benevolent being who never comes. *EarthBound*'s adults are not noise; the father's voice on the line is intelligible and kind. And the comparison with Linus anticipates the game's ending by contrast. Schulz's vigil is a prayer that is never answered. Paula's is answered by everyone.

The darkest version of the telephonic household was written by Bradbury in 1950. In "There Will Come Soft Rains," later collected in *The Martian Chronicles*, an automated house in California continues its domestic routines after its family has been reduced to silhouettes burned into a wall by a nuclear blast. A voice-clock announces the hours to empty rooms; the kitchen prepares breakfast for no one; in the evening the house reads Sara Teasdale's poem aloud to an empty chair. It is the house as pure address without an addressee, and it is the negative image of Ness's home, where the mother answers and the

father answers back. The terror of Bradbury's house is the terror of a call that nothing receives. Chapter 6 argues that this terror, magnified to a cosmic scale, is the meaning of Giygas.

The division of labour in Ness's household is unmistakably that of the American family sitcom of the 1950s—the mother at the stove, the father at work—and the game reproduces it without irony. A feminist critique of this arrangement is legitimate, and Chapter 8 takes it up. Two qualifications belong here. First, the series that bears the title *Mother* consistently places the decisive moral power in maternal and feminine figures: in the first game, the lullaby of Maria, the woman who raised the alien orphan; in the third, the death of the mother Hinawa, from which the whole tragedy unfolds; in the second, not only Ness's mother but Paula, whose prayer, the decisive act of the game, belongs to no kitchen. Second, the asymmetry of the household is better described as a division of telephonic labour than as an ontology of gender. The father is grace as archive, the voice from afar that preserves; the mother is grace as nourishment, the voice from home that restores. The child needs both lines open.

3.5 Pokey Minch and the Failed House: Envy, Mimesis, and the Eternal Child

Next door to Ness's house stands its negative. The Minch household—the father Aloysius, the mother Lardna, and their sons Pokey and Picky—is loud, punitive, and inattentive. When the boys return from the meteorite on the first night they are punished offstage to the sound of spanking; within minutes the mother swats the messenger from the future, mistaking him for a household pest, and never registers what she has done. Pokey, the elder son, becomes the game's most persistent human antagonist. Plump, cowardly, envious, and opportunistic, he summons Ness on the first night and betrays him thereafter at every turn, attaching himself successively to the blue-painting cult, to the tycoon of Fourside, and finally to Giygas, whose machine he guards in a mechanical walker at the end of the world. The soundtrack gives his battle music a title that is also a diagnosis: "Pokey Means Business."

René Girard's theory of mimetic desire, first set out in *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961), holds that human beings desire not objects but what others desire, so that the model of desire becomes a rival and the rival a fascination. Girard came to read the tenth commandment—"Thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's house" (Exodus 20:17)—as the Bible's prohibition of mimetic rivalry at its source, and he observed that the commandment names the neighbour because proximity is the condition of rivalry. Pokey is the neighbour who covets the neighbour's house. He needs Ness from the first knock and resents the need; unable to occupy Ness's place at the centre of the prophecy, he imitates centrality by attaching himself to whatever power is nearest. In Girard's later work the resolution of mimetic crisis is the scapegoat: the community discharges its rivalry upon a single victim. The game declines this resolution. Pokey is defeated, but he is never killed, never sacrificed, never expelled by the community. He escapes.

Melanie Klein's *Envy and Gratitude* (1957) supplies the affective anatomy. Envy, for Klein, is the angry feeling that another possesses and enjoys something desirable, accompanied by the impulse to take it away or to spoil it; in its primary form it is directed at the good breast precisely because the breast is good. Gratitude is its opposite: the capacity to receive goodness and enjoy it, and thereby to build within oneself a good internal object. Ness is the child of gratitude,

the boy who comes home to the dish he loves and says, in effect, *oishii*. Pokey is the child of envy, who can only seize or spoil. The Minch house is a house without gratitude. And Klein's association of envy with the death drive illuminates Pokey's final alliance: envy, which attacks the source of goodness, finds its natural ally in the being that would annihilate the world.

Weil described the same structure in social terms. Whoever is uprooted, she wrote in *L'Enracinement*, uproots others. Pokey, uprooted in his own house, becomes an agent of uprooting wherever he goes. The ethics of the neighbour converge on him. Leviticus commands that the neighbour be loved as oneself (19:18). Freud, in *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930), found the commandment absurd, since the neighbour so often has more claim on one's hostility than on one's love. Kierkegaard's *Kjerlighedens Gjerninger* (*Works of Love*, 1847) had answered in advance: the neighbour is precisely the one we do not choose, the one who is near, and love of the neighbour is therefore a duty rather than a preference. Pokey is the neighbour in all these senses—unchosen, unlovable, inescapable—and the game's treatment of him is remarkable for its restraint. Ness beats him in battle more than once, but never destroys him. At the end Pokey flees into time. The neighbour remains unredeemed, but not annihilated.

Pokey also frames the game. It is his knock, in the middle of the night, that first summons Ness. And after the credits, when the world has been saved and the hero is home, a second knock comes. It is Picky, bearing a letter from his vanished brother: "Come and get me, loser! Spankety spankety spankety!" The game ends as it began, with a neighbour at the door. The Gospel of Luke offers an uncanny gloss. Its teaching on prayer (11:1–13) opens with the Lord's Prayer and continues with a parable: a man goes to his friend at midnight, knocks, and asks for three loaves; the friend will not rise out of friendship, but he rises because of the man's importunity. The teaching concludes: "Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you." *EarthBound* opens with an importunate neighbour knocking at midnight and closes with an answered prayer. Even its most graceless figure inaugurates its economy of address. The first call in the game comes from the boy who will never learn to answer one.

Pokey's future, disclosed in *Mother 3*, completes the diagnosis. There he reappears as Porky, a tyrant of incalculable age who has wandered through time, built a dystopia of manufactured happiness,

and finally sealed himself, a decrepit child, inside an indestructible "Absolutely Safe Capsule." The figure has a long genealogy. Marie-Louise von Franz's lectures on the *puer aeternus*, published in 1970, developed a Jungian archetype of the eternal boy who refuses incarnation, commitment, and time. J. M. Barrie's Peter Pan (1904; *Peter and Wendy*, 1911) is the boy who will not grow up and who therefore cannot remember. And in "It's a Good Life," Jerome Bixby's story of 1953, adapted for *The Twilight Zone* in 1961, a six-year-old with godlike powers holds his town hostage, its adults compelled to pronounce everything good lest he wish them into the cornfield. Pokey is the boy who acquired power without love and therefore never grew up; Ness is the boy who received love and could therefore bear power. The difference between them is the difference between their houses.

The comparative corpus is crowded with failed houses: in King's *It*, Beverly Marsh's violent father and Eddie Kaspbrak's suffocating mother; in Rob Reiner's *Stand by Me* (1986), adapted from King's novella *The Body* (1982), a boy whose parents, frozen in grief for his dead brother, no longer see him; in *Twin Peaks*, the Palmer house, where the father is the vessel of the evil that destroys the daughter. These works locate horror in the home. *EarthBound* does something stranger. It places a failed house a few steps across a lawn from a good one, and it keeps the hero's own house inviolate. The uncanny is not abolished; it is relocated next door. The Minch house is the place where the domestic sublime fails, and the place from which the game's most stubborn human evil sets out.

Uncanny and Anti-Uncanny: Onett, *Twin Peaks*, and the Suburban Numinous 3.6

Freud's essay "Das Unheimliche" (1919) opened with a philological discovery. The German *heimlich*—homely, belonging to the house, familiar—develops by way of "concealed, kept out of sight" toward an ambivalence in which it finally coincides with its opposite, *unheimlich*. The uncanny, Freud concluded, is that class of the frightening which leads back to what is known of old and long familiar: the familiar that has been repressed and returns. Among his examples is the most intimate of all, the mother's body, which he called the entrance to the former home of all human beings. Anthony Vidler's *The Architectural Uncanny* (1992) extended the concept into a diagnosis of modern dwelling as such, a condition of homelessness at home.

American cinema of the 1980s and early 1990s made the suburban uncanny a genre. David Lynch's *Blue Velvet* (1986) opens with roses before a white picket fence, a fireman waving from a passing truck, and a man collapsing as he waters his lawn, while the camera descends into the grass to find beetles teeming in the dark; its young hero then finds a severed human ear in a field. Lynch and Mark Frost's *Twin Peaks* (1990–91) made a small town in the Pacific Northwest the stage for an evil that possesses fathers. Its reception in Japan, where it became a phenomenon in the early 1990s, culminated in a series of canned-coffee commercials that Lynch directed for the Japanese market, featuring the series' characters—in the very years in which *Mother* 2 was being made. And *Poltergeist* had already shown the planned suburb as a lid over the dead, its television static the channel through which the youngest child is taken and its mother's voice, calling through the noise, the means of her return.

EarthBound proceeds in the opposite direction. Where the uncanny makes the homely strange, the game makes the strange homely. The meteorite delivers a bee. The cosmic destroyer's vanguard is called Starman Junior. The herald of apocalypse is swatted by a housewife. The hero's psychic signature is named after the player's favourite thing. A valley of benevolent aliens speaks in a child's handwriting and serves the travellers coffee. And the ultimate weapon against the end of the world is a girl's prayer relayed through the households of everyone she has met. This is the *domestic sublime*: the sublime encountered from a home, measured against a home, and finally reabsorbed into one. The phrase has had scattered earlier uses in Romantic criti-

cism and art history to name grandeur found in domestic scenes. The sense proposed here is specific and structural: an inversion of the uncanny, in which the cosmic is made homely without being diminished.

The concept is less paradoxical than it appears. Kant's analysis of the dynamically sublime in the *Kritik der Urteilskraft* (1790, § 28) specifies a condition that is easily overlooked: overhanging cliffs, thunderclouds, volcanoes, and hurricanes are attractive to contemplate only provided that we find ourselves in safety. Burke had said much the same in 1757: danger and pain are simply terrible when they press too nearly, and become delightful only at a certain distance and with certain modifications. The sublime presupposes a shelter. Kant's safety condition is Bowlby's secure base translated into aesthetics: the cosmos can be faced because there is a house from which to face it. The domestic sublime is therefore not a contradiction in terms but the hidden condition of every sublime, made explicit. *EarthBound* makes the condition procedural. The hero can confront the vast because he can always call home.

Japanese tradition supplies its own versions of the domestic numinous. The household shelf for the kami (*kamidana*) and the Buddhist altar for the ancestors (*butsudan*) place the sacred inside the house, and Kunio Yanagita's *Tōno monogatari* (1910) records the *zashiki-warashi*, a child-spirit whose presence keeps a house prosperous and whose departure ruins it. Eagleland's houses have neither shelf nor altar—another index of Japan's absence from the game—but the structure survives in transposed form. The most exact Japanese precedent is Kenji Miyazawa's *Ginga tetsudō no yoru* (*Night on the Galactic Railroad*, published 1934). Its hero, Giovanni, is a poor boy whose father is away in the northern seas and whose mother lies ill at home. Sent out at night to fetch the milk that has not been delivered, he boards a train that crosses the Milky Way, and he returns, bereaved of his friend, to carry the milk home to his mother with the news that his father will soon come back. Miyazawa's cosmic journey is framed by a child's errand for his mother. Its sublimity is domestic from beginning to end.

Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) described the numinous as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, a mystery that makes one tremble and draws one in. *EarthBound* distributes the two moments across its geography. Near the house the numinous is fascinating and benign: a talking bee, a valley of kindly aliens, a sanctuary where a melody

waits. At the far edge of the world it becomes tremendous, a noise without form. The house stands at the centre of this field as the place from which the tremendous can be faced and to which the fascinated can return. It is the station of the call. The next chapter follows the call outward, along the eight sanctuaries in which the earth itself speaks to the boy in the second person.



the sacred geography and counterfeit graces it must traverse

4

"Your Sanctuary"

Pilgrimage, Melody, and the Sacred Geography of the Self

> "The eight together form one harmony."
>
> *Plato, Republic 617b (trans. Benjamin Jowett, 1871)*

> "They have mouths, but they speak not."
>
> *Psalm 115:5 (King James Version)*

THE HOUSE IS THE station of the call; the earth is its route. This chapter follows Ness outward across the eight sites the game calls "Your Sanctuary," whose melodies, gathered in the Sound Stone, compose a single song that opens an interior continent. It argues that the game's sacred geography is organized by address: the earth speaks to the boy in the second person, and its songs return him to himself. Along the route the game stages its counterfeit graces—an idol that possesses (4.3), a city that inverts speech (4.4), a cult that manufactures happiness (4.5)—and two forms of alterity that test what address requires, the gentle nonsense of Mr. Saturn and the shyness of the Tenda (4.6). It ends in Magicant, where the interior the sanctuaries have built is entered and its nightmare confronted (4.7).

4.1 The Sound Stone: Songline, Stamp Book, Gramophone

Before he dies, Buzz Buzz entrusts Ness with the Sound Stone, an object whose only function is to record melodies, and with a task: to visit eight places scattered across the world and take from each the song that dwells there. The game calls these places "Your Sanctuary." They are not temples, and they are dedicated to no god. The first is a giant footprint pressed into the summit of a hill north of Onett, reached through a cave and guarded by an enormous ant. The second, Lilliput Steps, lies near the village of the blue cult; the third, Milky Well, outside the valley of the Mr. Saturns; the fifth, Magnet Hill, beneath the streets of Fourside, reached through its sewers; the sixth, Pink Cloud, in the mountain kingdom of Dalaam, its entrance barred by statues of black rabbits until a carrot-shaped key is found; the seventh, Lumine Hall, in a cave whose glowing walls write out the hero's thoughts; the eighth, Fire Spring, deep in a subterranean continent of dinosaurs. Each is guarded by a creature whose defeat permits the melody to be recorded, and each restores the party in full. Together they form what the game will later call the eight power spots of the earth.

Two features distinguish this sacred geography from the conventions it inherits. The first is that it is not elemental. Role-playing games of the period, from *Final Fantasy* (1987) onward, organized their quests around elemental crystals or orbs—earth, water, fire, wind—each a principle rather than a place. *EarthBound*'s sanctuaries are named for sensations and accidents: milk, rain, magnetism, a pink cloud, light, a spring of fire, a footprint, a flight of tiny steps. They are places, not principles. The second is the second person. The sanctuaries belong to the player, or to Ness, which in the game's grammar of address amounts to the same thing. Their collective name confers a possession and an intimacy at once: *your* sanctuary, the place that is yours. The sacred, here, is not a god's house but the experience of belonging to a place, and of the place belonging to you.

The names of the first two sanctuaries announce a further theme. Giant Step and Lilliput Steps borrow the vocabulary of Jonathan Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), whose voyages to Lilliput and Brobdingnag made relative scale an instrument of moral perspective. The game returns to the device near the end of the pilgrimage. Dropping from Lumine Hall into the Lost Underworld, the party finds itself shrunk to a fraction of its size among dinosaurs, Lilliputians in a Brobdingnag of prehistory. The pilgrimage teaches proportion. The

boy who begins at a giant's footprint ends as a speck among the earth's oldest creatures, and the music the game assigns to that underworld bears the title "Earth's Love Song."

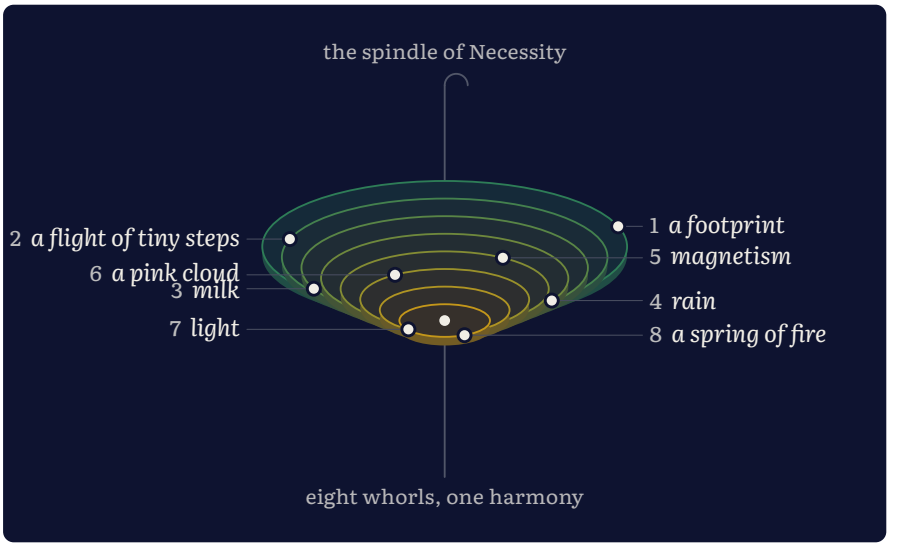
Bruce Chatwin's *The Songlines* (1987) brought to a wide readership, in a form anthropologists have criticized as romanticized, the Aboriginal Australian understanding of the Dreaming tracks: routes along which ancestral beings sang the world into being, whose songs, sung by those who walk them, both map the land and maintain it. T. G. H. Strehlow's *Songs of Central Australia* (1971), on which Chatwin drew, documented such songs as at once liturgy, title deed, and atlas. The homology with the Sound Stone is structural and implies no influence. Ness does not compose the melodies; he finds them already dwelling in the land. Walking the earth becomes a form of listening, and the songs gathered on the way bind the walker to the ground he crosses.

A closer homology lies in Japanese pilgrimage. The circuit of eighty-eight temples on the island of Shikoku, associated with the ninth-century monk Kūkai (Kōbō Daishi), is walked by pilgrims who carry a book, the *nōkyōchō*, in which each temple inscribes its vermilion seal and a line of calligraphy, so that the book becomes a record of the body's passage through sacred space. Pilgrims wear the phrase 「同行二人」, *dōgyō ninin*, "two travelling together," signifying that Kūkai accompanies each of them along the way: the pilgrim is never alone. The Sound Stone is a seal book for the ear, accumulating the marks of eight sacred places; and the boy who gathers them travels, as Chapter 3 showed, in the constant company of an absent voice. The commercial afterlife of the pilgrim's seal book—the rubber stamps kept at Japanese railway stations and the summer "stamp rallies" in which children collect them—made the accumulation of place-tokens a familiar ritual of childhood travel. The Sound Stone joins the sacred and the commercial lineages in one object, as Itoi's copy had always joined them.

Friedrich Kittler argued that the phonograph, unlike writing, records the real indiscriminately: not only the symbolic order of words but every noise in the room. Tradition holds that the first words Edison recorded on tinfoil in 1877 were a nursery rhyme, "Mary had a little lamb." A century later the Voyager probes carried into interstellar space a gold-plated record, assembled by a committee chaired by Carl Sagan, bearing greetings in fifty-five languages, music from many cultures, and the "sounds of Earth": a message addressed to listeners who might not exist. The Sound Stone is the Voyager

record inverted. It does not send the earth's sounds outward to an unknown cosmos; it gathers them inward, as a resource against a cosmic threat. What it records is neither speech nor noise but melody—address without words, the earth's own phatic utterance.

The seventh sanctuary makes the logic of the whole explicit. In Lumine Hall the cave wall begins to glow, and Ness's thoughts appear on it as scrolling text—a meditation on the long road behind him and the uncertain fate ahead—until the boy wonders whether the thoughts on the wall are really his. The sanctuary reads the pilgrim. The land, which has addressed him in song, now writes him out in words, and the boundary between interior and exterior begins to dissolve. When the eighth melody is recorded the dissolution is completed. A figure called the Star Master tells Ness that by standing on the eight power spots of the earth he has created Magicant, the realm of his own mind. The pilgrimage across the outer world has built an inner one. Karatani's inversion, discussed in Chapter 2, is here enacted as a procedure: the landscape traversed becomes the interiority discovered.



Eight places, each holding one melody, which together compose a single song: the sanctuaries, named for sensations and accidents rather than elements, set on the nested whorls of Plato's spindle, the first outermost (§§ 4.1–4.2).

Harmony and Anamnesis: From *Pythagoras* to Close Encounters 4.2

The doctrine that a cosmos sings is as old as Greek philosophy. The Pythagorean tradition, discovering that consonant intervals correspond to simple ratios of string lengths, inferred that the heavens are ordered by musical proportion and that the planets sound a harmony too constant for human ears to notice. Plato's *Timaeus* built the world-soul from harmonic ratios. And in the myth of Er that closes the *Republic*, the souls of the dead behold the spindle of Necessity, on whose eight nested whorls stand eight Sirens, each singing a single note; together, the eight form one harmony. The homology with *EarthBound* is exact in structure: eight places, each holding one melody, which together compose a single song. Boethius transmitted the doctrine to the Latin Middle Ages as a threefold music—of the cosmos, of the human being, and of instruments—and Kepler's *Harmonices Mundi* (1619) sought it in the proportions of the planetary orbits. *EarthBound* relocates it. Its harmony is not celestial but terrestrial, sounded in caves, on hillsides, and beneath a city's sewers: a *musica terrena*, a harmony bound to the earth.

The series had used the device before, to a different end. In *Mother*, the boy Ninten gathers eight melodies that prove to be fragments of a lullaby once sung by his great-grandmother Maria to an infant alien she raised during her captivity. When the children sing the completed song to that alien, now grown into the destroyer Giegue, he is overwhelmed by the memory of being loved and withdraws. In the first game, then, the melody is a weapon of memory aimed at the enemy: it reminds the other of a love he has lost. In the second, the gathered melodies are never sung at Giygas. They open the hero's own interior, carrying him into Magicant to confront himself. The function of the song has shifted from recalling the other's love to recollecting oneself.

Plato had a name for learning that is really recollection: *anamnēsis*. In the *Meno*, Socrates draws a geometrical proof from an untutored slave boy to show that the soul does not acquire knowledge so much as recover it; in the *Phaedo*, recollection becomes an argument for the soul's existence before birth. The sanctuary melodies are anamnetic in precisely this sense. Ness does not learn them; he finds them waiting in the earth, and they awaken what was already in him, since the realm they open is made of his own memories. The motif returns us to Maebashi. Hagiwara read Buson's nostalgia as the soul's longing for a home on the far side of time. The songs of *EarthBound* are such a longing given the form of a quest, and their completion is a homecoming to a place inside the one who sings.

The pilgrimage ends underground. The last two sanctuaries lie beneath the surface—the glowing cave of Lumine Hall and the fire spring of the Lost Underworld—and the final confrontation of the game will take place in the Cave of the Past. The descent into the underworld, the *katabasis* of Odysseus, Aeneas, and Dante, has a musical patron in Orpheus, whose song moved stones, tamed beasts, and persuaded the powers of the dead to release Eurydice, in the versions of Virgil's fourth *Georgic* and Ovid's *Metamorphoses*. Orpheus fails at the threshold because he looks back. *EarthBound*'s descent is likewise musical, but its music is not used to bargain with the powers below. It is used to constitute the one who descends.

Popular cinema supplied a modern myth of music as address across the gulf between species. In Spielberg's *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* (1977), a five-note figure composed by John Williams becomes the language in which humans and extraterrestrials converse, and the scientist Claude Lacombe, played by François Truffaut, accompa-

nies it with the hand signs of the Kodály method of music education. The film's hero, Roy Neary, is summoned by a sacred mountain, Devils Tower, which he obsessively sculpts in shaving cream and mashed potatoes, and the climactic exchange of tones with the mothership is an act of communion by melody. *Mother* is close kin to this film: its melody is addressed to the alien. *EarthBound* departs from it. Giygas cannot hear music; he lies beyond any channel a melody could travel. The eight melodies are therefore turned toward the human interior, and the address to the alien, when it comes, will take another form.

Jacques Attali's account of music as the channelling of noise, introduced in Chapter 1, explains why the melodies matter although they are never aimed at the enemy. A song is noise ordered into a shared form; to gather the earth's songs is to gather the forms in which the world holds together against the violence of noise. The Sound Stone is a portable cosmos, and the boy who carries it carries the earth's capacity for order into the region where order fails.

The Mani Mani Statue: Possession, Desire, and the Sheep 4.3

The game's chief counterfeit grace has a biography, and its biography is a chain of possessions. In Onett, a hermit and fabulist named Lier X. Agerate—a name that puns on "liar" and "exaggerate," as his Japanese name, Lier Horando, puns on *hora*, a tall tale—is seized by a compulsion to dig beneath his own house, and unearths a golden statue. He sells it at a high price to a man named Carpainter, who promptly founds the blue-painting cult of the Happy Happyists and acquires the power to call down lightning. When Ness has broken Carpainter's hold, the statue is stolen by Everdred, a thief from Twoson who means to sell it in Fourside; there he is betrayed and left for dead by Geldegarde Monotoli, a former elevator operator whom the statue raises to mastery of the city. Moonside, as the next section shows, is the statue's illusion. Ness and Jeff break it, and its image returns at the end of the pilgrimage, in the Sea of Eden, as the form of Ness's own Nightmare. At every stage the statue grants power—a treasure to a fabulist, lightning to a cult leader, a city to an elevator operator—and at every stage the power isolates, inflames desire, and possesses the one who holds it. It is grace without address: a gift that binds its recipient to a thing rather than to anyone.

The biblical prototype is the golden calf of Exodus 32, cast from the people's earrings while Moses is on the mountain receiving the law: an idol made in the interval during which the voice is absent. The psalmist supplied its theory. Idols have mouths but do not speak, eyes but do not see, ears but do not hear; and "they that make them are like unto them; so is every one that trusteth in them" (Psalm 115:8). From the standpoint of telephonic grace this is the decisive point. The idol is the anti-telephone. It has the form of address, a mouth, without its function, and it makes those who trust it like itself—mute, deaf, unreachable. The psalm's curse is fulfilled to the letter in Moonside, where the statue's domain speaks constantly and is never understood.

Modernity found its own name for the golden idol. In the first volume of *Das Kapital* (1867) Marx observed that a commodity, which appears at first sight a trivial thing, proves on analysis to be a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties: social relations between persons take on, in the market, the fantastic form of relations between things. He named the phenomenon the fetishism of commodities, after the Portuguese *feitiço*, a charm or idol. The Mani Mani Statue is the fetish in its literal form, a golden thing that concentrates and distorts the social relations that pass through it—a hermit's greed, a sect's devotion, a city's money. Walter Benjamin, studying the arcades of Paris, called the spectacle of commodities a phantasmagoria. The word fits Moonside exactly, and the game confirms the diagnosis in its last image of that city. When the statue is destroyed, the phantasmagoria vanishes, and Ness and Jeff find themselves standing in an empty warehouse.

The closest literary analogue is Murakami's *A Wild Sheep Chase* (1982), discussed in Chapter 2 as a novel of post-1968 drift. Its narrator, a partner in a small translation and advertising firm, prints a photograph of a mountain pasture in an insurance brochure, and the photograph contains a sheep with a star-shaped mark on its back. The sheep, it emerges, is a being that enters human hosts and grants them extraordinary will. It possessed an agricultural scholar in occupied Manchuria and then a right-wing fixer who built from nothing a postwar empire of politics, finance, and advertising. When the narrator's friend, the Rat, discovers the sheep inside himself, he hangs himself in order to destroy it. The structural homology with the Mani Mani Statue is close: a possessing power that passes from host to host, grants dominion, and devours the self, and whose cycle can be broken only by a refusal that costs the self. It is suggestive, though no

more than that, that Murakami's parable of possessing power is set in motion by an advertising man's image, and that Itoi's game sets its idol in circulation through a fabulist's greed.

The motif recurs across the comparative corpus. In *Twin Peaks* the spirit BOB passes into Leland Palmer and uses him; possession is the form evil takes in Lynch's small town. In Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* (1954–55) the One Ring grants power and invisibility, possesses those who bear it, cannot be used for good, and can be undone only by being returned to the fire in which it was made. Wagner's *Das Rheingold* (1869) states the condition explicitly: Alberich can forge the ring of world-mastery from the Rhine's gold only by renouncing love. Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) gives the most unsettling variant—a Room that grants not the wish one professes but the one one truly harbours, so that a man who entered it to save his brother came out rich, and hanged himself. Each of these objects is counterfeit grace: power obtained at the price of relation. The Mani Mani Statue condenses them all into a single golden thing kept behind a café counter.

The decisive detail comes at the end. When Ness reaches the centre of the Sea of Eden, the inmost place of his own mind, the enemy waiting there wears the statue's form. Counterfeit grace is not only a thing in the world that corrupts other people; its image is in the hero. The temptation to power without relation, which the statue has offered to a hermit, a cult leader, and a tycoon, is latent in the boy who has destroyed it, and he must face it alone, in a battle in which his Nightmare commands all of his own powers. The game thus refuses the comfortable division between the corrupted and the pure. The idol is defeated outside before it is defeated within, and Section 4.7 returns to that inner battle.

Moonside: Inversion, Surrealism, and the Red Room 4.4

Moonside is entered through a wall. In Fourside, the wounded thief Everdred directs Ness and Jeff to Jackie's Café; when they examine the wall behind its counter, they find themselves in a city at night, a neon double of Fourside whose inhabitants greet them—"Welcome to Moonside"—and then speak in riddles, non sequiturs, and inversions. One resident explains that in Moonside yes means no and no means yes; others remark on the visitors' hit points, breaking the frame of the fiction. Men posted on street corners transport the travellers to other districts when spoken to. Among the creatures in the streets

are an enemy called Abstract Art and another named for Dalí's melting clocks. At the city's heart a phantom Monotoli cowers before the golden statue, and when the statue is destroyed the city vanishes: Ness and Jeff are standing in an empty warehouse behind the café.

The structure has a Japanese precedent in Hagiwara's *Nekomachi*, discussed in Chapter 2: a familiar town approached from an unaccustomed side, revealed as a stranger, and then overrun. Takeo Doi, extending his analysis of *amae*, devoted a later book, *Omote to ura* (1985), to the front and the back—the public face and the private reverse that together structure Japanese social life. Moonside is Fourside's *ura*: the reverse of the bubble city, entered through the back of a café counter, where its madness is no longer concealed behind commerce.

Lewis Carroll's *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871) is the classic Western topology of inversion: a house in which everything runs the wrong way, a queen whose memory works in both directions, a rule of "jam to-morrow and jam yesterday—but never jam to-day." It is also a book about the politics of meaning. Humpty Dumpty insists that a word means just what he chooses it to mean, and when Alice asks whether one can make words mean so many different things, he answers that the question is which is to be master. Moonside's inversion of yes and no is Humpty Dumpty's doctrine enforced not by an eccentric but by an idol, and George Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) had already shown what such enforcement becomes in politics: war is peace, freedom is slavery, and the citizen's capacity to believe both at once is called doublethink. Mikhail Bakhtin described a different inversion in his study of Rabelais, written in 1940 and published in 1965: the carnival world turned upside down, in which a whole people laughs, crowns its fools, and renews itself. Moonside is carnival without the people. Its inversions are captive rather than festive. Nobody laughs in Moonside, and nobody is renewed.

The visual idiom of Moonside is surrealist. André Breton's *Manifeste du surréalisme* (1924) defined the movement as pure psychic automatism, the dictation of thought in the absence of any control exercised by reason. Salvador Dalí's *The Persistence of Memory* (1931) gave it an emblem of time gone soft; René Magritte's *La Trahison des images* (1929), a painted pipe captioned "Ceci n'est pas une pipe," severed word from image; and Giorgio de Chirico's empty piazzas at twilight, with their long shadows and absent crowds, supplied the mood of the metaphysical city. Moonside borrows all of this. But it reverses surre-

alism's promise. Breton's movement claimed to liberate desire from the censorship of reason. In Moonside the dream-logic of the unconscious is not liberated desire but desire captured by an idol: the surreal as the illusion of a golden thing.

Lynch's *Twin Peaks* offers the most precise contemporary analogue. Its Red Room—the curtained antechamber of the Black Lodge, with its chevron floor and its dancing Man from Another Place—is a space in which speech runs backward (the actors performed their lines phonetically reversed, and the recording was reversed again) and in which persons appear as doubles. Moonside is likewise a place of inverted speech and doubled persons, among them a Monotoli who is not Monotoli. The game was made while *Twin Peaks* was a sensation in Japan, and whether or not the Red Room was in anyone's mind at Ape and HAL, the two works share a single insight. The deepest corruption is not violence but the corruption of address: a world in which one can still speak, greet, and answer, but in which every utterance is turned against its meaning.

The name is apt. *Luna* gave the European languages their word for madness, and the moon is the emblem of the reverse side of things, the face turned perpetually away from the earth. Murakami would return to the image in 1Q84 (2009–10), whose heroine descends an emergency stairway from an elevated expressway into a world in which two moons hang in the sky. Moonside belongs to the quadrant of counterfeit grace, but it stands nearest the quadrant of noise. It is noise disguised as speech: the forms of conversation preserved, their function destroyed. Giygas will abolish even the forms. And the city's ending serves as the bubble's epitaph. When the idol breaks, the phantasmagoria that had seemed a whole metropolis is revealed as what it was all along: an empty warehouse behind a café.

4.5 *Happy Happy Village: Cult, Color, and the Commodification of Happiness*

Beyond Peaceful Rest Valley, a short journey from Twoson, lies a village whose inhabitants have painted their world blue. The Happy Happyists, led by Carpainter, the statue's second owner, have given themselves to a creed whose content is never stated and whose sign is a single colour applied to everything within reach. They have kidnapped Paula for her psychic gifts and hold her in a locked cabin, and Pokey has risen to prominence in their ranks. Carpainter wields lightning; Ness can face him only after Paula, through the bars of her cell, gives him the Franklin Badge, which turns lightning back upon its source. Defeated, Carpainter apologizes, explains that the statue drove him to it, disbands the cult, and hands over the key to the cabin.

The badge is worth a pause. It is named for Benjamin Franklin, who in 1752 is said to have drawn electricity from a thundercloud with a kite and a key, and who was, before he was a scientist or a statesman, a printer, a publisher of newspapers that carried advertisements, and the compiler of *Poor Richard's Almanack* (1732–58), whose maxims made him the first great aphorist of American commercial culture. The instrument with which a child defeats a cult's counterfeit lightning carries the name of the American Enlightenment's tamer of lightning, who was also, in his way, its first copywriter. The printer who domesticated the fire of the sky deflects the fire of the false god.

The structure of the village is the structure of a famous thought experiment. In Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), a city of perfect happiness owes that happiness to a single child kept in filth and darkness in a basement room. Every citizen knows of the child, and some, having seen it, walk away from the city and do not return. Le Guin traced her premise to a passage in William James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), and its kinship with Ivan Karamazov's refusal of a harmony purchased with the tears of a tortured child is unmistakable. Happy Happy Village is Omelas rendered in blue paint: its collective bliss is attended by a girl locked in a cabin. The game's answer to Le Guin's question is neither to stay nor to walk away. It is to open the cabin.

The colour is not arbitrary. Maurice Maeterlinck's play *L'Oiseau bleu* (1908) sends two children, Tyltyl and Mytyl, through the Land of Memory, the Palace of Night, and the Kingdom of the Future in

search of the blue bird of happiness, which they find at last in their own home. In Japan the play gave the language a byword: the *aoi tori*, the blue bird, is happiness sought far away and found close at hand. The Happy Happyists paint the world in happiness's colour, imposing by decree what Maeterlinck's children learned can be found only at home; their blue is the blue bird turned into paint. A second resonance is hard to resist in a game scored by musicians steeped in the Beatles. In George Dunning's *Yellow Submarine* (1968), the Blue Meanies drain Pepperland of colour and music and turn its people to stone, until the Beatles restore it with song. Intended or not, the cult's blue belongs to the same visual logic: one colour imposed in place of many, and silence imposed in place of music.

Japanese literature had already formulated the opposite of the cult's happiness. Kenji Miyazawa's *Nōmin geijutsu gairon kōyō* (*Outline of Peasant Art*, 1926) declares that there can be no individual happiness until the whole world is happy, and *Night on the Galactic Railroad* makes "true happiness" (*hontō no saiwai*) the object of its two boys' vow: a happiness for everyone, for whose sake the scorpion of the novel's parable prays that its body may burn as a light. Happy Happy Village inverts Miyazawa's ethic. Its happiness is exclusive, enforced, and founded on a captive. Bradbury's *Dandelion Wine* contains a gentler parable on the same theme: an inventor named Leo Auffmann builds a Happiness Machine that shows its users marvels and leaves them miserable for what they cannot have, and when it burns he sees through his own window the true happiness machine, his family at home. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) supplied the darkest version, a civilization of manufactured contentment administered by the drug soma. The village's blue is soma in pigment.

The Japanese context sharpens the satire into something like premonition. The 1970s and 1980s saw the rise of what sociologists called the "new new religions" (*shin-shin shūkyō*), movements offering spiritual power, healing, and happiness to an affluent and anxious public; one founded in 1986 took the name Kōfuku no Kagaku, "the Science of Happiness." The 1980s also brought scandals of so-called spiritual sales (*reikan shōhō*), in which talismans and seals were sold at extortionate prices with promises of protection for buyers and their ancestors—the commodification of salvation in its crudest form. Aum Shinrikyō, founded as a yoga circle in 1984, released sarin in Matsumoto in June 1994, two months before *Mother 2* appeared, and on the Tokyo subway in March 1995, three months before *EarthBound*.

The game did not foresee these events, and nothing in it refers to them. But its portrait of a cult that captures a psychic girl, paints the world one colour, and draws its power from a golden idol registers the atmosphere in which they became possible. Murakami's *Andāguraundo* (*Underground*, 1997), built from interviews with survivors of the subway attack, and its sequel *Yakusoku sareta basho de* (*The Place That Was Promised*, 1998), built from interviews with members of Aum, arrived at a diagnosis close to the game's: the cult had offered a ready-made story to people who had surrendered the labour of making their own, and the antidote was the capacity to tell, and to hear, one's own story. *Mother 3* later completed the satire by turning the cult into a broadcast. Its tyrant pacifies a village by distributing glowing "Happy Boxes," televisions in all but name.

The cult's deepest offence, in the terms of this dissertation, is an offence against address. Its members do not speak to one another; they repeat. And the person it imprisons is the one whose gift is address itself. Paula's first act in the game is a telepathic call: her voice reaches Ness in a dream while he sleeps at a hotel in Onett, asking for help before they have met. The cult can lock the girl in a cabin; it cannot keep her voice from leaving it. The pattern anticipates the end of the game, where the same girl, enclosed in a robot body in the Cave of the Past, sends out a prayer that the darkness cannot contain.

Saturn Valley and Tenda Village: Nonsense, Shyness, and the Ethics of Alterity 4.6

Saturn Valley is the gentlest place in the game. Its inhabitants, the Mr. Saturns—*Dosei-san* in Japanese—are small creatures with large noses and ribbons in their hair, who speak in a typeface of their own, a childlike scrawl, and punctuate their sentences with sound-words: "Boing!", "Zoom!", "Ding!" Their grammar is askew and their kindness is complete. They let the travellers rest and offer them coffee, and the coffee occasions one of the game's most remarkable interludes, in which the narrative halts and the screen fills with scrolling text addressed directly to the player, reflecting on the journey so far and on what lies ahead. The valley's peace is threatened by Master Belch, a being of animated vomit whose lair lies behind a waterfall and who is undone by a jar of fly honey. Later the valley becomes the workshop in which Dr. Andonuts and Apple Kid build the machine that will carry the children into the past.

Edward Lear's *A Book of Nonsense* (1846) and Lewis Carroll's "Jabberwocky" (1871) founded the Anglophone tradition of nonsense, which is not the absence of meaning but a play with its conditions; Gilles Deleuze, in *Logique du sens* (1969), read Carroll as the philosopher of the surface on which sense is produced. Japanese has its own resource in the vast lexicon of mimetic words (*giongo* and *gitaigo*) that render sounds, motions, and feelings, and Kenji Miyazawa exploited it to the full: his story "Kaze no Matasaburō" (1934) opens with a wind-song of pure sound, *doddodo dodōdo dodōdo dodō*. Mr. Saturn's speech belongs to this lineage. Its sound-words are not referential but phatic, in Jakobson's sense: utterances whose function is to establish and sustain contact. The Mr. Saturns speak in order to be with the listener. Theirs is the purest form of address in the game, almost empty of content and entirely full of regard.

The valley is also the game's clearest image of hospitality toward the radically other. Emmanuel Levinas located the origin of ethics in the encounter with the face of the Other, which cannot be reduced to the categories of the same. Jacques Derrida, in *De l'hospitalité* (1997), distinguished a conditional hospitality, which asks the stranger's name and sets terms, from an unconditional hospitality that welcomes the newcomer before any question. The Mr. Saturns practise the latter: they ask nothing of the travellers and give them coffee. Tove Jansson's Hattifatteners, the mute, electrical wanderers of the

Moomin books, are alterity without speech, glimpsed and never understood. Mr. Saturn is alterity with kind speech, incomprehensible in grammar and transparent in intent. It is significant that the game's most direct address to the player, the coffee interlude, is served by these aliens. Hospitality is the medium through which the game speaks to the one outside it.

Beyond the swamp of Deep Darkness lies a village of beings so shy that they will not speak. The Tenda turn away when addressed. Their chief, mastering himself enough to explain, reports in broken syntax the rumour of a book that can cure shyness. The book, *Overcoming Shyness*, is found on a shelf in the public library of Onett, Ness's hometown; once the chief has read it, the tribe speaks freely and helps the travellers onward. A second tribe of Tenda, living in the Lost Underworld below, left the first because they found it too shy. Extroverted and confident, they believe that the land outside their village is a cage in which dinosaurs are kept, although the dinosaurs' world in fact surrounds them.

The Tenda episode is the game's comedy of shame. Ruth Benedict's *The Chrysanthemum and the Sword* (1946), written in the service of the American war effort, notoriously characterized Japan as a "shame culture" in contrast to the "guilt culture" of the West—a thesis that Japanese scholars such as Keiichi Sakuta subjected to searching critique (*Haji no bunka saikō*, 1967). Philip Zimbardo's popular study *Shyness: What It Is, What to Do About It* (1977), drawn from the Stanford Shyness Survey, reported shyness to be most widespread among its Japanese and Taiwanese respondents. Whatever the merits of such generalizations, the Tenda can be read as a gentle self-caricature of a reticence that Japanese and foreign observers alike had made a national stereotype, and their cure—a self-help book from a public library—as a joke on the genre that Dale Carnegie's *How to Win Friends and Influence People* (1936) had made a global industry. Philosophy supplies the episode's depth. Jean-Paul Sartre's *L'Être et le néant* (1943) analysed shame as the experience of being seen by the Other, the moment in which I become an object for a look I cannot control; Levinas's early essay *De l'évasion* (1935) described shame as the impossibility of escaping oneself, of being riveted to one's own being. The Tenda are beings who cannot bear the look of the other and therefore can neither address nor be addressed. Overcoming shyness is entering the economy of address, and the means of entry comes from Ness's home.

The two tribes complete the parable. The upper Tenda are too shy to speak; the lower Tenda, who fled that shyness, are so sure of themselves that they mistake their own enclosure for the dinosaurs' cage. Neither extreme can truly address the other. Between the paralysed and the oblivious, the game's ethics of alterity asks for something harder: the courage to speak to the other, and the humility to know who is inside the cage.

Magicant: The Interior Continent and the Nightmare Within 4.7

When the eighth melody has been recorded at Fire Spring, Ness wakes in a pastel world of clouds and sea, dressed, as on the first night of the game, in his pyjamas. A figure the game calls the Star Master—the same sage who earlier trained Prince Poo—explains where he is. By standing on the eight power spots of the earth, Ness has created Magicant, the realm of his own mind. In it there are beauty, kindness, sorrow, and hatred, and there is also an evil and violent side of himself; at the centre of these feelings lies the Sea of Eden, which leads to the truth about him. Magicant is populated by the people of his journey, friends and enemies alike, rendered as illusions, and by older memories: his family, his friends, younger versions of himself. His mother stands near the threshold and restores him. Five Flying Men, figures the game associates with his courage, join him one at a time and fall in battle, each leaving a gravestone marked with a cross beside their house; among the graves is one for Buzz Buzz, whose epitaph records that he appeared earlier in the game and gave up the ghost before achieving his goal. A curled metal tentacle gives entry to the Sea of Eden, where krakens patrol the shallows. At its centre stands the golden image of the Mani Mani Statue. This is Ness's Nightmare, and he must fight it alone. When it falls, he receives an enormous accession of power and returns to Saturn Valley, where the machine that will carry him into the past is nearly ready.

The relocation of Magicant is the most consequential change between the first two games. In *Mother*, Magicant was the dream-kingdom of Queen Mary, revealed at the end to be the mind of Maria, the woman who had raised the alien orphan and sung him the lullaby: the interior world belonged to the mother. In *Mother 2* it belongs to the child. Melanie Klein's theory of internal objects describes the

movement precisely. The child takes the good mother into itself and builds, around that internalized presence, an inner world it can inhabit alone. Ness's Magicant contains his mother at its threshold. The realm that was hers is now his, and she is in it.

Augustine supplied the Western tradition with its classic image of the interior as a landscape. In the tenth book of the *Confessions* he describes memory as fields and spacious palaces, storehouses of countless images, a vastness so great that he cannot grasp the whole of what he is; he has become, he writes, a question to himself. In *De vera religione* he gave the inward turn its most famous imperative: *noli foras ire, in te ipsum redi; in interiore homine habitat veritas*—do not go outside, return into yourself; truth dwells in the inner man. The Star Master's account of the Sea of Eden, a place at the centre of the self that leads to the truth about oneself and in which one may touch the truth of the universe, is Augustinian in structure. Magicant is the palace of memory made walkable, and the Sea of Eden is its innermost chamber, where the self meets what it most needs and most fears to know. The sea's name, borrowed from the garden of the first innocence and the first fall, holds both possibilities.

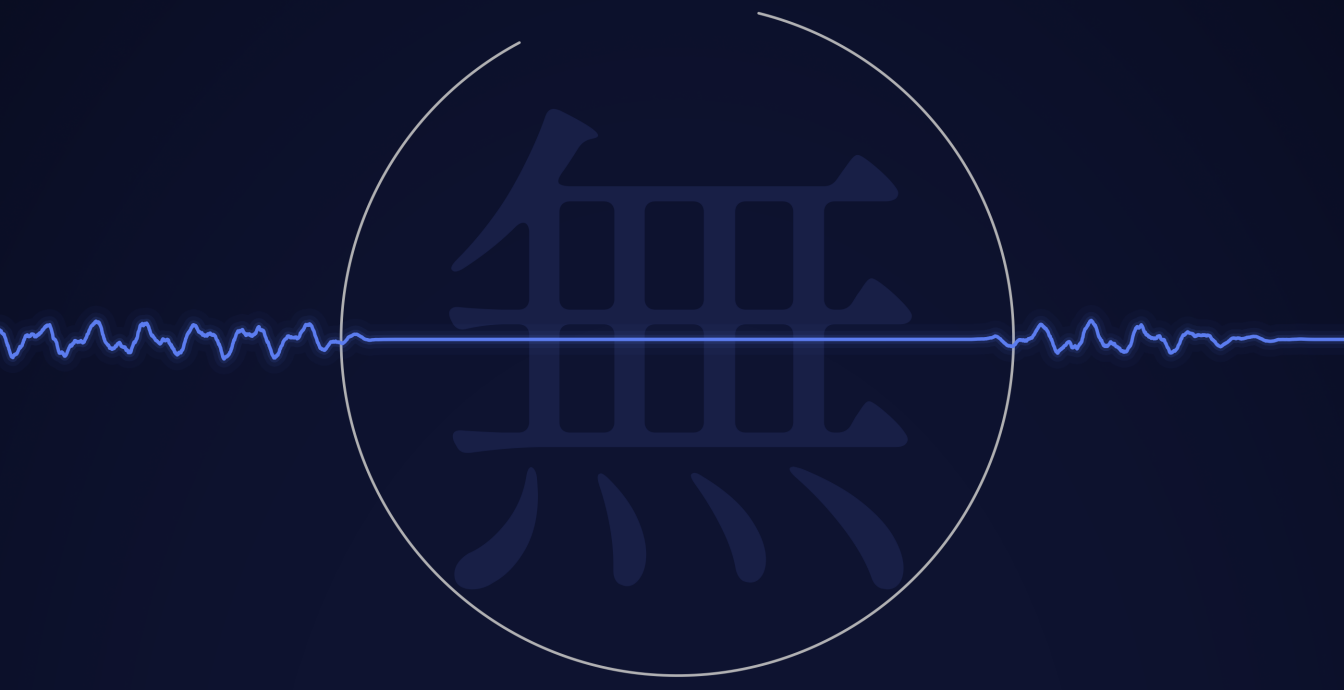
Two modern works map the same territory. In Murakami's *Sekai no owari to hādoboirudo wandārando* (*Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World*, 1985), the chapters set in the End of the World take place in a walled town that turns out to lie inside the narrator's own mind. At its gate his shadow is cut away from him and slowly weakens; at the novel's end the shadow escapes, and the narrator chooses to remain in the town of his interior. Ness makes the opposite choice. He confronts the dark part of himself, defeats it, and leaves. In Andrei Tarkovsky's *Solaris* (1972), adapted from Stanisław Lem's novel of 1961, an ocean-mind on a distant planet materializes the memories of the scientists who study it, and the film's final shot pulls back from the hero kneeling before his father's country house to reveal the house standing on an island in that alien ocean: a home rebuilt from memory by another mind. Magicant is *Solaris* turned inward—a home and a world rebuilt from memory, not by an alien ocean but by the child's own psyche, at the summons of the earth's songs.

The Nightmare is a shadow in Jung's sense: the unacknowledged dark part of the personality, which must be made conscious rather than denied. Jung remarked that one does not become enlightened by imagining figures of light but by making the darkness conscious. Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968) gave the shadow its

most influential modern fable. The young wizard Ged, through pride, looses a shadow-being into the world, flees it, and then hunts it to the edge of the world, where he names it with his own name, and the two become one. *EarthBound* takes a harder line than Le Guin. Ness does not integrate his Nightmare; he defeats it. But the form of the Nightmare tells us what is defeated. It is the golden statue, the image of power without relation, which possessed every other owner and now proves to have been waiting inside the hero as well. What Ness overcomes in the Sea of Eden is not the whole of his dark side but its idol: the temptation to become the kind of being the statue made of Carpainter and Monotoli, and the kind of being Giygas has become. The combat is solitary, and the enemy commands all of Ness's own powers, because the temptation is his own.

The cost of the passage is marked by the Flying Men. They join Ness one by one, fight beside him, and die; their graves accumulate beside the house where they lived. Courage, in Magicant, is not a possession but a company, and it is mortal. Among the graves stands Buzz Buzz's, with an epitaph that speaks in the language of the game itself: he appeared earlier in the game and died before achieving his goal. The inscription is a joke and also a liturgy. The game remembers its own fallen messenger in its own terms, and in doing so it reminds the player that the interior Ness traverses is made of the journey the two of them have shared. Magicant is the game's memory of itself.

The sacred geography of this chapter has run from the eight sanctuaries outside to the sea at the centre of the self. The earth's songs have composed an interior; the counterfeit graces met in the world—an idol, an inverted city, a cult—have been met again within; the hospitality of Mr. Saturn and the shyness of the Tenda have marked the conditions under which address is possible. The boy who returns from Magicant is complete in a sense the game has carefully prepared: he has gathered the earth's harmony and defeated the idol in himself. But completion is not yet readiness. To reach Giygas the children must do something stranger than gather and conquer. They must give up their bodies and enter the past as empty vessels. The next chapter turns to the discipline that teaches this emptying—the training of the prince of Dalaam—and to the machine that makes it literal.



「仏道をならふといふは、自己をならふなり。
自己をならふといふは、自己をわするるなり。」

the emptying that makes reception possible

5

"Mu"

Emptiness, Decreation, and the Ghost in the Robot

> 「仏道をならふといふは、自己をならふなり。自己をならふといふは、自己をわするるなり。」
>
> "To study the Buddha Way is to study the self. To study the self is to forget the self."
>
> Dōgen, Shōbōgenzō, "Genjōkōan" (1233)

> *Nous ne possédons rien au monde … sinon le pouvoir de dire je.*
>
> Simone Weil, La Pesanteur et la grâce (1947)

MAGICANT COMPLETES THE BOY; the next stage empties him. To reach Giygas, the four children must leave their bodies and travel into the past as souls housed in machines. This chapter argues that the game prepares and interprets that passage through the training of its fourth hero, Poo, whose discipline of "Mu" is a rehearsal, in the register of meditation, of what the Phase Distorter will accomplish in the register of engineering. It reads the training through Dōgen, Zhuangzi, and the Tibetan practice of Chöd (5.1–5.2); distinguishes, with Keiji Nishitani, the emptiness the children enter from the nihility Giygas has become (5.3); considers Jeff Andonuts and the question concerning technology (5.4) and the robot body (5.5); proposes that the four children together embody Heidegger's fourfold (5.6); and closes with the game's treatment of time—prophecy, the past, and the rolling meter that turns death into a duration (5.7).

5.1 *The Prince of Dalaam and the Training of Mu*

The fourth hero enters the game through a vision. In the seaside resort of Summers, Ness and his companions eat a Magic Cake and find themselves looking across the world at a mountain kingdom in the far east, Dalaam, whose crown prince is completing his education. Control passes to that prince. Poo—Pū in the Japanese original—is a martial artist in a white training uniform with a long queue of hair, adored by his people and, the game notes with a smile, especially by the young women of the court. His master sends him to complete his final trial at a site the Japanese text calls *mu no basho*, the Place of Mu, and the English localization calls the Place of Emptiness.

The site is a cluster of cliff-top platforms joined by ropes. Poo climbs, sits, and composes himself. A girl appears to tell him, falsely, that his master has ordered him to stop. Then a spirit speaks. It announces that it will take Poo's body from him piece by piece, and at each stage it asks for his assent. It breaks his legs. It tears off his arms and gives them to the crows. It takes his ears, and then his eyes. Only his mind remains, the spirit says, and it will take that too. A single refusal ends the trial, which must then begin again. When Poo has consented to everything, he finds himself sitting on the cliff exactly as before, whole, and his training is complete. He returns to the palace and then, at his master's instruction, teleports across the world to Summers, where he swears allegiance to Ness.

The syllable *mu* condenses several registers of late-twentieth-century Japanese culture. It is the *mu* of Zen, the nothingness of the most famous of all kōan: asked whether a dog has Buddha-nature, the Chinese master Zhaozhou answered *wu*, in Japanese *mu*, an answer that opens Wumen Huikai's collection *Wumenguan* (*Mumonkan*, 1228) and that generations of monks have taken as the object of a lifetime's meditation. Lengthened to *mū*, the same katakana names the lost Pacific continent of James Churchward's *The Lost Continent of Mu* (1926) and the occult monthly launched under that title in 1979, at the height of the boom described in Chapter 1. And, as Section 5.3 shows, the phrase *mu no basho* has a precise philosophical history of its own. The localization added a final register. In the Japanese script a village girl mishears *mu* as *me*, "eye," and wonders whether the prince's "eye training" has gone well; in English she wonders about his "Moo Training" and hopes he will show her his best barnyard impression. The syllable of nothingness becomes the lowing of a cow.

Two of Poo's peculiarities follow from his discipline. He cannot equip the ordinary weapons and armour that the other children buy and find; he fights empty-handed, with a handful of royal items as the only exceptions. And among his psychic techniques is one that lets him assume the form of the enemy before him, as though a self that has let go of itself could take on any shape. After the party emerges from the pyramid of Scaraba, a sage called the Star Master takes Poo away to teach him PSI Starstorm, a technique that calls down stars upon the enemy; Poo returns in the swamp of Deep Darkness to rescue his friends with it, and the Star Master appears again at the threshold of the final passage to teach him its ultimate form. The emptied prince is the one who can call down the sky.

The Mu training is usually remembered for its strangeness: a children's game in which a boy consents, calmly, to his own dismemberment. Its structural function matters more than its strangeness. Poo surrenders his limbs, his senses, and his mind, and receives them back intact, with a power he did not have before. Some hours later, at the threshold of the Cave of the Past, all four children will surrender their bodies to a machine and travel as souls housed in metal, and at the end of the game they will receive their bodies back. The training is the game's internal theory of the robot transfer. It teaches, in the mode of meditation and in the person of one child, what the Phase Distorter will accomplish in the mode of engineering for all four: that grace enters by way of a consented emptying, and that what is surrendered is returned.

Dropping Off Body and Mind: Dōgen, Zhuangzi, Chöd 5.2

Dōgen (1200–1253), who carried the Caodong lineage of Chan from China to Japan and founded the Sōtō school of Zen, described his own awakening, under the master Rujing at Mount Tiantong in 1225, with the phrase *shinjin datsuraku*: the dropping off of body and mind. The opening of "Genjōkōan" (1233), the first fascicle of the *Shōbōgenzō*, gives the doctrine its canonical form. To study the Buddha Way is to study the self; to study the self is to forget the self; to forget the self is to be actualized by the myriad things; and when one is actualized by the myriad things, one's own body and mind, and the bodies and minds of others, drop away. The Mu training stages this sequence with literal force. Poo's body and mind are taken from him, and what

remains is not a void but a self returned to itself by the world: the prince sitting on his cliff, unchanged and transformed.

An older and stranger precedent appears in the sixth chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, "The Great and Venerable Teacher." The disciple Yan Hui tells Confucius that he has made progress: he has forgotten benevolence and righteousness, then rites and music, and at last he can "sit and forget" (*zuowang*). Asked what that means, he answers: 「墮肢體，黜聰明，離形去知，同於大通，此謂坐忘。」—he lets his limbs and body fall away, dismisses hearing and sight, parts from form and casts off knowledge, and becomes one with the Great Thoroughfare. Confucius, astonished, asks to become his disciple's disciple. The correspondence with Poo's training is exact, item by item: limbs and body, then hearing and sight, then form and knowledge—legs and arms, then ears and eyes, then mind. Whether or not the game's writers knew the passage, the training reproduces in its very order the oldest Chinese description of meditative self-forgetting.

Tibetan Buddhism developed the image of bodily surrender into a ritual. The practice of *gcod*—Chöd, "cutting"—systematized by the eleventh-century yoginī Machig Labdrön, asks the practitioner, in solitary places and charnel grounds, to visualize his own body cut apart, transformed, and offered as a feast to demons and hungry spirits, in order to sever at the root the clinging to a self. The Tibetan funerary practice called sky burial, in which the dead are given to the vultures as a final gift to other beings, belongs to the same imaginative world. The spirit of the Mu training, which gives Poo's limbs to the crows, cannot help but recall both. The Japanese reception of Tibetan esotericism in the 1980s—Shin'ichi Nakazawa's *Niji no kaitei* (1981), written with a Tibetan lama, and his *Mozart in Tibet* (1983), discussed in Chapter 2—made such practices part of the ambient culture in which the game was conceived. The same reception would later be implicated, painfully, in the history of Aum Shinrikyō, whose founder drew on Tibetan sources.

Western popular fiction had already absorbed the motif. In Stephen King's *It*, the boy Bill Denbrough confronts the cosmic predator through what King calls the Ritual of Chüd, a name evidently borrowed from the Tibetan practice: a contest of wills in which the two combatants bite into each other's tongues and tell jokes until one of them breaks, conducted in a dimension where the boy meets the Turtle, the ancient and benevolent being who made the universe. King and Itoi thus both place a discipline of Tibetan origin at the centre of

a children's war against a cosmic devourer. In King the discipline is combat. In Itoi it is consent.

The oldest Japanese image of a prince who gives up his body comes from the same Buddhist imagination. On the panels of the Tamamushi Shrine at Hōryū-ji, a seventh-century reliquary cabinet, a painting called *shashin shiko*—"casting away the body to feed the tigress"—shows the Jātaka story of Prince Mahāsattva, who, finding a tigress starving with her cubs at the foot of a cliff, hangs his robe on a tree, leaps, and offers his flesh to them. Poo is likewise a prince on a cliff who gives up his body. The difference is instructive. Mahāsattva's gift ends his life; Poo's gift is returned to him. The Mu training belongs not to the literature of sacrifice but to the literature of emptiness, in which what is relinquished is not lost but received back, changed.

The Western traditions supply the same structure in theological vocabulary. The Letter to the Philippians says that Christ "made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant" (2:7); the Greek verb, *ekenōsen*, "emptied himself," gave Christian thought the word *kenosis*. Meister Eckhart's sermon on the poor in spirit described the soul that wants nothing, knows nothing, and has nothing as the soul in which God can work, and his concept of *Gelassenheit*, releasement, passed through the German mystics to Heidegger. Weil gave the idea its most demanding modern form. Decreation, in her notebooks, is the undoing of the creature in us—not destruction, which merely annihilates, but the consent by which the self withdraws so that something greater may pass through it. We possess nothing in the world, she wrote, except the power to say "I," and that is what must be given. The Mu training is decreation in the shape of a game: a series of yeses to one's own unmaking. And Weil's law of grace, that it fills only where there is a void to receive it, names the reason the game requires the trial at all.

Two Nothings: Nihility and Emptiness after Nishitani 5.3

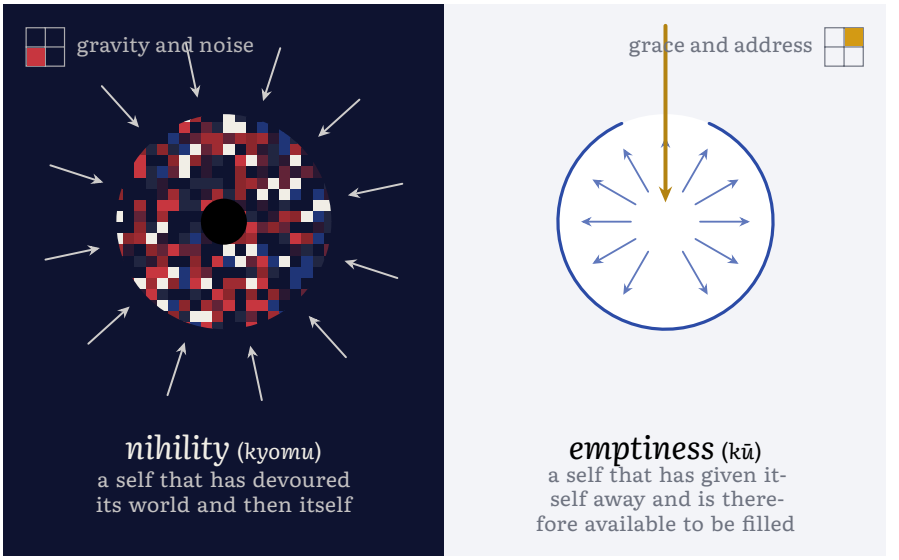
The game contains two nothings, and a careless reading confuses them. The first is the nothingness of the Mu training: a consented emptying through which a self is unmade and returned to itself, able now to take on any form and to call down the sky. The second is Giygas: a power that has destroyed its own mind, a being without form, without thought, without the capacity to be addressed—nothing in

the sense of an abyss. Both are nothing; they are not the same nothing. Their difference is the axis on which the game's metaphysics turns, and the most precise instrument for measuring it is the philosophy of the Kyoto School.

The Japanese name of Poo's training ground deserves a further moment. *Mu no basho*, "the place of nothingness," is a natural phrase in Japanese, but it is also the founding term of modern Japanese philosophy. In his essay "Basho" ("Place," 1926), Kitarō Nishida (1870–1945) argued that every judgment and every act of consciousness is situated in a place that encompasses it, and that the final, all-encompassing place, which cannot itself become an object, is a place of absolute nothingness (*zettai mu no basho*). Nishida's concept became the foundation of the Kyoto School. No claim is made that the game's writers intended the allusion; the phrase is ordinary enough to arise unprompted. But for a Japanese reader schooled in modern philosophy the resonance is unavoidable, and it is exact. The Place of Mu is where the self, emptied of everything that can be objectified, meets the ground that encompasses it.

Nishida's successor Keiji Nishitani (1900–1990) gave the idea its most powerful existential form in *Shūkyō to wa nani ka* (1961), translated as *Religion and Nothingness*. Nishitani distinguished three standpoints. The first is the ordinary field of consciousness, in which a subject confronts a world of objects. The second is the field of nihility (*kyomu*), which opens when the self-centred ego confronts the meaninglessness of its world and finds an abyss beneath its feet—the nihilism Nietzsche diagnosed and Nishitani had analysed in his earlier *Nihirizumu* (1949). Nihility is real and must not be evaded; it is the "great doubt" in which everything, the self included, becomes a question. But it remains, Nishitani insisted, a relative nothingness. It is still seen from the standpoint of the self, as the negation of the self's world, and so it remains captive to the very self-centredness it exposes. The third standpoint is the field of emptiness (*kū*, *śūnyatā*), reached only by breaking through nihility. In emptiness the self no longer stands over against the world as its centre; each thing appears in its own suchness, sustained by its relations with all other things, on what Jan Van Bragt's translation calls its "home-ground." Zen tradition gives the breakthrough its formula: having died the great death, one returns to life.

Mapped onto the game, the distinction is decisive. Giygas is nihility made cosmic. He is the self-centred will expanded without limit un-



Two nothings, at opposite corners of the field of Figure 1.1. Both lose everything; what separates them is not the extent of what is lost but the direction of the loss (§ 5.3).

til it has collapsed into its own abyss—a power that, as the game puts it on the eve of the final battle, has destroyed its own mind; relative nothingness, nothingness as the ruin of a self that never ceased to be a self. Poo's Mu is emptiness. His self is not destroyed but released, and after the great death of the training he returns to life more capable of relation than before, able to assume the form of the other and to receive the sky. In the quaternity of Chapter 1 the two nothings stand at opposite corners: nihility at the junction of gravity and noise, where power collapses inward and no signal escapes; emptiness at the junction of grace and address, where a self opens and something can arrive. The children must pass through the region of nihility, Giygas's domain in the Cave of the Past, without becoming it. They can do so only because they have first been emptied in the other sense.

The distinction also clarifies the robot transfer. The children's departure from their bodies is a great death in the Zen sense, a relinquishment that, unlike Giygas's collapse, is undertaken freely and opens toward return. Dr. Andonuts warns them that there is no turning back; they go anyway. What makes their nothing an emptiness rather than a nihility is not the extent of what is lost, which in both cases is everything, but the direction of the loss. Nihility is a self that

has devoured its world and then itself. Emptiness is a self that has given itself away and is therefore available to be filled. Weil's law of grace and Nishitani's field of *śūnyatā* converge here: only the emptied can receive.

The Kyoto School's concept of nothingness has a troubled political history. In the *Chūōkōron* roundtables of 1941–42, Nishitani and his colleagues argued that Japan had a world-historical mission grounded in its spiritual tradition, and critics have long asked whether the philosophy of absolute nothingness lent itself too readily to the self-negation of the individual before the state. The question bears on any appropriation of the concept, including this one. *EarthBound* offers an implicit answer. Its self-emptying is never demanded by a state or a nation, and it is never final. Poo empties himself and is returned to himself; the children give up their bodies and come home in them. The game's emptiness serves the restoration of persons, not their sacrifice to a collective. That is the difference between a discipline of grace and an ideology of self-negation, and the game keeps to the right side of it.

Jeff Andonuts and the Question Concerning Technology 5.4

The third of the four children is the only one without psychic power. Jeff Andonuts is a bespectacled boy at a boarding school in the snowbound north who receives Paula's telepathic call for help and answers it. His closest friend, Tony, helps him slip out of the dormitory at night by boosting him over the locked gate, and Jeff makes his way to the laboratory of his father, Dr. Andonuts, a distinguished scientist he has not seen in years. The reunion is a small masterpiece of paternal awkwardness: the father greets his son with the stiffness of a man more at ease with machines, and later, unprompted, tells Ness that Jeff used to wet the bed. He lends his son a flying machine, the Sky Runner, with which Jeff rescues Ness and Paula from captivity in Threed. In battle Jeff cannot use PSI. He fights with guns, bottle rockets, and gadgets; he can spy on enemies to learn their weaknesses; and when he sleeps he repairs the broken devices the party has collected, restoring them overnight as tools and weapons. He is the party's technician, and its only ordinary human.

Heidegger's lecture "Die Frage nach der Technik" (delivered in 1953 and published in 1954) argued that the essence of technology is nothing technological. Modern technology is a mode of revealing that challenges nature forth (*herausfordern*), setting upon it to deliver energy and resources as standing-reserve (*Bestand*); the essence of that revealing is *Gestell*, enframing, and its danger is that human beings come to treat themselves, too, as standing-reserve. Against it Heidegger recalled the older sense of *technē* as a form of *poiēsis*, a bringing-forth akin to the craftsman's and the artist's, which lets things appear rather than extracting them; and he took as his hope Hölderlin's lines on the saving power that grows where danger is. The game's two technologists stand on either side of this distinction, and then cross it. Dr. Andonuts, the absent father absorbed by his laboratory, is technology as enframing: work that consumes the family. Jeff, who mends what is broken while he sleeps, is technology as care. And at the climax the father's machine becomes the saving power itself, the instrument by which the children reach the source of the danger.

Repair deserves emphasis because it is so rarely the business of heroes. Steven Jackson's essay "Rethinking Repair" (2014) proposed what he called broken-world thinking: attention to maintenance and repair as the ordinary, undervalued labour by which a damaged

world is kept going. Japanese aesthetics has its own celebrated figure in *kintsugi*, the mending of broken ceramics with lacquer and gold so that the break becomes part of the object's beauty. Jeff's gift belongs to this ethic. The broken things he finds in the world are not discarded but returned to use, and the repair happens in sleep, in the time of the body's own restoration. The child who cannot call down stars or pray is the one who mends.

The relation between Jeff and his father is the game's subtlest portrait of paternity. Dr. Andonuts is absent not by circumstance, like Ness's father, but by temperament: a man who loves his son and does not know how to speak to him. Osamu Tezuka's *Tetsuwan Atomu* (*Astro Boy*, serialized 1952–68) had made the scientist-father a central figure of the postwar Japanese imagination in Dr. Tenma, who builds a robot in the likeness of his dead son and then rejects it because it cannot grow. Dr. Andonuts's arc runs the other way. At the threshold of the final passage, as the children step into his machine, he calls each of them by name and then, after a pause, addresses Jeff as "my son." In the game's ending Jeff remains in Saturn Valley to work beside his father. The relation is repaired through shared work: *technē* as the medium of love between people who lack the words for it.

Jeff's other bond is with Tony, the schoolmate who helps him over the wall and waits for his return. The game treats the boys' friendship with unusual tenderness, and players have long read it as a love between boys that a children's game of 1994 could not name. Whatever one's reading, Tony is among those whom Paula's prayer will reach at the end, and his devotion is part of what saves the world. The technician who cannot pray is prayed for.

Jeff is, finally, the human measure of the party. He alone depends entirely on things—weapons, tools, machines—and on sleep. He alone is nearsighted, and his glasses are his emblem. He alone cannot reach beyond the body by psychic means. He is, in the sense developed in Section 5.6, the mortal among the four. It is no accident that the game's final passage depends on his father's machine. The salvation of the world requires, among other things, technology given over to care.

The Phase Distorter: Souls, Shells, and the Robot Body 5.5

The machine that carries the children into the past has a history as comic as it is sublime. Dr. Andonuts—whose Japanese name, *An Dōnatsu*, is a bean-jam doughnut—builds it in Saturn Valley with the help of Apple Kid and the Mr. Saturns, and the second version takes the shape of a Mr. Saturn. The first Phase Distorter is stolen by Pokey, who flees in it into the past. The second will not run without Zexonyte, a rare element that can be made only from meteoric material, and the only meteorite the children know of is the one that fell on the hill above Ness's house on the first night. Ness must go home to fetch it. He returns to Onett at night, under siege now by Giygas's forces; the townspeople have locked themselves in their houses, his own family among them, and yet his mother, when he speaks to her, still restores him. He climbs the hill, takes a piece of the stone that brought the call, and carries it back. The meteorite that began the journey powers its final passage.

The second machine carries the party to a cliff in the Lost Underworld, where the Star Master teaches Poo the last form of Starstorm. There a third Phase Distorter arrives, bearing Dr. Andonuts, Apple Kid, and another Mr. Saturn. The doctor explains that Giygas is attacking from their exact location, but from many years in the past, and that living bodies cannot survive the journey there. The children's souls must be transferred into robots, and there will be no turning back. He takes Ness's red cap and places it on the head of Ness's robot. Then, calling each child by name and his own, after a pause, by the name of son, he asks Ness to activate the machine by his own hand, and so to follow his own destiny. The children wake as robots, small metal figures bearing slight likenesses of themselves, and the machine carries them into the past. Even here the father's line is not cut: the doctor has built into his time machine the means of restoring the body and of calling Dad to save one's progress.

The detail of the cap is precise. Chapter 3 read Ness's baseball cap as a transitional object in Winnicott's sense, a thing at the boundary between self and world, between the play of childhood and the instruments of the quest. When the boy's soul leaves his body, the cap goes with it. Identity is carried across the threshold not by flesh but by a beloved thing. The robot is made Ness's by the same token that made the boy recognizable on the game's first screen.

Postwar Japanese popular culture had thought long about robot bodies. Tezuka's *Astro Boy* asked, across hundreds of stories, whether a robot could have a *kokoro*—a heart, a mind, a soul—and answered by giving its robot child a moral sensibility finer than that of most of the humans around him. Fujiko F. Fujio's *Doraemon* (1969–96) made a robot from the future the closest friend of an ordinary suburban boy. *EarthBound* inverts the premise of both. In Tezuka and Fujiko a robot is made to be like a child. In Itoi, children consent to become like robots. The soul is not manufactured in the machine; it is carried into it.

The Western philosophical frame is the old problem of mind and body. Descartes, in the *Meditationes* (1641), distinguished thinking substance from extended substance, and in his treatise on man described the body as a machine; Julien Offray de La Mettrie, in *L'Homme machine* (1747), dispensed with the thinking substance altogether. Gilbert Ryle's *The Concept of Mind* (1949) mocked the Cartesian picture as the dogma of the ghost in the machine, and Arthur Koestler borrowed the phrase for a book of 1967, from which Masamune Shirow took the English title of his manga *Kōkaku kidōtai* (*Ghost in the Shell*, serialized 1989–90 and collected in 1991), whose cyborg heroine wonders whether her "ghost" persists in a wholly artificial "shell." Mamoru Oshii's film adaptation appeared in November 1995, five months after *EarthBound*'s North American release. The game takes the Cartesian picture at face value—souls can be poured into machines—and then quietly subverts it. The robots confer no new power. They are small and unadorned, and they enter a cave whose walls have struck generations of players as organic, fleshy, even uterine. Souls in machines inside a body: the hierarchy of ghost and shell is turned inside out.

In the terms established earlier in this chapter, the robot transfer is the Mu training made universal and technological. What Poo underwent in meditation, the four undergo by machine: the dropping off of body and mind, the consent to one's own unmaking, the passage through a great death. It is also, in Weil's terms, the preparation of a void. The children enter the Cave of the Past as empty vessels, emptied of their bodies and deprived even of the homesick child's recourse of going home, and it is into this void that the prayer of the final battle will come. Dr. Andonuts's insistence that Ness activate the machine by his own hand is the mechanical counterpart of the spirit's demand

for Poo's assent. The game's two great dispossessions are both consented to.

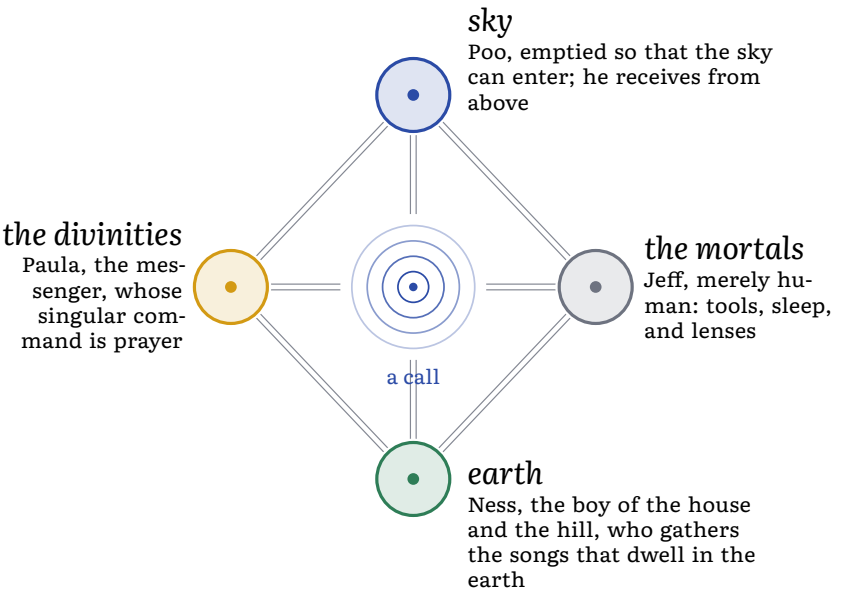
The return completes the figure. When Giygas has been defeated, the machine carries the robots back to Saturn Valley, where the scientists and the Mr. Saturns have been receiving the children's prayer from the past, and the children's souls return to their bodies. The emptying is not an end in itself. Its purpose is to make the children capable of receiving, and once they have received, they are given back to gravity—to their bodies, their homes, their mothers' cooking. *EarthBound*'s metaphysics does not prefer the soul to the body or grace to gravity. It requires that each pass through the other and return.

The Fourfold of Onett: Earth, Sky, Divinities, Mortals 5.6

Heidegger's late thought turns on a figure he called the fourfold (*das Geviert*): earth and sky, divinities and mortals, four that belong together in a mirror-play in which each reflects the others and none can be thought apart from the rest. In "Das Ding" (1950) a humble jug gathers the fourfold—the earth's water and wine, the sky's rain and sun, the libation poured out for the gods, the drink that refreshes mortals—and in "Bauen Wohnen Denken" dwelling is described as the sparing and preserving of the fourfold. This dissertation proposes that the four children of *EarthBound* can be read as an embodiment of the fourfold, and that the reading clarifies why the party is a whole rather than a team of specialists.

Ness is earth. Heidegger describes the earth as the serving bearer, blossoming and fruiting, spreading out in rock and water, rising up into plant and animal. Ness is the boy of the house and the hill, the one whose sanctuaries are the earth's own places and whose task is to gather the songs that dwell in them. His signature power is named after the player's favourite thing; his weapon is a bat, his emblem a cap; he alone grows homesick. He is earth-bound in the most exact sense, and through him the earth's harmony is gathered.

Poo is sky. Heidegger's sky is the vaulting path of the sun, the course of the moon, the glitter of the stars, the turning of the seasons, the light and dusk of the day. Poo is the prince of a kingdom in the mountains, trained on cliffs and emptied so that the sky can enter him; his ultimate technique calls down the stars. He is the one who receives from above.



The four children read as Heidegger’s fourfold: four relations to the world, to the ground, the heavens, the sacred and death, held in a mirror-play and gathered not by a jug but by a call (§ 5.6).

Paula is the divinities. For Heidegger the divinities are the beckoning messengers of the godhead, and mortals dwell insofar as they await them. Paula is the messenger of the party. Her telepathy carries her voice across the world to Ness and to Jeff before either has met her, and her singular command is prayer. She comes from the household that runs the Polestar Preschool—the pole star being the one fixed point in the turning sky, by which travellers find their way—and at the end it is through her that the children’s world receives what it could not produce for itself.

Jeff is the mortals. Mortals, in Heidegger, are human beings, called mortals because they can die, because they are capable of death as death. Jeff alone among the four has no power that reaches beyond the body; he alone depends on tools, sleep, and lenses; he alone is, in this sense, merely human. He is also the child through whom the question concerning technology enters the fourfold, and his presence there is the game’s answer to Heidegger’s pastoral bias. Heidegger’s fourfold is gathered by a hand-thrown jug and a Black Forest farmhouse; *EarthBound*’s includes a boy with a bottle rocket and a father

with a time machine. Technology is not outside dwelling. It is in the hands of the mortal child.

No single child can defeat Giygas. The party's strength lies not in the sum of four specializations but in the mirror-play of four relations to the world: to the ground, to the heavens, to the sacred, and to death. What gathers them is not a jug but a call—the prophecy that names three boys and a girl, the telepathic voice that summons them one by one, and at the end the prayer that gathers the whole world around them. Read this way, the party of *EarthBound* is a small image of what Heidegger called dwelling, transposed from the farmhouse to the suburb, from the jug to the telephone, from the poet's hut to the children's journey.

Time Out of Joint: Prophecy, Duration, and the Rolling Meter 5.7

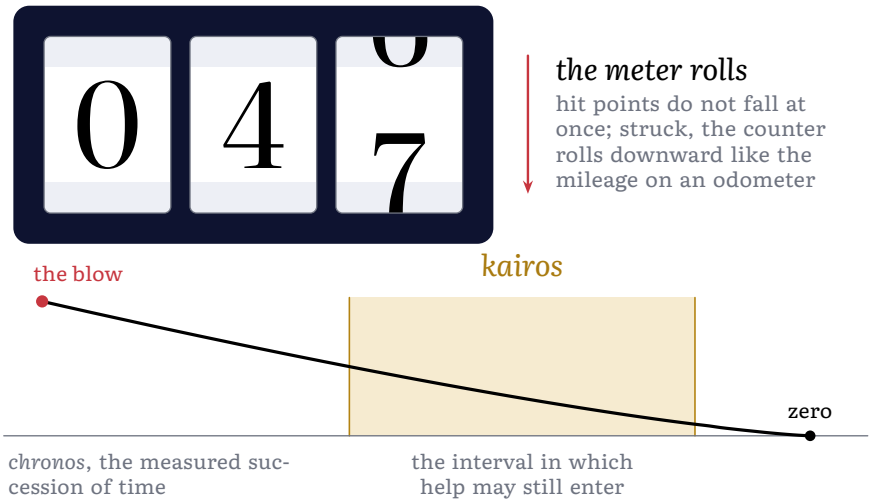
The game's time is out of joint. Its first messenger comes from ten years in the future, a future already destroyed, and the prophecy he carries, which he attributes to a source called the Apple of Enlightenment, names the children who will undo that future before they have met one another. Its final battle takes place in the past, against an enemy who, in Dr. Andonuts's formulation, is attacking from their exact location but from many years ago. Its human villain escapes into time, and its sequel finds him there, grown ancient without growing up. Hamlet's lament fits the shape of the whole: "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!" A son charged with setting time right is the protagonist of Shakespeare's tragedy and of Itoi's comedy alike. The difference is that Hamlet inherits the charge from a father's ghost, while Ness receives it from a dying insect and carries it out in a machine built by someone else's father. Jacques Derrida's *Spectres de Marx* (1993) took Hamlet's line as the motto of a "hauntology," a thinking of the present as visited by what is not present—the dead and the not yet born. *EarthBound* is haunted in both directions: by a future that has already happened and by a past that is still attacking.

Two console role-playing games of 1994–95 located the cosmic enemy in the deep past of the earth. *Chrono Trigger* (Square, 1995) imagines a parasite called Lavos that falls from the sky in a prehistoric age, burrows into the planet, feeds on it for millions of years, and rises in

1999 to destroy civilization; its heroes travel among the eras to prevent that day. *EarthBound* shares the structure—an alien lodged in the earth's past, threatening its future—but reverses its emphasis. *Chrono Trigger*'s heroes master time. Itoi's children are carried through it once, at the cost of their bodies. Robert Zemeckis's *Back to the Future* (1985), in which a suburban teenager must ensure in 1955 that his parents fall in love, gave popular culture its definitive image of time travel as a household drama. And Fujiko F. Fujio's *Doraemon* sends a robot from the twenty-second century through a hapless boy's desk drawer to improve his descendants' fortunes. Buzz Buzz is a stricken Doraemon: the helper from the future who dies on arrival, leaving the boy only a stone and a task. Osamu Tezuka's *Hi no tori* (*Phoenix*, 1954–88), whose volumes alternate between the remote past and the remote future and converge upon the present, supplied the most ambitious Japanese model of such a time.

Within this disjointed time the game installs a remarkable device for measuring the time of a single life. Hit points in *EarthBound* do not fall at once. When a character is struck, the counter rolls downward like the mileage on an odometer, and a blow that would be fatal does not kill immediately. The meter begins its descent toward zero, and if the player acts in time—healing the character, or ending the battle—the descent stops and the character lives. The game converts death from a point into a duration. Henri Bergson's *Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience* (1889) opposed to the spatialized time of clocks, measured in homogeneous and interchangeable units, the *durée* of lived experience: qualitative, continuous, and heterogeneous, a time in which each moment is coloured by those before it. The rolling meter is a peculiar hybrid. It is a mechanical counter, the very image of measured time, that nevertheless restores to death the character of duration: something that happens over time, within which something else can still happen.

Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death in *Sein und Zeit* argued that death is not an event at the end of life but a possibility that structures existence from within—the ownmost possibility, certain and indefinite, in relation to which a life is gathered. The rolling meter is a ludic image of this structure, compressed into the span of a battle: the fatal blow has fallen, death is certain if nothing intervenes, and the time that remains is a time of decision. Walter Benjamin's last text, the theses "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940), closed with an image drawn from Jewish messianic expectation, in which every



The rolling meter converts death from a point into a duration. After the blow the counter descends toward zero, and grace has the shape of the interval between (§ 5.7).

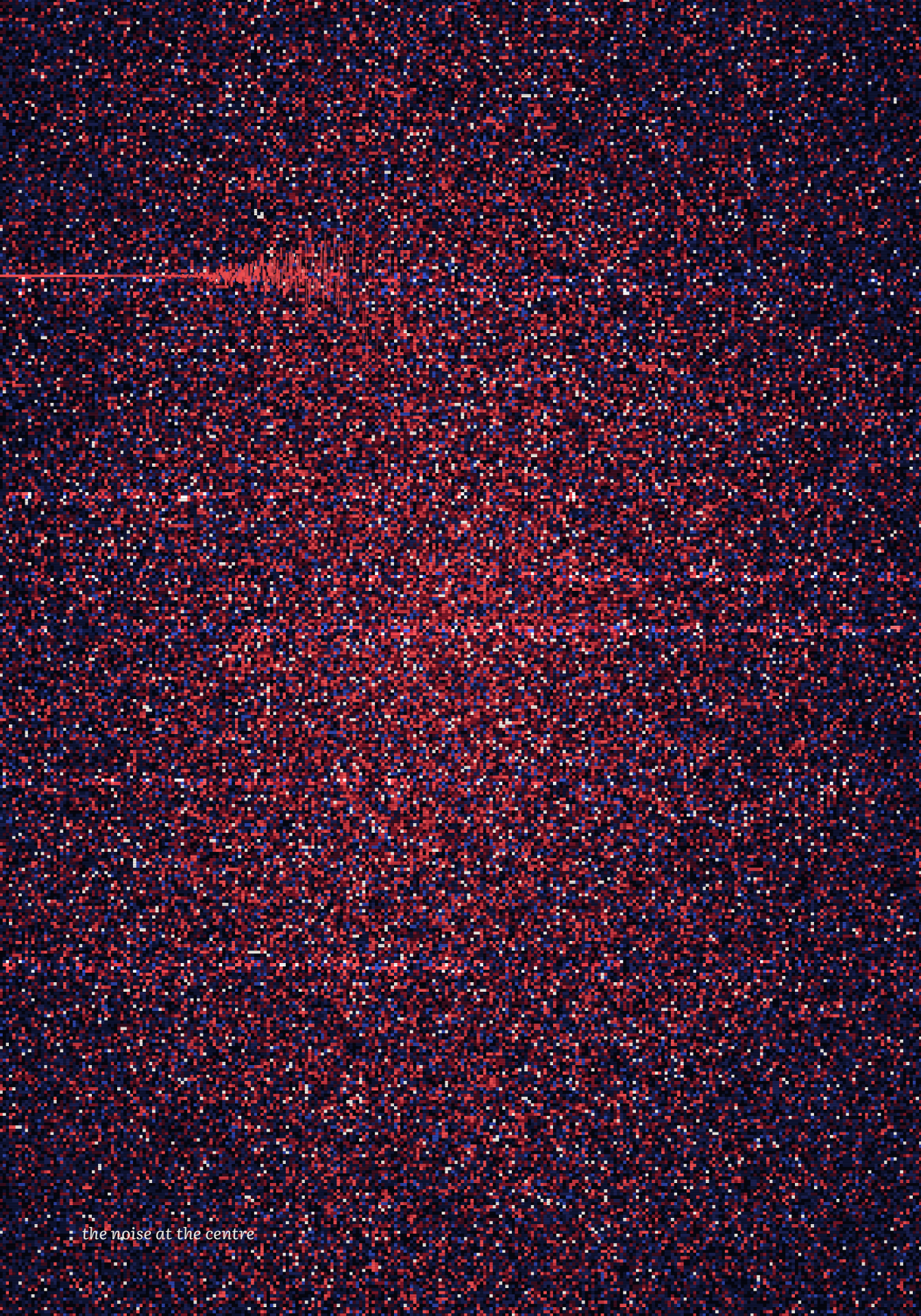
second of time was the strait gate through which the Messiah might enter. The rolling meter makes every second of a dying the strait gate through which help may enter. Greek distinguished *chronos*, the measured succession of time, from *kairos*, the opportune moment that breaks into it. The meter is *chronos* made visible, and the player's intervention is *kairos*. Grace, in this game, has the shape of an interval: the time between the blow and the zero.

Prophecy poses an old question. If the outcome is foretold, is the hero free? Boethius, in the *Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), answered that divine foreknowledge does not compel, because God sees all times in an eternal present, as a spectator on a height sees what happens below without causing it. *EarthBound* gives a different and humbler answer, implicit in its vocabulary. The prophecy does not determine the children; it calls them. Dr. Andonuts's last words before the passage—activate the machine by your own hand, and so follow your own destiny—join destiny to consent. The Latin *vocatio*, from *vocare*, "to call," gave the European languages their word for a destiny that must be answered: a vocation. Destiny, in this game, is a call that becomes real only when it is accepted. It is telephonic grace in the mode of time.

Pokey's fate supplies the counter-image. Having fled into time in a stolen machine, he reappears in *Mother 3* as a being of incalculable age

who never grew up, ruling a world of manufactured happiness and finally sealing himself inside a capsule from which nothing can ever remove him. His time is the opposite of the rolling meter’s: not a finite duration open to intervention but an endless one closed against it. The child who refused every call ends in a time no call can reach. Ness’s time is mortal and therefore open; Pokey’s is immortal and therefore sealed.

The children have now been emptied and carried into the past. They are small metal figures in a cave whose walls seem to breathe, at the far end of a time that has come unjointed, facing an enemy whom no weapon can touch. They have done everything a self can do: gathered the earth’s harmony, defeated the idol within, relinquished their bodies, and consented to their vocation. What remains is the encounter with the other nothing, the nihility that has become a cosmos. Chapter 6 turns to Giygas.


the noise at the centre

6

"You Cannot Grasp the True Form"

Giygas and the Metaphysics of Evil

> "The other shape, / If shape it might be call'd that shape had none / Distinguishable in member, joint, or limb …"
>
> *John Milton, Paradise Lost (1667), II.666–68*

> "Fathers and teachers, I ponder, 'What is hell?' I maintain that it is the suffering of being unable to love."
>
> *Fyodor Dostoevsky, The Brothers Karamazov (1880), trans. Constance Garnett (1912)*

EVERY ARGUMENT OF THIS dissertation converges on a single figure. Giygas is the negative pole of the game's cosmology, the point at which gravity meets noise, and the game's achievement is to render evil not as a rival will but as the collapse of addressability. This chapter traces Giygas's genealogy as the orphan of the first game (6.1); reads his rendering as background, noise, and parasite (6.2); interprets his mindlessness through Augustine and Arendt (6.3) and his infantile ambivalence through Kristeva, Rank, Lynch, and Ōtomo (6.4); measures him against the theory of the sublime (6.5); examines Itoi's account of the childhood film scene behind his dialogue (6.6); and proposes, through Isaac of Nineveh and Dostoevsky, why the only weapon that can touch him is love (6.7).

6.1 From Giegue to Giygas: The Orphan of Mother

Giygas has a childhood. In the backstory of *Mother*, a couple from the American countryside, George and Maria, were carried off by aliens early in the twentieth century. George came back, bearing knowledge of the aliens' psychic science that he had taken without leave; Maria did not. In her captivity she raised an alien infant as her own, and she sang to him. That infant, grown into the commander of the invasion the first game repels, is Giegue—in Japanese *Gīgu*, the name the English localization of the second game turned into Giygas. At the climax of *Mother*, on a peak the English localization named Mount Itoi, Giegue confronts Maria's great-grandson Ninten. Still grieving the woman who raised him, he invites the boy to come away with him to his own world. Ninten refuses, and the children sing the lullaby whose eight fragments they have gathered across the continent. Overwhelmed by the memory of being loved, Giegue withdraws, promising to return.

The Japanese subtitle of the sequel, *Gīgu no Gyakushū*, "Giegue's Counterattack," names that return as retaliation. But the being who returns is no longer a character in the usual sense. In the final battle Pokey, now his servant, explains what has become of him. Giygas is no longer the wielder of evil but its embodiment, a power he cannot control; he can no longer think rationally and is not even aware of what he is doing; his own incredible power has destroyed his mind. Pokey calls him an "all-mighty idiot." To contain that power Pokey has sealed him in a contraption called the Devil's Machine, an organic-looking apparatus at whose centre floats an image resembling Ness's own face. When the children have defeated Pokey, he switches the machine off. The stage dissolves into a swirling void, and the battle with Giygas proper begins.

Read across the two games, Giygas is the series' orphan: a child raised by a human mother and separated from her, the one being in a world threaded with telephones who has no home to call. The title of the series acquires its full force in him. *Mother* cannot help but resonate with John Lennon's "Mother" (1970), the opening track of *John Lennon/Plastic Ono Band*, composed in the wake of Arthur Janov's primal therapy, whose manifesto, *The Primal Scream*, appeared the same year: a song addressed to a mother who left and a father who never came, which ends in the repeated scream of an abandoned child. No influence is claimed; the resonance is structural. Giygas's

last utterances—Ness's name repeated, "It hurts," "I'm so sad," "I feel good," "I'm happy"—have the shape of a primal scream in Janov's sense: the pre-verbal pain of the unparented child, returning as cosmic catastrophe.

The face at the centre of the Devil's Machine deserves attention. Before his release, the cosmic destroyer shows the player the face of the hero. Lacan's account of the mirror stage (1949) described the infant's jubilant identification with its own image in a mirror, an identification that founds the ego in a misrecognition: the self first appears to itself as an image outside itself. The final enemy of *EarthBound* appears first as Ness's mirror, just as the inmost enemy of Magicant wore the golden statue's form. The game twice refuses to locate evil wholly outside the hero. Giygas is, among other things, what a child becomes without a mother, without a home, without a voice to call him back: the hero's negative image, the unloved child wearing the face of the loved one. Weil's maxim, cited in Chapter 3, applies with full force. Whoever is uprooted uproots others. Giygas is the uprooted orphan who would uproot the world.

Ground Without Figure: Giygas as Background, Noise, and Parasite 6.2

Every battle in *EarthBound* is composed of two layers. In front stands the enemy, a drawn sprite; behind it undulates a battle background, a field of shifting colour and pattern produced by the Super Famicom's layered backgrounds and line-by-line distortion effects. The background is decoration, the ground against which the figure appears. In the final phase of the battle with Giygas, the figure disappears. There is no sprite. The enemy is the background itself, a churning red-and-black vortex in which, now and then, a face surfaces and sinks. Players have noticed, too, that the effect that ends the battle resembles a television being switched off, and that the static accompanying it recalls the static that precedes the game's title screen.

Gestalt psychology formalized the distinction on which this effect depends. Edgar Rubin's studies of visual perception (*Synsoplevede Figurer*, 1915), the source of the famous vase that is also two faces, showed that perception organizes a field into a figure, which stands out and has a shape, and a ground, which recedes, lacks contour, and seems to continue behind the figure. The ground has no form of its own; that is

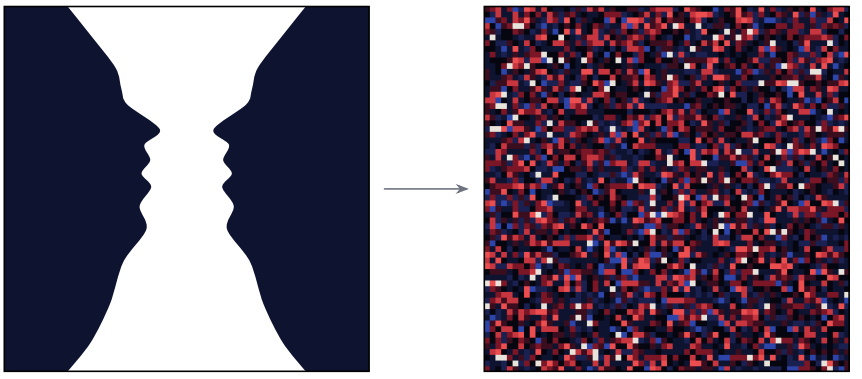


figure and ground
a vase, or two faces (Rubin, 1915)

ground without figure
there is no sprite; the background itself turns hostile

Perception organizes a field into a figure and a ground. In the final battle the figure disappears and the ground becomes the antagonist: the medium is the enemy (§ 6.2).

what makes it ground. Giygas is ground without figure: not an enemy in the world but the world's background turned hostile. Marshall and Eric McLuhan's *Laws of Media* (1988) made figure and ground the key to media analysis, arguing that the environment a medium creates is a ground that remains invisible until some disturbance brings it forward as figure. In the final battle the game's own rendering layer—the medium in which every previous battle took place—is brought forward and becomes the antagonist. The medium is not the message here. The medium is the enemy.

This is why noise is the right name for Giygas. Shannon defined noise as whatever perturbs a channel so that the received signal cannot be distinguished from randomness, and the snow of an untuned television is its most familiar image. The final battle borrows the imagery and the acoustics of that snow: a crackling, droning soundscape in place of a battle theme, a screen that churns like interference, an ending that looks like a set going dark. Serres's parasite, introduced in Chapter 1, is equally exact—the third term that lodges in a channel and feeds on it, the uninvited guest who eats without giving. Giygas is lodged in the earth's past and feeds on its future, and before the final confrontation his influence is a parasitic static in the social channel, making neighbours unrecognizable to one another. Pokey, who

attaches himself to one host after another, is the parasite at human scale.

The battle text completes the picture. In every other battle the window beneath the action names each attack: who used what, upon whom, to what effect. Against Giygas the window reports only its own failure: "You cannot grasp the true form of Giygas's attack!" The sentence is a message about the absence of a message. In Jakobson's terms it turns the metalingual function, which normally checks the code, against itself; the code reports that it cannot decode. Nothing in the interface has broken. The interface is telling the truth about what it faces.

Chapter 1 placed Giygas at the junction of gravity and noise and proposed the black hole as his emblem: a mass so dense that its gravity forbids any signal to escape. The image now has its full sense. Giygas is power collapsed upon itself, a mind crushed by its own force, a vortex from which no communication returns. The red spiral of his final form resembles nothing so much as an accretion disk seen face-on. And like a black hole, he is visible only by his effects on what surrounds him: the warped space of the background, the failure of the text, the children's falling hit points.

There is a domestic irony in all this. The medium Giygas inhabits is the medium through which the game is played, a television in a living room. Tobe Hooper's *Poltergeist*, discussed in Chapter 3, imagined television static as the portal through which the dead seize a suburban child. *EarthBound* makes the same static the face of the ultimate enemy and then, as Chapter 7 shows, sends a prayer through it. The household medium contains its own abyss, and the game's answer to that abyss is addressed to the person sitting in front of the screen.

Privation and Thoughtlessness: Augustine, Arendt, and the Mindless Power 6.3

For nearly a decade in his youth Augustine of Hippo was a hearer among the Manichaeans, followers of the third-century Persian prophet Mani, who taught that the cosmos is a battlefield between two co-eternal principles, Light and Darkness, and that evil is a substance in its own right. His break with Manichaeism, recounted in the seventh book of the *Confessions*, turned on a single conclusion: whatever exists is good insofar as it exists, and evil is not a substance at all.

In the *Enchiridion* (c. 421) he gave the conclusion its classic formula—what is called evil is nothing but the privation of good (*privatio boni*)—and its classic image. Disease and wounds in a body are the absence of health; when the body is healed they do not go somewhere else but simply cease to be. So evil has no being of its own, only a lack in what is.

Giygas is a privation in this strict sense. He is not a rival principle of darkness opposed to the light of the children's world. He has no form, no mind, no plan, and in the end no being; when the battle concludes he does not go anywhere, he ceases, and the screen goes dark as a television does when no signal remains. By an accident of nomenclature, the golden idol through which his influence spreads bears a name, Mani Mani, that recalls the very prophet of dualism Augustine renounced; the game, like Augustine, refuses dualism too. The consequence is decisive for the shape of the final battle. A substance can be overpowered by a greater substance. A privation cannot be overpowered at all, because there is nothing there to defeat; it can only be filled. This is why the children's weapons and psychic powers cannot touch Giygas. Adding force to a power that is already limitless only feeds it. What can end a privation is the good it lacks.

Hannah Arendt reached a cognate diagnosis from another direction. Reporting on the trial of Adolf Eichmann in Jerusalem in 1961, she expected a monster and found a functionary—a man neither demonic nor stupid but marked by what she called sheer thoughtlessness. *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963) gave the condition its notorious name, the banality of evil, and drew a connection that bears directly on this dissertation. The longer one listened to Eichmann, Arendt observed, the more evident it became that his inability to speak was bound up with an inability to think, that is, to think from the standpoint of anyone else. Her late work, from the lecture "Thinking and Moral Considerations" (1971) to the unfinished *The Life of the Mind* (1978), asked whether the activity of thinking itself—the silent dialogue of the self with itself—might condition human beings against evildoing.

Giygas is thoughtlessness raised to a cosmic power. He cannot think rationally; he is not aware of what he does; he cannot take the standpoint of another, because there is no longer any standpoint from which he could do so. His speech is the speech of a being who has lost the inner dialogue Arendt took to be the root of conscience: fragments, repetitions, a name said over and over. And the game's

other evils are banal in exactly Arendt's sense. The townspeople grow cranky, the police officious, the neighbour envious, the tycoon greedy, the cult conformist. None of them is demonic, and most, once freed from the statue's influence, apologize. At the centre of all this ordinary thoughtlessness stands its absolute form, a power without a mind, an "all-mighty idiot." The game's metaphysics of evil thus joins Augustine's ontology to Arendt's phenomenology: evil is privation in its being and thoughtlessness in its operation.

Simone Weil adds a final, compassionate turn. In "L'Amour de Dieu et le malheur" (written in 1942), she distinguished affliction (*malheur*) from mere suffering: an uprooting of life that seizes the body, the social standing, and the soul together, and that makes its victims into things, anonymous and mute. Giygas's speech—"It hurts," "I'm so sad"—is the speech of affliction. He is evil's embodiment and also its first casualty, a being crushed into thinghood by the very power he has become. The game does not ask the player to hate him. It asks the player to hear him.

The Abject Infant: Kristeva, Rank, Lynch, Ōtomo 6.4

Giygas's utterances during the final battle are among the most discussed lines in the history of video games. They come in broken syllables, as though spelled out one sound at a time: the hero's name, repeated dozens of times; "It hurts"; "I'm so sad"; "friends"; "go back"; "it's not right"; "I feel good"; "I'm happy." They oscillate between pain and pleasure, grief and contentment, without transition. Players have long heard in them the voice of an infant, and some have taken the hint further. The cave in which the battle takes place has walls of an organic, fleshy texture; the final background seems, in some phases, to disclose a fetal form; and from these details fans have built readings of Giygas as an unborn child and of the battle as an allegory of birth, or of abortion. The game neither confirms nor forbids these readings. What it unmistakably stages is the infantile.

Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) supplies the concept. The abject, for Kristeva, is neither subject nor object but what disturbs identity, system, and order—what does not respect borders, positions, rules. Its paradigm is the corpse, the most violent reminder of what the living must thrust aside in order to live; its origin is the infant's earliest and most violent separation from the maternal body, the abjection by which a self first draws its boundary against what it

was. The abject repels and fascinates at once, and its experience is a *jouissance* in which pleasure and horror are not yet distinguished. Giygas is the abject in its cosmic form. He has no boundary, no form, no position; he is neither a subject, since he has no mind, nor an object, since he has no shape; and his cries confound pain and pleasure precisely as Kristeva describes. He is the being who never completed the separation that makes a self.

Otto Rank's *Das Trauma der Geburt* (1924), the book that ended his collaboration with Freud, proposed that birth is the primal trauma, the prototype of all later anxiety, and that much of mental life is an attempt to master or to undo it. If the Cave of the Past is a womb and Giygas a fetus, the final battle can be read as a scene of birth, or of its refusal. Ness, the born and mothered child, who has just passed through his own interior and given up his own body, faces the unborn and unmothered one. The reading need not be pressed literally to be illuminating. The game's deepest antagonism is between a child who has been received into the world and a being who never was.

Three works of the comparative corpus stage the same figure. David Lynch's *Eraserhead* (1977), made over several years and set in an industrial wasteland of sound, gives its hapless hero a deformed and ceaselessly crying infant, which he finally destroys, unleashing an apocalyptic vision; the film's droning industrial soundscape, created with Alan Splet, is the nearest cinematic equivalent of the soundscape of the Giygas battle. Katsuhiro Ōtomo's *Akira* (manga, 1982–90; film, 1988) gives the figure its most precise Japanese form. The teenager Tetsuo, whose psychic powers grow beyond his capacity to contain them, loses control of his body, which swells into a monstrous mass of flesh that engulfs everything around it while he cries out for his friend Kaneda; the power that has destroyed his mind and body finally collapses into a singularity from which a new universe seems to emerge. Giygas is Tetsuo's cosmic successor: a psychic being whose power has destroyed his mind, crying out the name of a boy. Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) supplies the redemptive counter-image. After the psychedelic passage of the Star Gate, the astronaut is reborn as a Star Child, a fetus in a luminous sphere gazing down upon the earth. *EarthBound* stands between *Akira*'s catastrophe and *2001*'s rebirth. Its fetal cosmos is a power that has destroyed itself, and its ending leaves open whether what follows is annihilation or release.

One feature of Giygas's speech has escaped most commentary. Among the fragments, he calls a name. Over and over, he says "Ness."

The noise contains a vestigial address. A being who can no longer think, reason, or recognize can still do the most primitive thing that speech does: call. The infant's cry is the first vocative, a call without words for a presence that is not there, and Giygas's repetition of the hero's name is that cry in its last surviving form. The final battle, then, is not a contest between address and its absolute absence. It is a contest between a full address—the children's world, held together by voices—and a ruined one, a call that can no longer be heard as a call. Chapter 7 argues that the prayer answers it.

The Sublime Withheld: Burke, Kant, Lyotard, Lovecraft 6.5

Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) made obscurity a principal source of the sublime. "To make any thing very terrible," he wrote, "obscurity seems in general to be necessary," since it is our ignorance of things that excites our passions most; and he chose as his supreme example Milton's portrait of Death in the second book of *Paradise Lost*: a shape that had no shape distinguishable in member, joint, or limb, a substance that seemed a shadow and a shadow that seemed a substance. Burke admired the passage because nothing in it is clear; all is dark, uncertain, confused. Giygas is Milton's Death rendered in pixels. The game withholds his form entirely, and the only words it offers about his attack confess that its form cannot be grasped.

Kant's *Kritik der Urteilskraft* (1790) located the sublime in a failure of imagination. In the mathematical sublime, imagination strains to comprehend a magnitude in a single intuition and cannot; in that failure the mind discovers in itself a faculty—reason, with its idea of totality—superior to every measure of sense. The sublime, Kant observed, can be found even in an object devoid of form, insofar as it provokes a representation of limitlessness. In the dynamically sublime, nature's might appears as a power that has no dominion over us, provided we behold it from safety. The final battle of *EarthBound* stages the first moment of Kant's analysis and withholds the second. Imagination fails before Giygas, as it should. But the safety condition, which Chapter 3 identified with the house on the hill, has been deliberately removed. The children are robots in the deep past, as far from home as the game allows, in a cave from which there is no exit. And the mind's recovery does not come from reason. It comes from prayer: not the superiority of a faculty within the self, but an appeal to others beyond it.

Jean-François Lyotard rewrote the Kantian sublime as the key to modern and postmodern art. In "Réponse à la question: qu'est-ce que le postmoderne?" (1982) he argued that modern art devotes its technique to presenting the fact that the unpresentable exists, while the postmodern puts forward the unpresentable in presentation itself, denying itself the solace of good forms. The battle text "You cannot grasp the true form of Giygas's attack!" is postmodern in exactly this sense. It does not represent Giygas's attack; it represents, in the interface's own idiom, the impossibility of representing it. The sentence puts the unpresentable forward within the presentation, and it may be the most philosophically exact single line in any video game.

The popular literature of cosmic horror had prepared this territory. H. P. Lovecraft's "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens by calling the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents the most merciful thing in the world. At the centre of Lovecraft's cosmos sits Azathoth, the blind idiot god, a mindless daemon-sultan bubbling at the heart of infinity and lulled by the thin, monotonous piping of flutes. Giygas, the "all-mighty idiot" at the centre of *EarthBound*'s cosmos, is Azathoth's kin: limitless power without mind. Lovecraft's "The Colour Out of Space" (1927) supplies an even closer figure. A meteorite falls on a farm in the hills west of Arkham, bringing with it a colour that can be called a colour only by analogy, which seeps into the soil, the water, and the family, drains them of life, and drives them mad. The meteorite in the backyard opens both works. In Lovecraft it brings an unrepresentable poison; in Itoi it brings a messenger. Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011) describes cosmic horror as the attempt to think the world-without-us, a world indifferent to human beings and unthinkable by them. *EarthBound* shares that vision only at its outer edge. An idiot god stands at the centre of its cosmos, but the game refuses Lovecraft's conclusion that human beings are therefore insignificant. It answers the mindless power with the most fragile human act it knows.

Two further vocabularies complete the picture. Georges Bataille's entry "Informe" in the critical dictionary of the review *Documents* (1929) proposed that "formless" is not merely an adjective but a term that serves to bring things down in the world, and that to affirm that the universe resembles nothing and is only formless amounts to saying that it is something like a spider or spit. Rosalind Krauss and Yve-Alain Bois's *Formless: A User's Guide* (1997) made the concept an instrument of art history. Giygas is the universe declassified, the cos-

mos as *informe*. And Rudolf Otto's numinous, the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* of Chapter 3, appears in him with its fascination stripped away. Giygas is tremendous without being fascinating: the holy's shadow, a numinous that has lost its face. What the prayer restores, as Chapter 7 shows, is the second term of Otto's formula—the attraction of a presence that loves.

The Scene Behind the Screen: Itoi's Primal Cinema 6.6

In a series of interviews published on *Hobonichi Itoi Shinbun* in April 2003, Itoi gave an account of the origin of Giygas's dialogue that has since become one of the most retold anecdotes in the history of games. As a small child he wandered by mistake into the wrong screening at a cinema and saw part of *Kenpei to barabara shibijin* (*The Military Policeman and the Dismembered Beauty*), a Shintoho thriller of 1957 directed by Kyōtarō Namiki, which follows the investigation of a young woman's dismembered body found in a well in 1937. He saw a scene beside a river that he took to be a rape; it was in fact the murder that the film's investigation reconstructs. The image disturbed him so badly that his parents worried about him. Decades later, writing the final battle, he drew on the memory. He has described what he saw as a combination of atrocity and eroticism, and has said that this is what Giygas's lines are. He dictated them aloud, syllable by syllable, while a member of the staff wrote them down, because the broken syllables were more frightening. He has insisted that he took from the film no images, sounds, or words—a misunderstanding that has hardened into internet legend—but only something like its power over a spectator's emotions. And he has described Giygas as something people cannot make sense of, and as a living being who deserves love.

Psychoanalysis has a name for such a scene. In the case history of the "Wolf Man" ("Aus der Geschichte einer infantilen Neurose," 1918), Freud reconstructed a primal scene (*Urszene*): the infant's witnessing of parental intercourse, which the child understood as an act of violence. He emphasized that the scene's traumatic meaning was not fixed at the moment of perception but conferred later, through what he called *Nachträglichkeit*—deferred action, or afterwardsness—in which an earlier impression is reworked and acquires its force in the light of later development. Jean Laplanche and Jean-Bertrand Pontalis made the concept central to their *Vocabulaire de la psychanalyse* (1967). Itoi's anecdote is a primal scene with its terms inverted: a

child witnesses a violent act and takes it for a sexual one. And its meaning is conferred afterwards, nearly four decades later, in the composition of a game. The final battle with Giygas is Itoi's *Nachträglichkeit*, the moment at which an image that a child could neither understand nor forget received its form.

The anecdote clarifies the strangest feature of Giygas's speech, its confusion of pain and pleasure. "It hurts" and "I feel good" are spoken by the same voice without transition because they derive from a child's inability to tell the one from the other in what he saw. Evil, in this account, is not a will but an indistinction: the collapse of the difference between hurting and loving. In this dissertation's vocabulary it is noise in the affective channel, a signal in which the most important distinction a person must learn to make can no longer be made. Giygas is not cruel. He is confused, and his confusion is a catastrophe.

The method of composition is equally telling. Itoi did not write Giygas's lines; he spoke them, one syllable at a time, and they were transcribed in hiragana, the script in which Japanese children first learn to read. The address of the final enemy was produced as a voice breaking into its smallest phonetic units and preserved in the alphabet of childhood. Lacan read the *fort* and *da* of Freud's grandson as the moment at which absence enters language through the opposition of phonemes. Giygas's syllables run the process backward. They are language decomposing into phonemes, address dissolving toward the cry from which it came.

The anecdote demands care. It has been distorted into the claim that the game reproduces material from the film, which Itoi's own account contradicts, and it has licensed sexualized readings of the final battle that the game's text neither states nor requires. The scholarly task is neither to sensationalize the story nor to suppress it, but to see what it explains. It explains why the evil at the centre of the game is figured as a confusion rather than an intention, why it speaks like a child, and why its defeat cannot come from force. It also explains something about the player's position. The child Itoi was an accidental spectator, unable to leave the scene or to act within it. The player of the final battle is likewise trapped—there is no exit from the Cave of the Past—but is not powerless. The game converts the helpless spectatorship of the primal scene into address. The witness becomes the one who is asked to pray.

The Scourge of Love: Isaac of Nineveh, Zosima, and the Damnation of the Unloved 6.7

The final battle poses a question its admirers usually answer too quickly. Why does prayer wound Giygas? Every weapon fails against him and every psychic power is turned aside; yet when Paula prays, and her prayer passes from the children to their families and friends and onward, each prayer draws a new cry from the darkness, and the last, which reaches the player, ends him. The common answer is the power of friendship: love is stronger than hate. The answer is true but incomplete. It does not explain why love should hurt the one it reaches, nor why Giygas's response to it is not simply pain but pain and pleasure at once. For that, this dissertation turns to the theology of the Church of the East.

Isaac of Nineveh, also called Isaac the Syrian, was a seventh-century monk who served briefly as bishop of Nineveh before withdrawing to the solitude of the mountains of Khuzistan. His ascetical homilies, written in Syriac and translated into Greek by the ninth century, became one of the most widely read works of Eastern Christian spirituality. In one of their most celebrated passages Isaac maintains that those who are punished in Gehenna are scourged by the scourge of love. It would be wrong, he argues, to imagine that sinners in Gehenna are deprived of the love of God, for love is given to all without distinction. But the power of love works in two ways. It torments sinners, as happens even in this life when a friend suffers from a friend, and it becomes a source of joy for those who have kept its duties. Hell, for Isaac, is not the absence of love but its presence to those who cannot receive it; the torment is the grief of having turned against love, experienced in love's own light.

Fyodor Dostoevsky knew Isaac's homilies, and *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880) carries their mark. In the novel the old servant Grigory reads the sayings of Isaac the Syrian for years, understanding little of them, and the elder Zosima's discourse on hell restates Isaac's doctrine in modern form. Hell, Zosima says, is the suffering of being unable to love. Once, in the infinity of existence, a spiritual creature was given the capacity for active love, and it rejected the gift; now, having passed beyond the earth, it sees the love it might have given and can no longer give it. Were such a creature offered paradise, Zosima suggests, its torment would only increase, for it would see love in others and be unable to answer it.

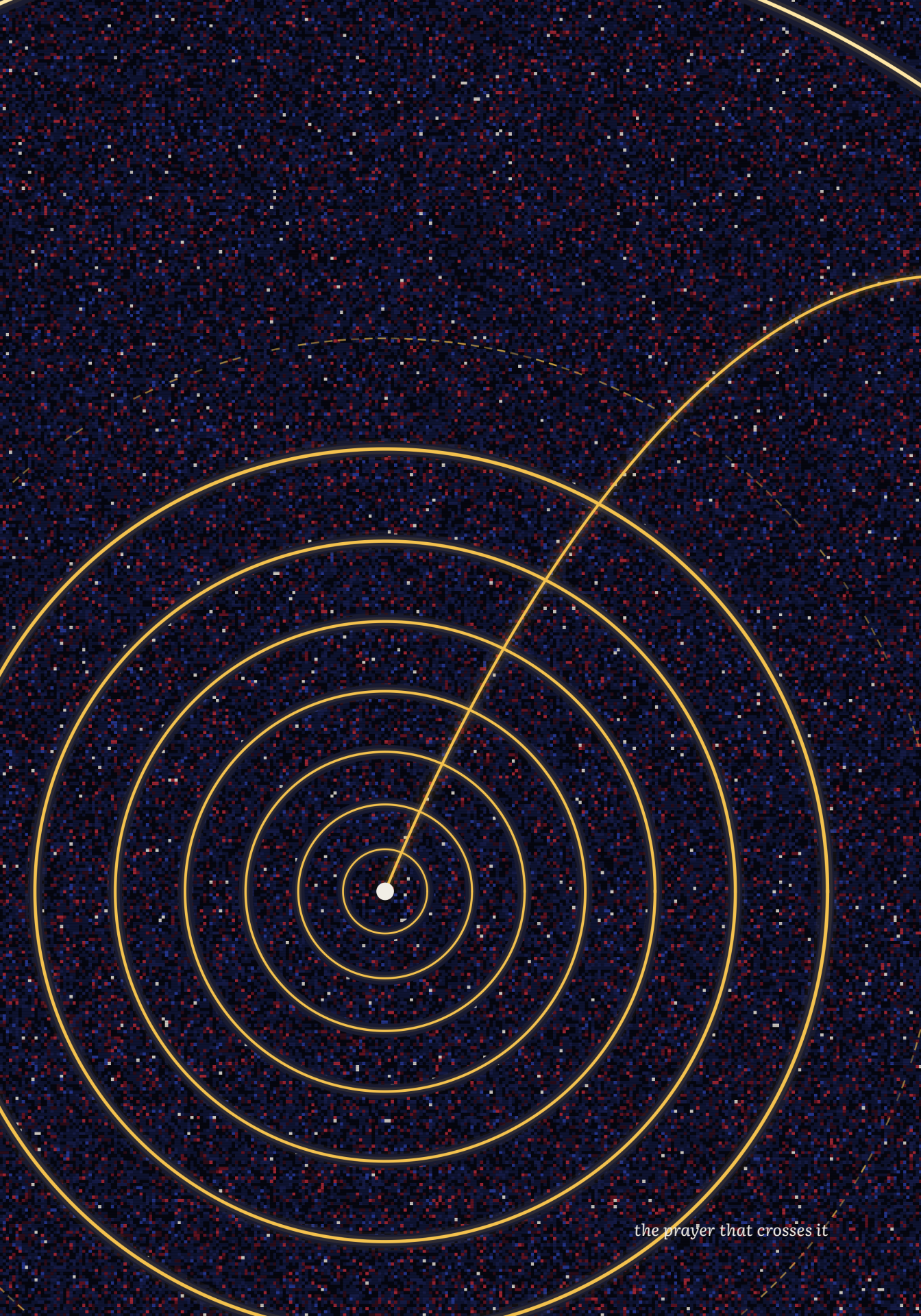
Read through Isaac and Zosima, the final battle becomes intelligible in its strangest details. Giygas is the being Zosima describes: a creature given love—raised by a human mother who sang to him—who lost the capacity to love and now cannot even think. The prayer that reaches him is not a weapon in the ordinary sense. It is love, sent through the voices of everyone the children have met, toward a being who cannot receive it. Love works on him in both of Isaac's ways at once, and because he can no longer tell them apart, he reports both at once: it hurts, it feels good; I'm so sad, I'm happy. His ambivalence, which Section 6.6 traced to a child's confusion of violence and eroticism, receives here its theological reading. It is the double action of love upon a being in whom the capacity to receive has been destroyed. Among his last fragments is a protest—"it's not right"—as though the vestige of a conscience flickered for a moment in the noise.

This reading accords with Itoi's own description of Giygas as a living being who deserves love, and it answers, at least in part, the objection Ivan Karamazov would raise. Ivan returned his ticket to any harmony purchased with the tears of a tortured child, and Giygas, in the final battle, is a tortured child of a kind. Does the world's salvation require his suffering? The game's answer is that it requires his being loved. Nothing in the final battle is done to Giygas out of hatred. No character curses him, and the decisive act is a prayer whose content is help for the children, not harm to their enemy. If Giygas suffers from it, he suffers as Isaac's damned suffer, from the presence of a love he cannot bear. The game does not pretend that this is painless. It makes the player hear the pain.

Isaac took one further step, which Christian tradition has always found difficult. In a group of homilies long thought lost and identified in 1983 by Sebastian Brock in a manuscript in the Bodleian Library—the so-called Second Part—he expressed the hope that the torments of Gehenna would not be eternal, that the love which scourges would in the end heal, and that all creatures would finally be restored. The hope places him in the lineage of Origen and Gregory of Nyssa and their doctrine of *apokatastasis*, the restoration of all things. *EarthBound*'s ending leaves the question exactly where Isaac's tradition leaves it: open. Giygas's last syllables include "I'm happy" and "I feel good" as well as "It hurts." When the prayer reaches its final addressee the darkness collapses, and the screen falls silent like a television switched off. Whether that silence is annihilation or rest, the game

does not say. It is the one question the game declines to answer, and its refusal is a form of reverence.

The difference between the first and second games can now be stated precisely. In *Mother*, Giegue was turned back by a lullaby: love remembered, the song of a mother he had lost. In *Mother 2* he is beyond remembering. He can no longer be reminded of love; he can only be reached by it, from outside, by voices he does not know. The first game's weapon was memory. The second game's is address. That is why its final weapon is not a song but a prayer, and why the prayer must pass through the whole world before it arrives. Chapter 7 follows it.


the prayer that crosses it

7

"Paula Prayed"

Telephonic Grace and the Soteriology of Address

> *L'attention, à son plus haut degré, est la même chose que la prière.*
>
> Simone Weil, La Pesanteur et la grâce (1947)

> "Mr. Watson—come here—I want to see you."
>
> *Alexander Graham Bell, the first sentence transmitted by telephone, 10 March 1876*

THE DISSERTATION'S ARGUMENT CULMINATES in a sequence lasting a few minutes. In the Cave of the Past, against an enemy no weapon can touch, a girl in a robot body prays, and her prayer passes through the world until it reaches the person holding the controller. This chapter reads that sequence as the fulfilment of telephonic grace. It describes the final battle as a liturgy (7.1); reconstructs the phenomenology of prayer it enacts (7.2); analyses the prayer as an inversion of interpellation and as a phatic act (7.3); situates it in the history of dissemination, telepathy, and the telephone (7.4); interprets the address to the player by name (7.5); reads the photographs of the closing credits as a work of mourning and return (7.6); and argues that the battle completes the operation this dissertation has called counter-copy, converting attention into prayer (7.7).

7.1 The Final Battle as Liturgy

The final battle unfolds in phases. In the first, the four children—small robots now, their bodies left behind in Saturn Valley—face Pokey, enthroned in a mechanical walker beside the Devil's Machine, at whose centre floats the image of Ness's face. When Pokey has been beaten back, he switches the machine off, and the stage dissolves into a churning red void. Giygas is released, and with him the battle text that confesses the limit of every representation: the true form of his attack cannot be grasped. The children's weapons and psychic powers now pass through him without effect. Ness, Jeff, and Poo can only endure, guard, and heal. One command remains. Paula prays.

The prayer is the same command that, throughout the game, produced random and mostly useless effects. Here it produces a liturgy. Each time Paula prays, the screen leaves the cave and shows people the children have met, in the places where they live, joining her prayer; each time, the force of their prayer strikes Giygas, who answers with a new cry; and with each turn the circle widens. Once, after the prayer has reached Ness's own mother, the game reports that Paula's call was absorbed by the darkness, and the child must pray again. In all, Paula prays nine times. The last prayer leaves the world altogether. It reaches the player, called by the name the player gave hours earlier to a voice on the telephone, and the game reports that the player, too, is praying. Giygas collapses. The screen fills with static, and then with silence.

The Greek *leitourgia* meant a public work, a service performed for the people, before it came to name the Church's ordered worship. The final battle is liturgical in both senses: it is a work done on behalf of everyone, and it has the form of a rite. Its structure is that of the litany—from *litaneia*, supplication—in which a single petition is repeated and answered, again and again, by a congregation: the *Kyrie eleison* of the Christian East and West, the call and response of countless traditions. Its theology is that of intercession and of what the Apostles' Creed calls the communion of saints, the solidarity of all who pray for one another across distance and even across death. The congregation that answers Paula is not composed of saints in any doctrinal sense. It is composed of mothers and friends and neighbours, a valley of aliens, people the children helped and people who helped them. But it performs the communion of saints in the only sense the game requires: a community constituted by the act of praying for others.

The division of labour within the battle has an ancient image. In the seventeenth chapter of Exodus, Israel fights Amalek in the valley while Moses stands on a hill with his hands raised. When his hands are raised, Israel prevails; when they fall, Amalek prevails; and when Moses tires, Aaron and Hur set a stone beneath him and hold up his hands, one on either side, until the sun goes down. In the final battle of *EarthBound*, Ness, Jeff, and Poo are Aaron and Hur. Their turns are spent not attacking but keeping Paula alive—shielding, healing, enduring—so that the one who prays can go on praying. The victory belongs to the prayer, but the prayer depends on the friends who hold it up.

The moment of absorption deserves emphasis, because it is the liturgy's most honest element. A prayer fails. The call goes out and the darkness swallows it. The Gospel of Luke, whose parable of the importunate friend Chapter 3 read beside the game's opening knock, contains a second parable on the same theme: a widow who comes again and again to an unjust judge until he grants her plea, a story told, Luke says, to teach that one ought always to pray and not to faint (18:1). The game teaches the same lesson in the grammar of turns. The player who has seen a prayer absorbed must select the same command again, with no assurance that it will be heard. The final battle includes the experience of unanswered prayer, and asks for persistence through it.

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) argued that play and sacred ritual share a form: both mark off a consecrated space, a magic circle, within which special rules hold and actions take on special meaning. The final battle makes the identity explicit. A game that has trained its player for dozens of hours in the agency of self-power—choosing weapons, managing resources, timing attacks—ends by reducing that agency to its minimum. The player can do nothing but select Pray, and watch, and wait. In the vocabulary of Chapter 1, *jiriki* has been exhausted and *tariki* has arrived; in the vocabulary of play, the contest (*agôn*) has become a rite. The magic circle of the game has become a sacred one.

7.2 *The Phenomenology of Prayer*: Mauss, Heiler, Weil, Chrétien

Marcel Mauss began a doctoral thesis on prayer in the first years of the twentieth century and had part of it printed in 1909, then withdrew it; it was never finished, and appeared only after his death, in his collected works (1968). Its opening definition remains the most economical in the sociology of religion: prayer is a religious rite, oral, bearing directly on sacred things. Mauss insisted on two points his contemporaries tended to forget. Prayer is speech, *parole*, before it is feeling; and it is social before it is individual, an institution whose forms are learned, shared, and transmitted. Paula's prayer is Maussian on both counts. It is an utterance, not an emotion; and it is not the private cry of a solitary soul but a rite that propagates through a community, each member of which joins it in a form the community recognizes. The prayer saves because it is shared. There is a small poetic justice, too, in the fact that the founding sociological study of prayer was itself an unfinished address, a work withdrawn before it reached its readers.

Friedrich Heiler's *Das Gebet* (1918), the great comparative study of prayer, called prayer the heart and centre of all religion and defined it as a living communion of the religious person with God, conceived as personal and present. Heiler's typology distinguished, among other forms, mystical prayer, the contemplative ascent toward union, from what he called prophetic prayer: spontaneous, urgent, personal, the cry of a creature in need, whose archetype is the psalmist's *de profundis*, "Out of the depths have I cried unto thee" (Psalm 130:1). Paula's prayer is prophetic in Heiler's sense. It rises literally out of the depths, from a cave at the bottom of time, and its content is the most elementary petition there is: help.

Weil supplies the deepest account of what the final battle asks of its player. Attention, she wrote in the notebooks collected as *La Pesanteur et la grâce*, at its highest degree is the same thing as prayer; it presupposes faith and love. In her essay on the right use of school studies she argued that the true purpose of education is the formation of the faculty of attention, because prayer consists of attention, and she drew from the argument an ethical consequence. The love of one's neighbour in its fullness, she wrote, consists simply in being able to ask the afflicted: what are you going through? She found the question in the legend of the Grail, in which the vessel belongs to the one who

first asks the wounded king what ails him. The final battle is the place where the game's long cultivation of attention becomes prayer, and where, for the first time, the player hears the affliction of the enemy. Giygas says that it hurts. The prayer that answers him is, among other things, the question Weil placed at the root of love.

Jean-Louis Chrétien's essay "La parole blessée" (1992) gave prayer its most rigorous phenomenology. Prayer, Chrétien argued, is the religious phenomenon par excellence, because in it a person manifests himself before an invisible other and is altered by doing so. Its speech is "wounded": exposed to an addressee it can neither see nor master, it bears the mark of that exposure, and it is always already a response to a call that preceded it. *EarthBound*'s final prayer is wounded speech in exactly this sense. It is uttered by a girl at the limit of hope, in a body not her own, toward an addressee she does not name. And its last destination discloses something remarkable about the place of the invisible in this game. The one before whom the prayer finally manifests itself is not a god. It is the player, the invisible presence on the other side of the screen who has watched over the children from the beginning without ever being seen by them.

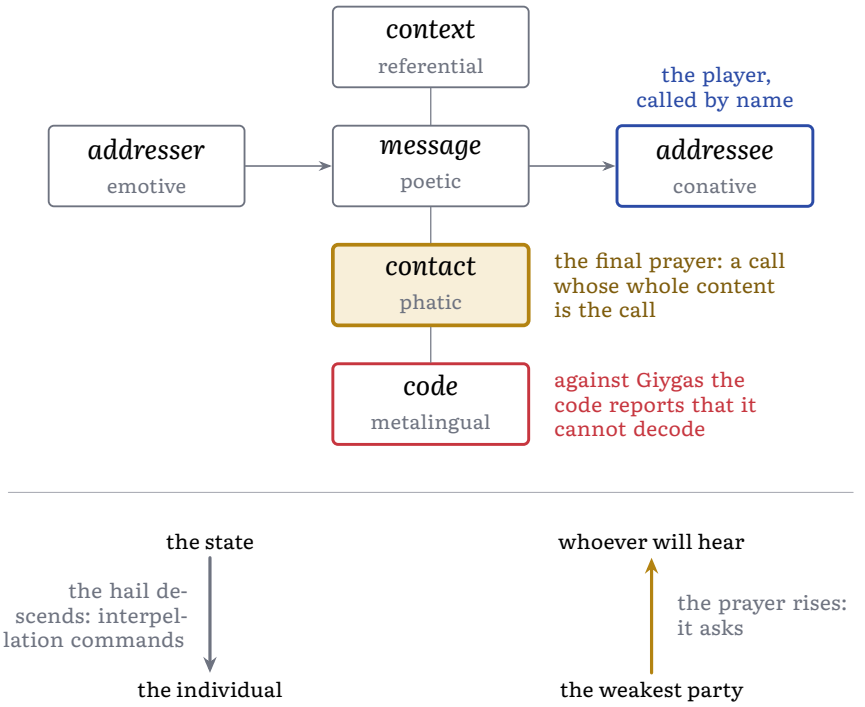
The game does not leave the player in that place. When the prayer reaches the player, the player prays in turn; the invisible addressee answers by joining the congregation. This is the game's most delicate theological move. It occupies, for one moment, the position that the phenomenology of prayer reserves for the divine, and then empties it: the one to whom the world prays turns out to be another who prays. Emmanuel Levinas, in a late essay on "prayer without demand" (1984), described a form of prayer that asks nothing for the one who prays but intercedes for others. The player's prayer is of that kind. It asks nothing for the player. It is the last voice added to a chorus of intercession, and with it the circle of the world's address is closed.

7.3 *Interpellation Inverted: Althusser, Jakobson, and the Phatic Channel*

Louis Althusser's essay on ideology (1970) staged the formation of the subject as a scene of address. A police officer calls out in the street, "Hey, you there!" The individual hailed turns around, and by that one-hundred-and-eighty-degree turn becomes a subject, recognizing that the call was meant for him and thereby accepting the place it assigns him. Ideology, Althusser concluded, interpellates individuals as subjects, and he observed that such calls almost never miss their target. Judith Williamson, as Chapter 2 noted, found the same structure in advertising, whose "you" offers the viewer an identity to recognize and inhabit. *EarthBound*'s final address preserves the formal power of interpellation—it individualizes, it names, it obliges a turn—and reverses everything else. The call comes not from authority but from need. Its content is not "Hey, you there!" but "Help." And the place it assigns its addressee is not that of a subject, in Althusser's double sense of one who is subjected, but that of a giver.

The reversal can be specified in three respects. The first is the vector. Althusser's hail descends from the apparatus of the state to the individual; Paula's prayer rises from the weakest party in the cosmos toward whoever will hear it. The second is the content: interpellation commands, prayer asks. The third is the constitution of the addressee. Interpellation produces a subject who recognizes himself in the law; the prayer produces a person who recognizes himself in another's need. And yet the most important feature of interpellation survives. The prayer, like the hail, is singular in its final aim. It ends not in a general appeal but in a name. The player is addressed not as "players" or "everyone" but as the one person who answered Tony's telephone call. Counter-interpellation is still interpellation; it still makes someone turn around. What differs is what it asks the one who turns to become.

The anthropologist Bronisław Malinowski, writing in 1923 about speech among the Trobriand Islanders, coined the phrase "phatic communion" for a type of speech in which ties of union are created by a mere exchange of words: greetings, inquiries after health, remarks on the weather, the talk whose purpose is not to inform but to bind. Roman Jakobson made the phatic one of the six functions of language in "Linguistics and Poetics" (1960): messages that serve to establish, prolong, or discontinue communication, to check whether



Jakobson's six factors of communication, with the channel the final prayer uses; below, Althusser's hail beside its inversion (§ 7.3).

the channel works—"Hello, do you hear me?" He added two observations of great consequence for this dissertation. The phatic function is the only one human beings share with talking birds; and it is the first verbal function acquired by infants, who try to communicate before they can send or receive information.

The final battle is a contest between two phatic utterances. Giygas, as Chapter 6 argued, has been reduced to the infant's first function: he repeats a name, calls without content, in the vestigial phatic speech of a mind that can no longer inform or be informed. Paula's prayer is phatic too. Its informational content is nearly nil; it asks for help and for nothing more specific. What it carries is contact. And the telephone, the game's master figure, is the phatic medium par excellence. Thomas Edison is said to have proposed "hello" as the word with which to open a telephone call, and it became the universal phatic token of the electric age. *EarthBound*'s calls are almost entirely phatic. The father's carry little information beyond a bank balance; the mother's carry none at all, and they are precisely what cures

the boy's homesickness. The game's economy of grace has been phatic from the beginning. The final prayer universalizes it: a call whose whole content is the call.

Interpellation inverted, then, is address stripped of command and of information alike and reduced to its two irreducible elements: a name and a need. Those two elements suffice. A call that asks nothing but to be heard, directed to someone by name, is the form telephonic grace takes at the end of the world.

7.4 *Speaking into the Air*: Dissemination, Telepathy, and The Telephone Book

John Durham Peters took the title of *Speaking into the Air* (1999) from Paul's first letter to the Corinthians, where the apostle warns that words uttered without understanding are spoken "into the air" (14:9). Peters's history of the idea of communication argues that the modern dream of communication as a meeting of minds—a fusion of souls without loss—is a fantasy, and that its failure is not a disaster but the condition of ethics. He sets two models against each other. The first is dialogue, as Socrates praises it in Plato's *Phaedrus*: living speech between two persons who can question and answer, in contrast with writing, which cannot defend itself and falls into anyone's hands. The second is dissemination, as Jesus enacts it in the parable of the sower, who casts seed indiscriminately—on the path, on stony ground, among thorns, and on good soil—without choosing who will receive it. Peters defends dissemination against the prestige of dialogue. Broadcast that does not demand reciprocity, he argues, can be a form of generosity: love that does not wait to be returned.

Paula's prayer is dissemination in this precise sense. It is cast outward to anyone who will hear, without assurance of reception, and it meets the fates of the sower's seed. Some of it falls on good ground: communities that hear and answer. Some falls where nothing can grow, and the game says in so many words that Paula's call was absorbed by the darkness. The parable does not counsel the sower to sow more selectively, and the game does not counsel Paula to pray more efficiently. It counsels her to keep sowing. The final harvest comes from the most unlikely ground of all, a field outside the world, where the last of the seed falls on the player.

The word "telepathy" was coined in 1882 by the classicist and psychical researcher Frederic W. H. Myers, in the year the Society for Psychical Research was founded: *tēle*, at a distance, and *pathos*, feeling—feeling at a distance. The nineteenth century's new media and its spiritualism grew up together, as Peters and others have shown. The telegraph seemed a nervous system for the planet, the séance a telegraph to the dead, and telepathy the medium that would need no wires at all. *EarthBound*'s media form a complete spectrum of this imagination. The telephone carries the voice at a distance; telepathy carries feeling at a distance, as Paula reaches Ness and Jeff in dreams before either has met her; the photograph, as Section 7.6 discusses, carries light from the past; the Sound Stone records the earth's sound; the courier carries things. Prayer, at the end, carries all of them at once—voice, feeling, and presence—sent to the far edge of the world and beyond it.

Avital Ronell's *The Telephone Book* (1989), typographically disordered by design, reads the telephone as the technical form of the call that philosophy, from Heidegger's call of conscience onward, had placed at the origin of responsibility. Ronell dwells on the way one answers a ringing telephone before knowing who calls—a "yes" that precedes every content—and on the telephone's entanglement with absence and the dead: Thomas Watson, Bell's assistant, took part in spiritualist séances. The telephone's own origin story is a call for presence. The first sentence Bell transmitted, on 10 March 1876, was a summons to his assistant in the next room: "Mr. Watson—come here—I want to see you." It is worth recalling, too, that Bell was by profession a teacher of the deaf, the son of a deaf mother and the husband of a deaf wife, and that the telephone emerged from a lifetime's work on making speech reach those who could not hear it. *EarthBound*'s final enemy is a being who cannot hear—deaf to the melodies of the earth and to every word. The prayer is a call made to reach the one who cannot hear. Its medium is the inventor's ethic, carried past the limits of the inventor's machine.

These histories converge on a proposition that may be the theoretical core of telephonic grace. Shannon's theory of communication, as its author insisted, abstracts entirely from meaning: it measures information as the reduction of uncertainty and defines noise as whatever corrupts the information a signal carries. On that account a channel as noisy as Giygas transmits nothing. But a prayer is not primarily information. It carries almost none—a name, a need. What it car-

ries is address, the phatic fact that someone is calling someone, and address, being nearly empty of information, is nearly immune to the kind of corruption noise inflicts. A single word can cross a storm that would destroy a page. Wolfgang Petersen's film of *The Neverending Story* (1984) gives the point an image: Bastian, the boy who must save a world being devoured by a void, shouts its sovereign's new name from a window into a thunderstorm, and the name, all but drowned, is heard. Noise can corrupt information. It cannot finally corrupt a call that asks only to be heard. That is why the prayer gets through where every weapon fails. Weapons are messages about force, and force is what the noise has infinitely more of. A call is a message about relation, and relation is precisely what the noise has lost.

7.5 *The Player's Name: Ende, Calvino, and the Second Person*

The name the final prayer reaches is collected, characteristically, by telephone. In the seaside region of Summers, at about the midpoint of the adventure, the telephone rings. It is Tony, Jeff's friend from the boarding school in the north, and in the course of the call he asks for a name—not Ness's, not Jeff's, but that of the person playing the game. A naming screen appears; the player types; the conversation moves on, and the moment is easily forgotten. In the Japanese original the screen accepted only capital Roman letters, asking players in effect to give their names as they would appear in English; the English localization, having no foreign alphabet to offer, simply asks for a name. Hours later, in the Cave of the Past, the name returns as the destination of the world's prayer.

The circuit is telephonic grace in miniature. The name is given to a voice on the telephone—the voice of the boy whose devotion to his friend is the game's most tender love—and it returns as the address of a prayer. What is entrusted to the line comes back as grace. The Japanese detail deepens the figure. Chapter 2 argued that Japan is absent from the world of the game, the eye that cannot appear in its own visual field, and that the player stands in the same position. To be reached by the prayer, the Japanese player had first to transcribe himself or herself into the alphabet of Eagleland: to cross, in the act of self-naming, the border between the subject who sees the world and

the world that is seen. The last prayer reaches the limit of the world by a name that the limit has written in the world's own letters.

Michael Ende's *Die unendliche Geschichte* (1979) is the most exact literary precedent for this structure. Bastian Balthasar Bux, a lonely, bullied boy whose mother has died and whose father has withdrawn into grief, steals a book and reads it in a school attic. It tells of Fantastica, a realm being devoured by the Nothing, a spreading void that annihilates whatever it touches, and of the young hunter Atreyu's quest for a cure for the realm's ailing sovereign, the Childlike Empress. The cure, it emerges, is a new name for the Empress, and only a human child from outside Fantastica can give it. Bastian slowly realizes that the book is addressing him. When he still hesitates, the Empress compels him: the story begins to repeat itself from the beginning, endlessly, until he cries out the name and is drawn into the world he has been reading. The parallels are close—a void consuming a world, an in-world hero who cannot finish the task alone, a reader outside the story whose act of naming saves it, a motherless boy—and the difference is instructive. In Ende the reader gives a name to the sovereign of the fiction. In *EarthBound* the fiction gives the reader's own name back and asks for help. Ende's reader rescues by naming; Itoi's player rescues by being named.

Italo Calvino's *Se una notte d'inverno un viaggiatore* (1979) made the reader the protagonist of a novel told in the second person, which opens by informing "you" that you are about to begin reading Italo Calvino's new novel. The Reader pursues a story whose every instalment breaks off, falls in love with another reader, and ends, in the last sentence, about to finish the very book in which he appears. Calvino's "you" is a pronoun, and its intimacy is a literary effect; it addresses every reader and therefore no one in particular. *EarthBound*'s final address is not a pronoun but a proper name, supplied by the person addressed. The difference is that between the second person and the vocative: the second person describes, the vocative calls. Bakhtin's addressivity, introduced in Chapter 1, reaches here its limit case—an utterance oriented not toward a type of addressee but toward one irreplaceable person, by name.

Haruki Murakami's story "Kaeru-kun, Tōkyō o sukuu" ("Super-Frog Saves Tokyo," 2000), written in the aftermath of the Kobe earthquake, supplies a third precedent, closer in spirit than either. Katagiri, a mild and unremarkable collector of bad debts for a Tokyo bank, comes home to find a giant frog in his apartment. Frog explains that

a vast worm beneath the city is about to cause an earthquake and that he must fight it. He does not need Katagiri to fight. He needs him to be there, to support him, to lend him the courage of an ordinary person who believes in him; and the battle, when it comes, takes place in the realm of imagination while Katagiri lies in a hospital bed. The decisive contribution to the salvation of a city is an ordinary person's solidarity, given in a dream. It is surely relevant, too, that Murakami's hero is a collector of debts who saves Tokyo by giving something no ledger records. The player's prayer is Katagiri's support: the participation of an ordinary person, outside the battle, without which the battle cannot be won.

Video games have broken the fourth wall many times, often for vertiginous effect. In Hideo Kojima's *Metal Gear Solid* (1998), a psychic villain reads the contents of the player's memory card and can be beaten only when the player moves the controller to a different port. *EarthBound*'s gesture differs in purpose. It is not a trick played on the player's position but an invitation to occupy it fully. Bertolt Brecht's *Verfremdungseffekt* broke the illusion of the stage in order to estrange the spectator, preventing identification so that the audience might think critically. Itoi breaks the frame for the opposite reason: not to distance the player from the fiction but to include the player in its communion. The sequel confirmed the design by relocating it. In *Mother 3* the player's name is asked not over the telephone but in a sanctuary of prayer in a forest. The series knows where the name belongs.

The Hebrew Bible had long since made being called by name the form of grace. "Fear not: for I have redeemed thee," the prophet hears in the forty-third chapter of Isaiah; "I have called thee by thy name; thou art mine." Rosenzweig, as Chapter 1 recalled, found revelation in the moment when God calls Abraham by name and Abraham answers, "Here I am." The final battle of *EarthBound* transposes that moment into a secular and ludic key. The world calls the player by name, and the player answers, in the only words the interface permits, by praying. It is the game's "Here I am."

Camera Lucida: The Photograph, the Credits, and the Mother 7.6

Throughout the journey, at moments the player cannot predict, a man with a camera descends from the sky to photograph the children. He appears first on the morning after the meteorite, in front of Ness's house, and thereafter at thirty other places—before a bicycle shop, beside a cabin in a valley, in a swamp, in the house of a shy chief who has just learned to speak. Each time he arranges the party, delivers a burst of patter about instant memories, and asks them to say "fuzzy pickles." The photographs are never shown. They accumulate out of sight. After Giygas has been defeated, Paula asks Ness to take her home and comes along whatever he answers; she receives a letter from the children of her family's preschool; the player may wander the pacified world, visiting friends. At last Ness goes home. When he speaks to his mother, the two of them look together at an album of the photographs—thirty-two in all, the last added automatically at the end of the game—while the credits roll.

Roland Barthes wrote *La Chambre claire* (1980) in the period after his mother's death in 1977, and the book appeared shortly before his own. Searching the photographs of her for one that would give back her true face, he found it in a picture of her as a five-year-old girl standing with her brother at the end of a little bridge in a glassed-in winter garden, in 1898. He refused to reproduce it: for any other viewer, he wrote, it would be merely one more ordinary photograph. The essence of the photograph, Barthes concluded, is "that-has-been" (*ça-a-été*). It certifies that its object was really there before the lens, and it therefore carries within it both a resurrection and a death. He distinguished the *studium*, the general cultural interest a photograph arouses, from the *punctum*, the detail that pricks a particular viewer and wounds.

The credits of *EarthBound* are a Winter Garden photograph distributed over thirty-two frames: a mother and child looking at pictures of the child, in the mother's house. For any other viewer they would be ordinary—low-resolution snapshots of sprites posed before landmarks. For the player who made the journey they are pure *punctum*, each certifying that the journey took place, that the children were there in their own bodies before they gave those bodies up in the cave. Their order is the order of the player's own passage, since

each was taken where the player chose to go. The album is the player's "that-has-been," returned as a gift.

Susan Sontag's *On Photography* (1977) argued that all photographs are *memento mori*: to take a photograph is to participate in another person's mortality and vulnerability. The photographs of the journey are taken of children who will later relinquish their bodies, and they return those bodies to the player as memory at the very moment the story returns them to the children as flesh. Walter Benjamin's "Kleine Geschichte der Photographie" (1931) located in early photographs an aura bound to presence and duration; Pierre Bourdieu's study of amateur photography, *Un art moyen* (1965), showed that the family photograph functions as a rite of integration, solemnizing the high points of family life and binding the group together. The album of *EarthBound* performs Bourdieu's rite with a difference. It integrates into Ness's family not only Ness but his three friends and, by implication, the player, whose route through the world it records. The photographer of Fellini's *La dolce vita*, as Chapter 2 noted, hunts images to sell; *EarthBound*'s photographer takes them to give back. The paparazzo of the age of spectacle becomes, in Itoi's game, the archivist of a family.

The afterlife of the album makes a fitting coda. In 2024 *Hobonichi*, the company Itoi founded, issued a diary for the following year whose cover reproduces the group photographs from the ending of *Mother* 2, with copy observing that the ending moves the player more the more photographs he or she has taken, and that the diary, filled with everyday things, will become a book of memories in its turn. The game's archive passes back into ordinary life as a book in which to record ordinary days. Counter-copy, which began as the inversion of a slogan, ends here as an invitation to keep a diary.

The ending is, in fact, a flurry of addresses. Paula receives a letter from children. Ness and his mother receive the album. The credits deliver to the player the names of the people who made the game, completing the exchange that began when the game asked for the player's name. And after the credits, as Chapter 3 recalled, a knock at the door brings Pokey's taunting letter. The music that accompanies the album is called "Smiles and Tears," the most accurate summary the series has ever offered of its own tonal alloy. The first *Mother* forbade tears until the ending. The ending of the second gives them leave.

Attention as Prayer: Counter-Copy Fulfilled 7.7

Chapter 2 defined counter-copy by three reversals of advertising's address: of its vector, from seller and buyer to need and other; of its content, from offer to supplication; and of its addressee, from a subject of lack to a source of grace. The final battle performs all three, in order. The vector runs from the weakest beings in the cosmos—four children in borrowed metal bodies at the bottom of time—outward to the person holding the controller. The content is a single supplication, help, which offers nothing in exchange. And the addressee is constituted as the one whose response is the decisive good: not a consumer to be satisfied but a giver to be asked. The copywriter who spent the bubble years addressing a "you" with offers ends his great game by addressing a named "you" with a request.

The substance of this conversion is attention. For dozens of hours the game has asked its player to attend—to the inscriptions of its townspeople, to the songs of its sanctuaries, to the calls of a mother and a father, to the slow descent of a rolling meter. Weil held that the real purpose of school studies is the formation of attention, because attention is the substance of prayer; studies matter less for their content than for the capacity they build. *EarthBound* is, in this sense, a school. Its long cultivation of attention to small things prepares the moment at which attention is asked to become prayer. The player who has learned to listen to Mr. Saturn's nonsense and to the Tenda's silence is the player who can hear Giygas say that it hurts.

The political significance of the conversion has grown with time. When *EarthBound* was released, the economy of attention was still largely the economy of broadcast advertising, the economy in which Itoi had been a master. In the decades since, it has become the dominant economy of the digital world, in which platforms are engineered, as Tim Wu and others have documented, to capture and resell the attention of their users. Bernard Stiegler's late work, notably *Prendre soin* (2008), described the industrial capture of attention by what he called psychotechnologies as a destruction of the capacity for care, and called for a therapeutics that would redirect attention toward the long circuits of education, memory, and care. *EarthBound*, a commercial product of the same industry, contains in its final minutes a small model of such a therapeutics. It asks for the attention it has captured, and it does not resell it. It asks that the attention be given away—to

children who need help, and through them to an enemy who suffers. The commodity converts its own currency into prayer.

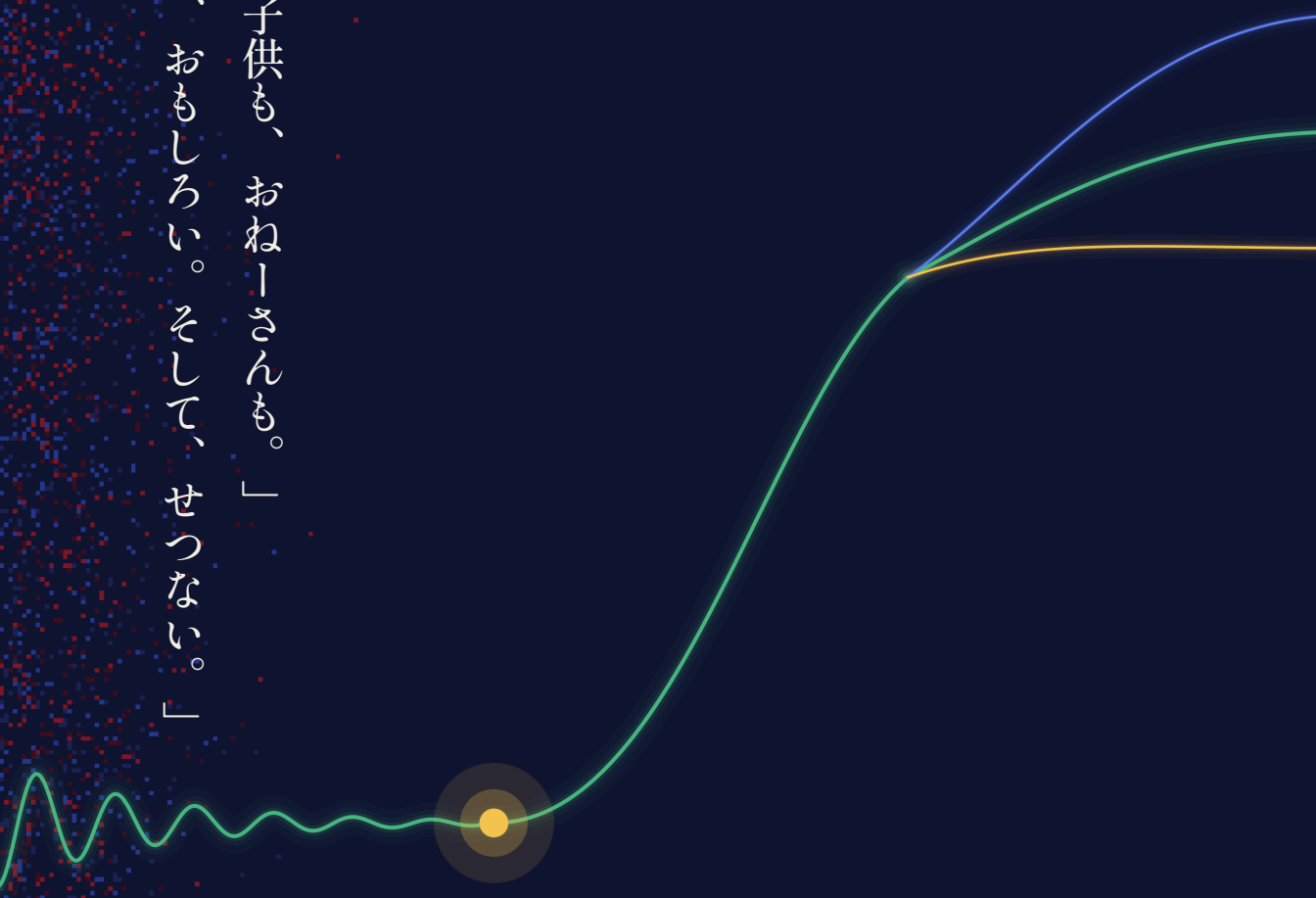
The dissertation can now give telephonic grace its full definition. Telephonic grace is grace that arrives as address: a call from afar, carried by voices, through channels both technical and spiritual—the telephone line and the telepathic dream, the recorded melody and the photograph, the letter and the prayer. It constitutes its addressee not as a subject of lack but as a giver; it asks rather than offers; and it can traverse the noise that destroys every message about force, because it is not information but relation, a name and a need. It presupposes gravity—bodies that hunger, homes that can be missed, mothers who answer—and it requires emptiness, a self that has consented to be emptied so that something can arrive. It is threatened only by the absolute collapse of addressability, the black hole of noise that Giygas embodies; and even there, the game proposes, it can reach the one who cannot hear, because love works in two ways.

The final battle is also the completion of Itoi's art. The great slogans of the 1980s—*fushigi*, *daisuki*; *oishii seikatsu*; *kuu neru asobu*—were addresses offered to a reader in the name of a corporation. The address with which *EarthBound* ends is the player's own name, offered back to the player in the name of a world that needs help. Three years later Itoi would write, for *Princess Mononoke*, the bare imperative「生きろ。」—"Live." The final battle of *EarthBound* belongs to the same late style. Its last copy is not an injunction to buy, nor even to live, but a request: help us. It is, in the most precise sense, the inverse of a slogan. It is a prayer.

The dissertation's circuit is now complete. The call has departed from the house on the hill, crossed the sanctuaries and the counterfeit graces of the earth, passed through selves emptied to receive it, met the noise at the centre, and returned through prayer to the house, where a mother and her son look at photographs. What remains is to gather the findings, follow the inheritance of telephonic grace in later works, confront the objections the argument must face, and draw out its implications beyond *EarthBound*. That is the work of the final chapter.

「大人も子供も、おねーさんも。」

「奇妙で、おもしろい。そして、せつない。」



return

8

"Adults, Children, and Older Sisters, Too"

Toward a General Theory of Telephonic Grace

「大人も子供も、おねーさんも。」
"Adults, children, and older sisters, too."
promotional copy for Mother 2 (1994)

「奇妙で、おもしろい。そして、せつない。」
"Strange, funny—and heartrending."
promotional copy for Mother 3 (2006)

THE COPY FOR MOTHER 2 did not describe a product; it enumerated the people to whom the product spoke. This final chapter asks, in the same spirit, whom the argument of the dissertation addresses and what follows from it. It gathers the findings (8.1); traces the inheritance of telephonic grace in the works that descend from *EarthBound* (8.2); confronts the principal objections the argument must face (8.3); draws out its implications for game studies, media theory, and the philosophy of religion (8.4); and closes with the one call the game leaves unanswered (8.5).

8.1 *Summary of Findings*

This dissertation set out to show that *EarthBound* elaborates a complete metaphysics, and that its centre is a theory of address. Section 1.5 stated the argument in seven theses. The intervening chapters have tested them against the work, and they can now be restated as findings.

1 **Being is being-addressed.** The game constitutes its world through calls. It opens with a knock at midnight and closes with another (Chapter 3). Before play begins it asks the player what he or she loves, and builds the mother's cooking and the hero's power from the answers (3.4). It names the sacred places of the earth in the second person (4.1), and midway through it collects the player's own name by telephone in order to return it at the end (7.5). The series' paratexts, from「エンディングまで、泣くんじゃない。」to「大人も子供も、おねーさんも。」, are addresses rather than descriptions (1.1).

2 **The world is a network of channels.** Eagleland contains a media history in miniature: the telephone as archive, cure, and law (1.5, 3.3–3.4); money transmitted at a distance by a father (2.5); the phonographic Sound Stone (4.1); telepathy (4.5, 7.4); the photograph (7.6); the courier; and finally prayer, which gathers all of them (7.4). Grace in this world arrives at a distance and as a voice.

3 **Gravity is the condition of the addressed.** The game's procedures make finitude meaningful rather than merely limiting. Homesickness renders attachment a variable of courage (3.3); the house is a *metaxu* and an enclave of the gift within a money economy (3.2); the rolling meter converts mortality into a duration open to rescue (5.7); and Itoi's own triad of eating, sleeping, and playing names the gravity on which a child's survival depends (2.2).

4 **Evil is noise.** Giygas is ground without figure, a corrupted background rather than a sprite (6.2); a privation in Augustine's sense and thoughtlessness in Arendt's (6.3); an abject infant whose ambivalent cries derive, by Itoi's own account, from a child's confusion of violence and eroticism (6.4, 6.6); and the sublime withheld, an unpresentable that the interface itself confesses (6.5). Short of Giygas lie the counterfeit graces—the idol, the inverted city, the cult—which

give power without relation and corrupt address into its opposite (4.3–4.5).

5

Salvation is address restored. The decisive act is a prayer that functions as liturgy (7.1), as Maussian rite and prophetic cry (7.2), as inverted interpellation and phatic communion (7.3), and as dissemination in Peters's sense (7.4). It prevails because address, being nearly empty of information, survives the noise that destroys every message about force (7.4); and it wounds Giygas because love, in Isaac of Nineveh's phrase, is a scourge to those who cannot receive it (6.7).

6

The last channel runs through the screen. The father's call counselling rest is the first address to pass through the screen (3.4); the coffee interlude speaks to the player directly (4.6); and the final prayer reaches the player by a name given to a voice on the telephone, making the player first the invisible addressee of the world's prayer and then one who prays in turn (7.2, 7.5).

7

This structure is counter-copy. Itoi's slogans of the bubble years addressed a consumer with offers; his game ends by addressing a named player with a request (2.6, 7.7). The genealogy of 「おいしい生活。」 in Fellini's *La dolce vita*, which ends with a girl's call drowned by noise, finds its reversal in a girl's call that crosses the noise (2.6). The game converts the attention it has captured into prayer (7.7).

Several subsidiary concepts were introduced along the way and proved their worth. The *domestic sublime* named an inversion of the uncanny, grounded in the observation that Kant's safety condition is Bowlby's secure base translated into aesthetics (3.6). The *suburban cosmic* named the lineage, from Bradbury to Spielberg, in which the universe lands behind a house (3.1). The *sincere simulacrum* distinguished Eagleland from Baudrillard's blank hyperreality by the fact that every copy in it is addressed to someone (2.3). *Counterfeit grace* named power given without relation (1.6, 4.3). The distinction between two nothings, nihility and emptiness, with Nishida's *mu no basho* as its unexpected pivot, explained why the children's self-emptying is the opposite of Giygas's collapse, and why the Mu training serves as the game's internal theory of the robot transfer (5.1–5.3). The reading of the four children as Heidegger's fourfold clarified the party as a whole rather than a team (5.6). And the quaternity of Figure 1.1 proved a

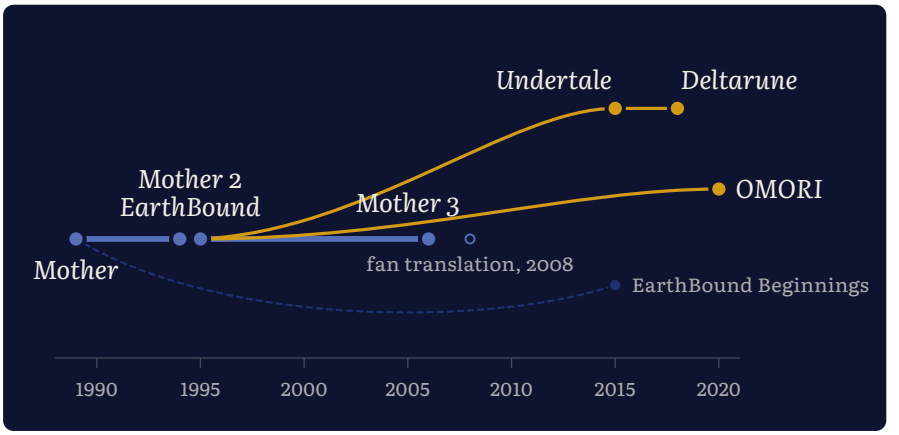
durable heuristic. Across seven chapters, the habitable regions of the game's world have been those in which gravity or grace is joined to address, and its uninhabitable regions those in which either is joined to noise.

Two methodological findings deserve mention. Procedural hermeneutics showed that the game's mechanics carry its metaphysics: the save is a relation, homesickness an attachment, the rolling meter a duration, the Pray command a figure of gratuity, the naming screen a question about love, and the rendering of the final enemy as background a statement about evil. The comparative method, disciplined by the distinction between attested, ambient, and homological relations, allowed bold comparisons—with Weil, Shinran, Isaac of Nineveh, Zhuangzi, and the Book of Exodus—without any claim that the game was made from them. It also allowed attested sources from Itoi's own account to be brought to bear on the game: the derivation of his most famous slogan from *La dolce vita*, the American family sitcoms behind his copy for Parco, the vocative structure of his first prize-winning line, and the childhood film scene behind Giygas's dialogue.

The thesis can therefore be restated in a single sentence. *EarthBound* is a work about what it means to be addressed: its cosmos is ordered by gravity and grace, noise and address; its antagonist is the collapse of addressability; and its climax, the prayer that reaches the player by name, converts the player's attention into grace.

8.2 *Lineages*: Mother 3, Undertale, OMORI, *and the EarthBound Inheritance*

The series' own sequel took twelve years to arrive. *Mother* 3 was announced for Nintendo's 64DD peripheral and then for the Nintendo 64, and was cancelled in 2000; revived for the Game Boy Advance, it was released in Japan in 2006, developed by Brownie Brown and HAL Laboratory, written by Itoi, and scored by Shogo Sakai. Its copy promised a game that was strange, funny, and *setsunai*, heartrending, and it kept the promise. Set in Tazmily, a village on remote islands that knows no money, it narrates the death of a mother, Hinawa, in its first chapter; the disappearance of one of her twin sons, Claus; and the arrival of an army in pig masks, led by a figure who proves to be Pokey, grown ancient in his wanderings through time. The army



The inheritance: the series in blue, with its shelved first localization released at last in 2015; in gold, the call answered, long after it was placed, by addressees it could not have known (§§ 1.1, 8.2).

brings money to the village and installs in its houses glowing "Happy Boxes" that keep their owners content. The counterfeit grace of *EarthBound*'s cult has become an economy and a broadcast.

Mother 3 reconfigures telephonic grace at every point. The father is present now and the mother absent, as in *Totoro*; the game is saved not by calling home but by speaking to frogs; and the player's name is asked not over the telephone but in a sanctuary of prayer in a forest. The climax inherits *EarthBound*'s structure and darkens it. Lucas, the surviving twin, faces the masked commander of Porky's army, a cyborg whom the boy cannot bring himself to attack. During the battle a voice is heard: the voice of the dead mother, calling the masked figure by his name—Claus—and telling him that he is not Porky's robot but her son. The voice from beyond restores the robot to his humanity, and he dies in his brother's arms. Lucas completes his task; the world is unmade and remade; and in a pitch-black epilogue the player is assured, by voices speaking out of the darkness, that the characters have survived. The series' final address is a chorus speaking to the player from a world the player can no longer see.

Mother 3 also completes the diagnosis of Pokey. His regime is the political form of the eternal child: a world arranged for his amusement and populated by captive happiness. And his end is the image of absolute unaddressability. He seals himself inside a capsule designed to be perfectly safe, which nothing can enter or leave, and in which, hav-

ing made himself unable to die, he will remain forever. Section 8.5 returns to him. Itoi has said that there will be no fourth *Mother*. The trilogy closes on a world remade by a voice from the dead, and on a child who can never be reached.

The most influential heir of *EarthBound* was made by a fan. Toby Fox began by modifying the game itself—his *EarthBound* "Halloween Hack" of 2008 first featured the music that would become "Megalovania"—and in 2015 he released *Undertale*, a role-playing game that turns telephonic grace into a complete grammar of play. Every battle can be resolved without violence through the ACT and MERCY commands: the player talks to monsters, compliments them, listens to them, and spares them. Paula's single prayer, the one moment in *EarthBound* at which address replaces force, becomes in *Undertale* the general form of encounter. The telephone returns as well. Early in the game a motherly guardian, Toriel, gives the human child a cell phone and calls to ask whether the child prefers cinnamon or butterscotch in the pie she is baking: the mother, the telephone, and the favourite food of Ness's household, reassembled in a single call. And the game's climax, in its fullest ending, is a battle the player cannot win by force, in which the player must instead reach the lost souls of friends, who remember the player and return. Afterwards the game addresses the player directly, asking that the world and its newfound happiness be left alone—that the player not reset what has been saved.

Undertale also draws out an implication *EarthBound* left latent. If the save is a relation, as Chapter 3 argued, then its abuse is a moral act. *Undertale*'s characters remember what the player did in earlier playthroughs and reproach the player for resets, and the game reveals, at the end of its fullest route, that the name the player entered at the start belonged to someone else entirely. The player who is addressed is also the player who is held responsible. Fox's later *Deltarune* (2018–) opens by inviting the player to design a vessel and then discards it, observing that no one can choose who they are in this world. Here the address to the player begins by refusing the player's sovereignty.

Omocat's *OMORI* (2020), whose makers have counted *EarthBound* among its influences alongside the dream-wandering of *Yume Nikki*, carries the inheritance into the territory of grief. Its hero divides his days between a bright imaginary world called Headspace, a Magicant built as a refuge, and a real town in which an unbearable truth about his sister's death waits to be faced. Its real-world story begins only if

the player answers a friend's knocks at the hero's door. Its save points are picnic blankets kept by the dead sister. Its world is punctuated by a photo album. And its final battle, against the hero's own idealized and repressive self, is won not by force but by music: in the good ending the hero takes up the violin he abandoned and plays, with his sister's spirit at the piano, the duet that grief had silenced, and then wakes to tell his friends the truth. The knock, the save as relation, the album, the interior world, the melody, and the confession as address—*EarthBound*'s grammar survives entire, turned toward mourning.

Across these works a common inheritance is visible. The address to the player passes from *EarthBound*'s single prayer to *Undertale*'s memory and OMORI's knock; the save becomes a relationship, with a frog, with a mother on the telephone, with a dead sister on a picnic blanket; battle yields to address in *Undertale*'s mercy and OMORI's duet; the interior world of Magicant becomes Headspace; the closing album returns. What these heirs do not inherit is equally instructive. None is a copywriter's game, and none carries *EarthBound*'s reckoning with the economy of advertising in which its author made his name. They inherit telephonic grace without counter-copy. And they move the centre of gravity from the household to the wound. Where *EarthBound* stands on a secure base, its heirs begin from its loss. They are, in that sense, games about what becomes of address when the house on the hill is no longer standing.

Limits and Objections: Orientalism, Localization, and the Canon of Fan Theory 8.3

A dissertation that has praised its object at such length owes its reader an account of the object's limits, and of its own. Six objections are pressing.

The first concerns Orientalism. Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) described a Western discourse that constructed "the Orient" as an object of knowledge and fantasy—exotic, timeless, available. *EarthBound*'s margins draw on that repertoire. Dalaam is a Himalayan principality of meditation and martial arts whose prince wears a long queue, a hairstyle imposed on Han men by the Qing dynasty and long a staple of Western caricatures of the Chinese; Scaraba is a desert kingdom of pyramids, sphinx, and bazaar assembled from the deserts of adventure cinema. Chapter 2 traced these images to a double source:

Western Orientalism, absorbed through film, and Japan's own Orientalism, its construction of Asia as *tōyō*, the past and spiritual reserve of Japanese modernity. Japan, Orientalized by the West, orientalizes in turn. Eagleland is the mirror image, a benign Occidentalism in James Carrier's sense of an essentialized image of the West, built from television. Koichi Iwabuchi's *Recentering Globalization* (2002) argued that Japanese media exports often achieve global circulation by becoming "culturally odorless" (*mukokuseki*), shedding visible Japaneseness. The absence of Japan from *EarthBound* might be read in that light, though the game's strongly American flavour, and its commercial failure in America, complicate any simple application. None of this cancels the game's ethics of alterity, which Mr. Saturn and the Tenda embody with real grace. But that ethics coexists with stereotype, and an honest reading must hold both.

The same objection applies to this dissertation. Its use of Zen, of Tibetan practice, and of the Kyoto School risks reproducing a familiar Western pleasure in "Eastern wisdom." Robert Sharf's essay "The Zen of Japanese Nationalism" (1993) showed how the Zen presented to the West by D. T. Suzuki and the Kyoto philosophers was shaped by modern Japanese nationalism and by the apologetic needs of a modernizing nation. The comparisons of Chapters 5 and 6 have therefore been framed as homologies rather than as revelations of an essence, and the political history of the Kyoto School has been named rather than suppressed (1.4, 5.3). The risk remains, and the reader should weigh it.

The second objection concerns gender. Chapter 3 acknowledged that Ness's household reproduces the division of labour of the 1950s American sitcom, the mother at the stove and the father at work. Paula, the only girl among the four, is kidnapped twice, once by the cult and once by the tycoon; her weapons are frying pans; and her decisive power is prayer, an act long coded as feminine intercession. Anita Sarkeesian's video series *Tropes vs. Women in Video Games* (2013–) catalogued the damsel in distress as one of the medium's most persistent conventions, and Paula fits it. The case for the defence is real but partial. Paula's prayer is not passive: it is the only effective act in the final battle, and the boys' turns are spent sustaining it. Itoi's copy for the game named young women explicitly among its addressees. And the series later complicated its own gender order in *Mother* 3's Magypsies, immortal guardians of the world who stand outside the binary, as it had earlier, gently, in the tenderness of Tony's devotion to

Jeff. The fairest judgment is that *EarthBound* inherits a conventional gender order and partially transvalues it, placing at the summit of its world an act that convention had relegated to the margins.

The third objection concerns language. This dissertation has read *EarthBound* largely through its English script, and the English script is a translation that altered its original under Nintendo of America's content standards, renamed its characters, and transposed its jokes (1.7). Lawrence Venuti's *The Translator's Invisibility* (1995) distinguished domesticating translation, which assimilates a text to the receiving culture, from foreignizing translation, which preserves its strangeness. *EarthBound* presents an unusual case: a Japanese game about an imagined America, domesticated into the language of the country it imagined. The localization returned the dream of America to American English and in doing so effaced some of the strangeness that made it a dream—the capital Roman letters in which the Japanese player had to spell his or her own name, for instance (7.5). The parallel-text method of this dissertation, and its debt to Clyde Mandelin's philology, mitigate the problem without removing it. A study written from the Japanese script alone would be a different study, and a necessary one.

The fourth objection concerns interpretation itself. *EarthBound* has generated a dense culture of fan theory: the reading of Giygas as a fetus and the final battle as an allegory of abortion; the theory that the whole adventure is the dream of a comatose boy; the legend that the game contains material from the film Itoi saw as a child. Henry Jenkins's *Textual Poachers* (1992), extending Michel de Certeau's account of reading as poaching (*L'Invention du quotidien*, 1980), taught scholars to treat such fan production as active, creative, and communal rather than naïve. This dissertation has cited fan readings as evidence of reception and has declined to canonize them. But it must acknowledge that its own homologies—between Poo's training and Zhuangzi, between Paula and Fellini's Paola, between Giygas and Isaac of Nineveh's damned—are of the same species as fan theory, written in a different idiom. Stanley Fish's account of interpretive communities (1980) would describe the dissertation as one more such community's reading. Umberto Eco, in the Tanner Lectures published as *Interpretation and Overinterpretation* (1992), proposed a criterion: a reading is legitimate insofar as it is confirmed by the coherence of the work as a whole, the *intentio operis*, rather than by the author's intention or the reader's desire. That is the standard this dissertation has tried

to meet. Its homologies are offered not as hidden sources but as patterns the work sustains across its length. Whether they succeed is for the reader to judge.

The fifth objection returns to the commodity. Chapter 2 conceded that counter-copy works within the commodity form, and the concession has consequences. Telephonic grace can itself be sold—as nostalgia, as merchandise, as "the power of friendship" in a marketing campaign. Even the diary that Itoi's company issued with the ending photographs on its cover (7.6) belongs to the market. The dissertation does not claim that *EarthBound* escapes the economy that produced it. It claims that the game contains, within that economy, a structure that reverses its logic, and that the reversal is real for as long as the player's attention is not recaptured. Counter-copy is fragile. Its survival depends on how the work is received.

The sixth objection is theological, and it comes from two directions. Secular readers may find the use of Isaac of Nineveh, Shinran, and the phenomenology of prayer an imposition on a children's game; religious readers may find the description of the player as the addressee of prayer close to blasphemy. The dissertation's answer to both is the methodological agnosticism announced in Chapter 1. It has not argued that *EarthBound* is religious, nor that prayer to a player is prayer to God. It has argued that the game enacts a structure—a call from need, across noise, to an absent other, answered—that theology has described with unusual precision, and that the game itself refuses to name a god. The place of the divine in the final battle is occupied for a moment and then emptied, as Chapter 7 showed. A theology that cannot recognize its own structures in a secular work is the poorer for it; a secular criticism that cannot borrow theology's descriptions is poorer still.

Beyond EarthBound: Implications for Game Studies, Media Theory, and the Philosophy of Religion 8.4

For game studies the dissertation proposes, first, a concept: *procedural address*. Ian Bogost's procedural rhetoric, discussed in Chapter 1, names the way rule-based systems persuade. *EarthBound* shows that rules can also address—that they can constitute the player not merely as an agent to be persuaded but as a person to be called. The father who telephones to suggest a break, the naming screen that asks what the player loves, the save that takes the form of a conversation, the name collected by one character and returned by another: these are procedures whose meaning lies in the relation they establish with the one who plays. Espen Aarseth's implied player names the role a game prepares; procedural address names the relation a game proposes to the one who fills the role. The concept invites a research programme. Save systems in particular deserve study as sites of meaning—as archives, confessions, relations, and, in *Undertale*, moral records—rather than as interface conveniences.

The dissertation offers, second, a case against the persistence of the old division between rules and stories. In *EarthBound* the decisive meanings are neither procedural nor narrative alone: a menu command completes a story, a save system is a family relation, an antagonist is a rendering technique. Third, it bears on the ethics of play. Much contemporary design aims to capture attention and convert it into engagement, and Bogost himself denounced the gamification of commerce as exploitationware. *EarthBound* demonstrates that a game can form attention rather than harvest it, that the long cultivation of attention to small things can culminate in an act of care. A criticism alert to that possibility would judge games not only by what they make players do but by what they make players capable of.

For media theory, the implications concern the fate of the telephone. In *EarthBound* the telephone carries a mother's voice, a father's archive, a friend's question, and finally the shape of prayer. In the decades since, the telephone has become the smartphone, and the call has become the notification: an address engineered, in the economy Shoshana Zuboff has named surveillance capitalism (2019), to capture and predict behaviour, and, in the economy Tim Wu has traced, to resell attention. Sherry Turkle's *Alone Together* (2011) described a connectedness that has lost the capacity for presence; Byung-Chul Han's *Die Austreibung des Anderen* (2016) diagnosed

the expulsion of the other from a digital world of the same. The device that, in Itoi's game, cured a child's homesickness has become the medium through which the attention economy reaches into every hour of the day. Telephonic grace offers a criterion by which to judge the calls that now arrive. An address is graceful insofar as it asks rather than offers, constitutes its addressee as a giver rather than as inventory, carries relation rather than information, and can be refused. The question it teaches the user of any medium to ask is simple: does this call ask me to give, or does it ask to take me?

For the philosophy of religion, *EarthBound* offers an unusually clear instance of what might be called structural prayer: prayer whose form is preserved while its addressee is left open. John D. Caputo's *The Prayers and Tears of Jacques Derrida* (1997) found in Derrida a "religion without religion," a passion for the impossible that survives the loss of doctrine. Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* (2007) described the modern condition as life within an "immanent frame" in which experiences of fullness persist without a guaranteed transcendent reference. Simone Weil, in "Formes de l'amour implicite de Dieu" (1942), named four loves that are directed toward God without knowing it: love of neighbour, love of the beauty of the world, love of religious practices, and friendship. *EarthBound* displays all four. Its prayer is love of neighbour extended even to the enemy; its sanctuaries sing the beauty of the world; its final battle is a religious practice in the strict form of a litany; and its four children are bound by friendship. The game is, in Weil's sense, a work of implicit love.

The Japanese context sharpens the point. Ian Reader and George Tanabe's *Practically Religious* (1998) described the common religion of Japan as a practice oriented toward worldly benefits (*genze riyaku*) and conducted largely without doctrinal commitment: the prayer for help in an examination or an illness, the amulet bought at a shrine, the wooden votive tablet (*ema*) on which a wish is written and hung up for the gods and for passers-by to read. Surveys have long found that a majority of Japanese describe themselves as non-religious while taking part in such practices. Paula's prayer belongs to this world more than to any creed. It is a petition for help in extremity, addressed to whoever can hear, written, as it were, on a tablet hung in public for the whole world to read. The game's soteriology is practical before it is theological, and that is part of its universality. It can be performed by anyone, of any faith or of none.

Gathered together, these implications describe what the title of this chapter called a general theory of telephonic grace. In any medium, grace arrives as address from afar: a call that asks rather than offers, that includes rather than captures, that carries relation rather than information, and that can therefore cross noise. Its enemy is not information or technology as such but the collapse of addressability—the conversion of persons into audiences, of calls into notifications, of attention into inventory. Its condition is gravity: bodies, homes, mothers who answer. Its preparation is emptiness: a self that can receive. And its form, at the limit, is the oldest form of address there is, the one that Itoi's game, a product of the most sophisticated advertising culture of its time, chose for its last word. It is a prayer.

Coda: Pokey's Escape 8.5

One call in *EarthBound* goes unanswered. In the final battle Pokey gloats and taunts, and when Giygas falls he vanishes, promising that the children have not seen the last of him. After the credits, when the hero is home and the album has been closed, there is a knock at the door. It is Picky, Pokey's brother, carrying a letter: "Come and get me, loser! Spankety spankety spankety!" The game that began with a knock at midnight ends with this one. *Mother 3* reveals where the letter leads: to an ancient child who has ruined a world for his amusement and then sealed himself inside an "Absolutely Safe Capsule," unable to die, from which nothing can ever come out and into which nothing can ever go. Absolute safety is absolute unaddressability. Pokey is the one human being in the series whom no prayer reaches.

The neighbour remains outside the communion. Paula's prayer passes through mothers and friends and aliens and the player; it does not pass through Pokey, who was in the cave when it was spoken and who fled from it. The game's grace is wide but not total, and it marks its limit not with a wall but with a knock. Kierkegaard insisted that the neighbour is precisely the one we did not choose and cannot escape. *EarthBound* does not pretend to have loved Pokey. It leaves his letter on the doormat.

Pokey's letter is, for all its spite, an address. "Come and get me" is a call, the only kind the eternal child knows how to make: an invitation to pursuit. It leaves the future open. Jacques Derrida, in *Spectres de*

Marx, spoke of a messianic structure without a messiah, an openness to what is to come, *à venir*, that no fulfilment can close. The last knock of *EarthBound* has that structure. It is a call the game neither answers nor cancels. It is addressed, like everything in this game, to someone, and the someone is left to decide.

The first *Mother* told its player not to cry until the ending. The second told the world that it was speaking to adults, children, and older sisters, too—to everyone. This dissertation has tried to show what it means for a work to speak to everyone, and what it means for such a work to end by speaking to one person by name. It has been, in its own way, an address, and its reader, like the player at the end of the game, has been asked to attend. As the game closes, so does the argument: with a knock, a letter, and a call that has not yet been answered.

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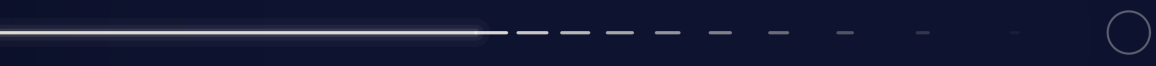
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Keywords

EarthBound; *Mother 2: Gīgu no Gyakushū*; Shigesato Itoi; *Mother* series; *Mother 3*; Japanese role-playing games; game studies; procedural rhetoric; procedural hermeneutics; procedural address; addressed player; save systems; platform studies; implied player; telephonic grace; counter-copy; domestic sublime; suburban cosmic; sincere simulacrum; counterfeit grace; soteriology of address; addressivity; interpellation; phatic function; phatic communion; Bronisław Malinowski; vocative; second-person address; the player's name; fourth wall; phenomenology of prayer; structural prayer; liturgy; litany; intercession; communion of saints; Marcel Mauss; Friedrich Heiler; prophetic prayer; wounded word; Simone Weil; gravity and grace; implicit love of God; decreation; kenosis; affliction (*malheur*); rootedness; *metaxu*; attention; attention economy; surveillance capitalism; Shoshana Zuboff; Sherry Turkle; Byung-Chul Han; Bernard Stiegler; care; *tariki* and *jiriki*; Shinran; Pure Land Buddhism; Japanese common religion; *genze riyaku*; *ema*; Kyoto School; Kitarō Nishida; *mu no basho*; Keiji Nishitani; nihility and emptiness (*kyomu*, *kū*); great death; Dōgen; dropping off body and mind (*shinjin datsuraku*); Zhuangzi; sitting and forgetting (*zuowang*); Chöd; Meister Eckhart; Giygas; Giegue; the orphan; Devil's Machine; *privatio boni*; Manichaeism; Hannah Arendt; banality of evil; thoughtlessness; theodicy; problem of evil; Isaac of Nineveh; scourge of love; *apokatastasis*; Fyodor Dostoevsky; Father Zosima; religion without religion; secularity; Charles Taylor; noise; television static; information theory; Michel Serres; Jacques Attali; figure and ground; the sublime; obscurity; Edmund Burke; Kant's dynamical sublime; the unpresentable; Jean-François Lyotard; cosmic horror; H. P. Lovecraft; Azathoth; *informe*; Georges Bataille; the numinous; Rudolf Otto; the abject; birth trauma; Otto Rank; primal scene; *Nachträglichkeit*; *Kenpei to barabara shibijin*; primal scream; John Lennon; the uncanny; suburban uncanny; psychoanalysis; mirror stage; attachment theory; John Bowlby; secure base; homesickness; D. W. Winnicott; transitional object; *fort-da*; *amae*; Takeo Doi; Name-of-the-Father; Jacques Lacan; absent father; Jun Etō; envy and gratitude; Melanie Klein; mimetic desire; René Girard; the neighbour; *puer aeternus*; the shadow; C. G. Jung; interiority; memory; Augustine; Magicant; home and dwelling; Gaston Bachelard; Martin Heidegger; the fourfold; question concerning technology; *Gestell*;

repair; robot body; ghost in the machine; Cartesian dualism; Emmanuel Levinas; hospitality; shame and shyness; sacred geography; pilgrimage; songlines; *dōgyō ninin*; harmony of the spheres; *anamnēsis*; *katabasis*; idolatry; commodity fetishism; possession; inversion; carnival; surrealism; nonsense; new religious movements; Aum Shinrikyō; time travel; prophecy; vocation; duration; Henri Bergson; being-toward-death; *kairos*; hauntology; media theory; media archaeology; the telephone; Alexander Graham Bell; telepathy; Frederic Myers; dissemination; parable of the sower; the phonograph; photography; *Camera Lucida*; *punctum*; Susan Sontag; Pierre Bourdieu; family photography; Avital Ronell; John Durham Peters; Martin Buber; Jean-Louis Chrétien; copywriting; advertising theory; Raymond Williams; Judith Williamson; Seibu Saison group; Seiji Tsutsumi; Saison culture; New Academism; Japanese consumer society; bubble economy; lost decade; *jishuku*; Shōwa era; *furusato*; hyperreality; simulation; Jean Baudrillard; Americana; postwar Japanese imaginary of America; Shun'ya Yoshimi; nostalgia; armchair nostalgia; Arjun Appadurai; narrative consumption; Eiji Ōtsuka; database consumption; Hiroki Azuma; Alexandre Kojève; discovery of landscape; Kōjin Karatani; Ludwig Wittgenstein; Orientalism; Edward Said; Occidentalism; Japanese Orientalism; cultural odorlessness (*mukokuseki*); Koichi Iwabuchi; Robert Sharf; gender and games; damsel in distress; translation studies; Lawrence Venuti; localization studies; fan studies; Henry Jenkins; interpretive communities; overinterpretation; *intentio operis*; Sakutarō Hagiwara; Federico Fellini; *La dolce vita*; money and debt; Georg Simmel; Walter Benjamin; Michael Ende; *Momo*; *The Neverending Story*; Italo Calvino; "Super-Frog Saves Tokyo"; Ray Bradbury; Stephen King; *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial*; *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*; David Lynch; *Twin Peaks*; *Eraserhead*; *Peanuts*; *My Neighbor Totoro*; Kenji Miyazawa; *Night on the Galactic Railroad*; Lewis Carroll; Ursula K. Le Guin; Andrei Tarkovsky; Osamu Tezuka; *Astro Boy*; Katsuhiro Ōtomo; *Akira*; *2001: A Space Odyssey*; *Ghost in the Shell*; *Doraemon*; *Chrono Trigger*; transmedia comparison; Haruki Murakami; *Undertale*; *Deltarune*; OMORI.



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